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PM reviews economic roadmap

India must continue its development agenda despite global challenges

DEEPAK KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

A day after economic growth data for the fiscal year 2026 came out, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday chaired a meeting of the Economic Advisory Council (EAC to PM) to discuss the impact of the West Asia crisis on the Indian economy and ways ahead. Though no specific decision was announced after the meeting, various new reform measures to ease doing business, boost consumption and give relief to people were discussed.

The Prime Minister is understood to have emphasised the need for preparedness in the face of a volatile international environment, stressing that India must continue advancing its development agenda despite global challenges. The discussions centered on safeguarding supply chains,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairing a meeting with the members of the Economic Advisory Council (EAC) to the prime minister in New Delhi

containing inflationary pressures and ensuring that economic growth remains on a stable trajectory. The meeting also reflected the Government's broader approach of combining short-term crisis management with long-term structural reforms.

The members of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) also gave their assessment of the impact of the West Asia conflict on India and the

world. Various reforms to improve ease of living and ease of doing business were also discussed at the high-level meeting, the sources said. "Chaired a meeting of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister. Deliberated on a wide range of issues relating to India's economic transformation and long-term development priorities. Also shared perspectives on adding more momentum to the reforms

journey and ensuring Ease of Living as well as Ease of Doing Business," Modi said in a social media post. The meeting was also attended by two principal secretaries to the Prime Minister — PK Mishra and Shaktikanta Das.

The EAC is an independent body that gives advice to the Government of India, specifically to the Prime Minister, on economic and related issues. Two principal secretaries to the Prime Minister — PK

Mishra and Shaktikanta Das — attended the meeting, besides the members of the EAC. At present, the EAC comprises a chairman, three full-time members and 11 part-time members. S Mahendra Dev is the chairman, while full-time members are Sanjay Kumar Mishra, Sanjeev Sanyal and Shamika Ravi.

There are 11 part-time members: Rakesh Mohan, Sajjid Z Chinoy, Neelkanth Mishra, Nilesh Shah, TT Ram Mohan, Soumya Kanti Ghosh, KV Raju, Chetan Ghate, Pami Dua, Pulak Ghosh and Gaurav Vallabh.

The terms of reference of EAC include analysing any issue, economic or otherwise, referred to it by the Prime Minister, and advising him thereon, addressing issues of macroeconomic importance and presenting views thereon to the PM.

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Delhi to Siliguri in 6 hours: Vaishnaw

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

Unveiling a rail infrastructure blitz in Bengal, Railways Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Saturday announced a bullet train project that would connect Delhi with Siliguri, the gateway to the Northeast. Vaishnaw said it would reduce the travel time to just six hours from the present 20 hours. This will be India's second bullet train project after the 508 km Mumbai-Ahmedabad corridor, which is set to be operational next year.

"A bullet train project will come to West Bengal. It will connect Delhi and Siliguri via Lucknow, Varanasi and Patna," the Union Minister said. Vaishnaw on Saturday said, "In the next five years, 60 next-generation trains will be introduced for Kolkata Metro... This will prove to be very beneficial for Kolkata and its surrounding areas."

The Government had blocked



Union Railways Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw conducts an inspection during his visit to Chingrighata crossing on the Kolkata Metro's Orange line in Kolkata on Saturday

all forms of development. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has plans for Bengal, and that is evident from the ₹14,205 crore allotted for railway projects in the State. Under the UPA Government, Bengal got ₹4,000 crore," Vaishnaw claimed.

He also referred to proposed high-speed rail corridors linking Delhi with Varanasi and Varanasi with Siliguri, saying they would significantly reduce travel time. Referring to the East-West Dedicated Freight Corridor,

the Railway Minister said it would connect West Bengal's Dankuni with Surat in Gujarat and boost industrial and trade movement across several States.

The corridor will benefit States like Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh, he said. The minister said 100 per cent railway electrification had been achieved in the State and assured the people of continued investment in new trains and infrastructure.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

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ARMY OFFICER FALLS TO DEATH IN J&K

An army officer died after slipping in a mountainous area and falling into a deep gorge during an anti-terror operation in Jammu and Kashmir's Rajouri district on Saturday evening, officials said. The officer, a lieutenant, was part of the security forces engaged in Operation Sherwali, which entered its 15th day. Operation Sherwali is underway in the Dorimaal and Gambhir Mughalan belt to track down two to three Pakistani terrorists believed to be hiding in the forests of Rajouri district. During the search operation, the lieutenant reportedly slipped and fell into a 30-metre-deep gorge in the Dorimaal area, the officials said, adding that he succumbed to his injuries. The exercise began on May 22, with troops having a brief exchange of fire with militants the next day. There has been no further contact since. The body has been recovered, and further details are awaited.

CJP protest at Jantar Mantar fizzles out without impact

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

Despite the buzz across India, the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar on Saturday turned out to be just another routine demonstration, a damp squib amid high expectations. Participants held placards and slogans demanding *azadi* and condemning paper leaks, as well as placards criticising the Government and the education minister. Some banners pointed out Prime Minister Narendra Modi's absence from press conferences. In contrast, others questioned the Government's response to the ongoing ethnic violence in Manipur between the Kuki and Meitei communities.

The protest felt like a typical left-wing rally, familiar to Delhi residents, marked by *azadi* slogans commonly chanted by leftist student unions. Even the few genuine students present, hoping their voices would be heard, left disappointed. Attendees sported cockroach masks, carried flowers, and included schoolchildren accompanied by their parents.

Earlier, Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the online movement Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), issued an ultimatum to Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, demanding his resignation



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, its spokesperson Saurav Das, and others, during a protest at Jantar Mantar

by 5 pm and warning of a nationwide mobilisation, including a major protest scheduled for June 13 at the same venue if the minister refuses to step down.

Dipke, the rally's organiser, arrived from the US early on Saturday morning. After obtaining police approval, he reached Jantar Mantar, where supporters had gathered since dawn. He appealed for peaceful conduct, encouraging supporters to bring books and national flags, and to offer flowers to police officers as a sign of compassion and gratitude. Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk joined him, along with leaders from CPI(ML) Liberation, CPI, and various leftist youth and student organisations.

Reflecting on his arrival at Indira Gandhi International Airport, Dipke shared that just before landing, he felt as if he were experiencing his last moments of freedom, ready to sacrifice everything for his cause. He accused many of compromising themselves out of fear of imprisonment. Still, he declared, "*Lekin is desh ka chatra, yuva nahi bika hai*", the youth and students of this country have not sold out, eliciting loud cheers.

Wangchuk praised the youngsters' peaceful protest and expressed hope that future demonstrations would be allowed to flourish. Calling Dipke the "Cockroach-in-Chief," Wangchuk commended the protesters for their resilience, noting they didn't sit at home crying or create chaos on the streets.

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Jaishankar praises resilient India-Nepal ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India and Nepal have a unique opportunity to take their long-standing bilateral partnership to a new level by expanding cooperation into innovation-driven sectors while consolidating gains made in traditional areas of collaboration, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Saturday during talks with Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal in New Delhi.

Addressing the meeting, Jaishankar described India-Nepal ties as one of South Asia's most enduring and resilient relationships,



anchored in deep-rooted social, cultural, economic and historical connections. He noted that the open border between the two countries, vibrant people-to-people exchanges and shared civilisational heritage continue to

serve as the foundation of the partnership. The External Affairs Minister said cooperation between the two neighbours has expanded significantly in recent years across sectors such as trade, investment, energy, education,

infrastructure development, disaster management and cultural exchanges.

However, he stressed that both countries are now well-positioned to explore new opportunities in emerging fields that could define the next phase of bilateral engagement. "India and Nepal have the potential to elevate their partnership by embracing innovation and technology-led growth," Jaishankar said, identifying startups, artificial intelligence, information technology and renewable energy as promising areas for future collaboration.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Coemtp Edutek to continue CBSE work

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Hyderabad-based Coemtp Edutek Private Limited, which has faced criticism over its On-Screen Marking (OSM) system used for re-evaluating Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) Class 12 answer sheets, will continue to handle the process.

However, CBSE has now transferred all relevant data from Coemtp's servers to its own servers as a safeguard against potential data breaches and cyber attacks. Two portals have been used for the evaluation process - a CBSE registration portal and the OSM evaluation



portal. The CBSE registration portal was launched on May 19, but it faced multiple technical glitches that were flagged by students on social media, prompting the board to shut it.

Meanwhile, students have raised issues in accessing their answer books and applying for verification and re-evaluation on the CBSE's

post-result services portal launched on June 2. The board has extended the last date for submission of applications for verification and re-evaluation of Class 12 answer sheets till June 7.

Students are requested to take note of the revised schedule and submit their applications accordingly.

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Federal court blocks US immigration restrictions on nationals of 39 nations

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

A federal judge has struck down a set of immigration restrictions introduced by the Trump administration that affected nationals from 39 countries, ruling that the measures violated US immigration and administrative law. In a landmark decision issued on Friday, Chief US District Judge John McConnell concluded that the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) had improperly suspended or delayed immigration-related benefits for individuals solely because of their nationality.

The ruling is expected to impact thousands of appli-



cants whose cases had remained unresolved under the policy.

The restrictions were introduced after a shooting incident in Washington, DC, last November involving an Afghan national accused of attacking two members of

the National Guard. Following the incident, the administration implemented heightened scrutiny and processing freezes for applicants from a group of countries spanning Africa, Asia, Latin America and the Middle East.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Sooryavanshi becomes youngest India player

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Wonder kid Vaibhav Sooryavanshi found a place in the squad for the twin tour of Ireland and England, said Chief selector Ajit Agarkar.

At 15 years and 71 days old, Sooryavanshi becomes the youngest ever player to feature in an Indian cricket team, surpassing the long-standing record held by the great Sachin Tendulkar.

Tendulkar was 16 years and 205 days when he made his Test debut against Pakistan at Karachi on November 15, 1989.

Family members of India's 15-year-old batting sensation from Bihar, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, expressed delight over his selection in India's T20 squad for Ireland



AT 15 YEARS AND 71 DAYS OLD, SOORYAVANSHI BECOMES THE YOUNGEST EVER PLAYER TO FEATURE IN AN INDIAN CRICKET TEAM

and England on Saturday, asserting that his hard work is bearing fruit now.

"The hard work he put into his game since childhood is bearing fruit now. Getting an

opportunity to play for the country is a huge achievement. My wish stands fulfilled today," Vaibhav's father Sanjeev Sooryavanshi told reporters.

Sooryavanshi's inclusion was a foregone conclusion after the 15-year-old bagged the Orange Cap in IPL 2026, scoring 776 runs with a hundred and five fifties at a strike rate of 237.30 for Rajasthan Royals.

"We have seen what he can do. Even in the (IPL) playoffs, we saw he almost single-handedly carried the Rajasthan Royals (into the final). For a young kid to be batting in a high-pressure environment, he can be a game-changer. It's commendable," said Ajit Agarkar.

RELATED REPORTS ON >> P11

LPG price hiked by ₹29 per 14.2-kg cylinder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Domestic cooking gas LPG price has been raised by ₹29 per cylinder, marking the second increase in three months as State-owned fuel retailers continue to grapple with elevated global energy costs. The price of a 14.2-kg LPG cylinder in Delhi will rise to ₹942 from ₹913 with effect from June 7, according to industry sources.

The increase follows a ₹60-per-cylinder hike on March 7 after the conflict in West Asia disrupted global energy supplies and drove up international fuel prices. Industry



sources said that the increase had only partly offset losses incurred on domestic LPG sales. State-run oil marketing companies were estimated to be losing about ₹703 on every LPG cylinder sold before the latest revision, the sources said.

The LPG price hike comes amid a broader round of fuel price increases. Petrol and diesel prices have been raised by a cumulative ₹7.50 per litre since mid-May, while compressed natural gas (CNG) rates have increased by about ₹6 per kg.

Over 6,000 youngsters participate in MY Bharat Youth Convention

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Over 6,000 youngsters from diverse backgrounds participated in the MY Bharat Youth Convention organised by the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports here on Saturday, interacting with Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, among others.

The 'Youth for Viksit Bharat: MY Bharat Youth Convention' was held at the Thyagaraj Sports Complex in the national capital. It showcased the transformative role of youth in nation-building and India's journey towards becoming a developed nation by 2047.

Eminent personalities, including MLA and singer Maithili Thakur, actor Vikrant Massey, entrepreneur Aman Gupta, and Indian cricketer Jitesh Sharma, interacted with MY Bharat NSS volunteers and shared their experiences, encouraging young people to pursue excellence and contribute meaningfully to national development.

In his address, Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports Dr Mandaviya underscored that India's youth constitute the nation's greatest strength and are central to the realisation of the vision of Viksit Bharat, emphasising India's demographic advantages, social awakening. His legacy reminds us that the protection of rights and the preservation of culture are inseparable," Gupta said.



Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, second left, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, right, singer and BJP MLA Maithili Thakur, left, and others, during the 'Youth for Viksit Bharat – MY Bharat Youth Convention' in New Delhi.

Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, second left, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, right, singer and BJP MLA Maithili Thakur, left, and others, during the 'Youth for Viksit Bharat – MY Bharat Youth Convention' in New Delhi.

Speaker Gupta calls for greater recognition of tribal heritage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Saturday said tribal histories are not peripheral to India's story; they are integral to its civilisational journey.

Speaker Gupta, who was attending a national seminar on 'Bhagwan Shri Birsa Munda' at the India International Centre, called for greater recognition of tribal heritage. "Bhagwan Shri Birsa Munda



occupies a unique and inspiring place in India's history. He was not merely a freedom fighter but a symbol of self-respect, cultural identity and social awakening. His legacy reminds us that the protection of rights and the preservation of culture are inseparable," Gupta said.

preneurs, sportspersons, artists, content creators, UPSC aspirants and other high-achieving youth, the Chief Minister said that the platform was truly a celebration of India's youth power.

Praising the event, the chief minister said that the presence of so many talented young people and inspirational personalities from diverse fields gave the gathering the feel of 'stars on earth'. When young entrepreneurs, athletes, artists, public representatives, content creators and those who have succeeded in highly competitive examinations such as the UPSC come together on one stage, it becomes a powerful reflection of India's diverse talent and limitless potential, she said.

The Chief Minister said the programme was proof that India's youth are fully prepared to shoulder the nation's responsibilities.

CAQM reviews enforcement actions across NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CAQM Enforcement Task Force (ETF) has reviewed reports from 245 inspections and enforcement actions carried out in the National Capital Region area between May 11 and May 29 at its 132nd meeting.

The flying squads carried out 31 inspections across construction and demolition sites, 74 inspections across the industrial sector, and 140 inspections related to diesel generator sets.

A total of 87 violations were reported,



including 21 from construction and demolition sites, 25 from the industrial sector and 41 across diesel generator sets.

"The ETF also reviewed the issue of road dust mitigation and took note of

inspections carried out by the Greater Noida Industrial Development Authority on May 18," an official said on Saturday.

During these inspections, nine areas were examined, and 37 violations were reported. The ETF examined inspections conducted by Municipal Corporation Ghaziabad on May 26, covering four areas where 24 violations were reported.

"Moreover, the Commission for Air Quality Management has emphasised the need for timely submission of inspection reports by flying squad teams along with photographic/video graphic evidence," said the official.

Delhi-Punjab bond rooted in Sikh history: LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday underscored the deep historical and spiritual ties between Delhi and Punjab during his visit to several prominent Sikh shrines in Sri Anandpur Sahib and Kiratpur Sahib.

The LG said the relationship between the national



capital and Punjab is closely linked to the lives and teachings of Guru Arjan Dev Ji, Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji and Guru Gobind Singh Ji, as well as historic Delhi shrines

such as Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib and Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib.

He noted that the bond has been further strengthened by Delhi's large Punjabi and Sikh population, many of whom migrated to the city during Partition and rebuilt their lives through resilience and hard work, contributing significantly to the capital's social and cultural fabric.

Police dismantle inter-state cyber fraud syndicate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Cyber Cell of the Central District has dismantled an inter-state cyber fraud syndicate involved in siphoning funds through unauthorised banking transactions. Three suspects have been taken into custody, and authorities have recovered 28 debit cards, 12 SIM cards, and four mobile phones associated with the operation.

DCP Central district, Rohit Rajbir Singh, said prompt financial trail analysis



enabled the authorities to freeze and secure nearly ₹4 lakh of the ₹4.82 lakh allegedly stolen from a 50-year-old resident of Karol Bagh.

The case surfaced after the victim, a resident of Prem Nagar, received SMS alerts

about unauthorised debits from his bank account. Although his son acted quickly to block the account, the suspects had already transferred ₹4,82,476 through rapid electronic transactions, the DCP said.

Investigators traced the money to a bank account operated by Sonu, 21, of Uttam Nagar. He and his suspected associate, Yash Kumar, 27, also from Uttam Nagar, were arrested on May 27. Their interrogation led to the arrest of Baljinder Singh, alias Mangga, 48, from Haryana's Yamunanagar district on June 3. The syndicate is believed to have operated via a network of mule accounts used for swift fund transfers.

Sonu allegedly provided the bank accounts used to receive cybercrime proceeds, while Yash coordinated the collection and transfer of account credentials. Baljinder is suspected of managing interstate operations, maintaining a stock of debit and SIM cards linked to multiple accounts and overseeing cash withdrawals across states.

Police recovered 28 debit

cards linked to mule accounts, 12 SIM cards used for internet banking and UPI transactions, and four mobile phones containing transaction data and chats purportedly related to the fraud network.

Technical analysis of the seized devices and bank accounts is ongoing to establish connections with other cybercrime cases registered on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal. Efforts are also underway to identify and apprehend additional members of the network.

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यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

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निम्नलिखित भूमि यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा आपसी सहमति के आधार पर काश्तकारों से क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित है। क्रय हेतु काश्तकार, गांठा संख्या, क्षेत्रफल व काश्तकार का हिस्सा निम्नलिखित तालिका में अंकित है:-

औद्योगिक सैक्टर - 08, ग्राम दस्तमपुर, मिल्क करीमाबाद

क्रमांक	ग्राम का नाम	खाता संख्या	खसरा संख्या	खसरे का कुल (हे. में)	खातेदार का नाम व पता	तहसील से प्राप्त रिपोर्ट का आधार पर काश्तकार का हिस्सा (हे. में)	काश्तकार का विक्रय हेतु क्षेत्रफल (हे. में)
1.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	21	33	0.6030	शिवम अग्रवाल पुत्र सजीव अजय कुमार गुप्ता, श्रीमती रमा गुप्ता पत्नी अजय कुमार गुप्ता निवासी-292 पट्टी हुलासराय स्थाना अंसल गार्डन एनक्लेव, गोविन्दपुरम गाजियाबाद	में से	0.1265
2.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	187	24	0.3890	हरेन्द्र सिंह व सतवीर पुत्रगण जगना सिंह निवासी नगला हुकम सिंह माजरा करौली बांगर	में से	0.0835
3.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	149	01	2.1190	उर्मिला गोयल पत्नी राजेन्द्र उर्फ राजेन्द्र कुमार गोयल निवासी हौज खास एनक्लेव साउथ वेस्ट दिल्ली	में से	0.4259
4.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	74	95	0.6770	विष्णु कान्त पुत्र धर्मेन्द्र कुमार	में से	0.0211
5.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	245	99	0.3770	भूपेन्द्र सिंह पुत्र मान सिंह	में से	0.0628 0.0421 0.1049
6.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	74	95	0.6770	सुरेन्द्र प्रताप पुत्र विशम्भर व कृष्ण कुमार पुत्र विशम्भर	में से	0.0211
7.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	32		0.7410	रोहित बंसल पुत्र रामअवतार बंसल निवासी-78 मोहल्ला काजीबाड़ा, जेवर गौतमबुद्धनगर	में से	0.1080
8.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	114	82	2.7420	अरविन्द भारद्वाज पुत्र गंगादत्त निवासी दस्तमपुर	में से	0.1153
9.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	114	82	2.7420	ब्रजेश पुत्र गंगादत्त निवासी दस्तमपुर	में से	0.1153
10.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	114	82	2.7420	बंटी शर्मा पुत्र गंगादत्त उर्फ खिल्लू निवासी दस्तमपुर	में से	0.1153
11.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	114	82	2.7420	हरीश पुत्र गंगादत्त निवासी दस्तमपुर	में से	0.1153
12.	दस्तमपुर (सै.-8)	115	285म	1.2360	रिपुदमन सिंह पुत्र बिजेन्द्र सिंह निवासी ग्राम रुन्हेरा हाल निं० शालीमार बाग दिल्ली	में से	0.0852
13.	मिल्क करीमाबाद (सै०-8)	101 14 100 99	10 13 8/1 7ख	1.2900 1.2490 0.0765 0.7920	अक्षरामा पुत्र देशराज शर्मा व विजय शर्मा पत्नी देशराज शर्मा नि० मयूर विहार पूर्व दिल्ली	में से	0.0860 0.0833 0.0051 0.0107 0.1851
14.	मिल्क करीमाबाद (सै०-8)	86	16	1.1720	धर्मपाल पुत्र रामस्वरूप निवासी मिल्क करीमाबाद	में से	0.0391
15.	मिल्क करीमाबाद (सै०-8)	62	11	2.4910	नरेन्द्र पुत्र नैम सिंह नि० मिल्क करीमाबाद	में से	0.0020
16.	मिल्क करीमाबाद (सै०-8)	86	16	1.1720	मन्जू देवी पत्नी गंगासरन नि० ग्राम	में से	0.1265

उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है, तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिन के अंदर अपर मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण कार्यालय में अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

डिस्ट्री कलेक्टर, यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे प्राधिकरण

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/ हाउसिंग/ कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीद - फरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।

BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES

Sadiq Road, Faridkot-151 203 (Punjab) Phone: 01639-251232

University Institute of Pharmaceutical Sciences & Research

ADMISSION NOTICE (2026-2027)

Online Applications are invited for admission to the following courses from 09.06.2026 onwards.

S. No.	Name of Course	Eligibility	Last Date to apply online
1.	B. Pharm.	10+2 (Sci.)	02-07-2026
2.	B. Pharm. (Pharmaceutics) and M. Pharm. (Pharmaceutical Chemistry)	B. Pharm.	15-07-2026
3.	B. Pharm. (Lateral Entry)	D. Pharm.	To be intimated later on through University website

For further details visit our website: www.bfuis.ggsamch.org

REGISTRAR

3108/12/2026-27/12073 Dated CHD :- 05/06/2026

The South Indian Bank Ltd

Regional Office-Delhi, 3rd Floor, Plot No.21, 21/1, Pusa Road,Karol Bagh, New Delhi - 110005, Phone-011 4233 1664/011 4512 8661 email-ro1008@sib.co.in.

Ref: DEL/CRD/SAR/16/2026-27

Date: 05-06-2026

E - AUCTION SALE NOTICE

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

1. Ms. Shri Gargdas Textile Industries Limited, 7098 Shop no. 1, Jain Market, Guru Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi- 110 031. Also at: F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 010. Also at: Ground & First Floor, Property no. 465, Near Sabzi Mandi, Jheel Khurana, Delhi 110 051

2. M/S GG Fabrics under proprietorship of Mr. Nitin Dawar at F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana Punjab-141 010

3. Mr. Pankaj Ahuja 4181, 04 Duragpuri Haibowal, Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab- 141 001

4. Mrs. Hema Ahuja 4181, 04 Duragpuri Haibowal, Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 001

5. Mr. Rakesh Kumar 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051

6. Mr. Suresh Kumar 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051

7. Mr. Vinay Dawar House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012

8. Mr. Nitin Dawar, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012 (Personal guarantor and legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar).

9. Mrs. Shivani Kochar, 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051, also at, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012 (Legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar)

10. Mrs. Savita Dawar, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012, also at, House 504, Block GX, BRS Nagar Extension, Opposite Verka Milk Plant, Ferozpur Road, Ludhiana-141 012, also at 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower/guarantor/ Legal heirs that the below described immovable properties mortgaged to the South Indian Bank Ltd, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of The South Indian Bank Limited (Secured Creditor), will be sold on "as is where it is" basis, "as is what is" and "whatever there is" condition on 24-06-2026 for recovery of an amount of Rs.16,92,38,143.26/- (Rupees Sixteen Crore Ninety Two Lakh Thirty Eight Thousand One Hundred Forty Three and Twenty Six Paise Only) as on 18-02-2026, with future interest, costs and expenses etc. thereon. Due to The South Indian Bank Limited, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), from the above mentioned Borrower(s) and guarantor(s).

Item No. 1	
Name of Property Owner	Late Mr.Ramesh Kumar(Now represented by legal heirs Mrs. Savita Dawar, Mr. Vinay Dawar,Mr.Nitin Dawar and Mrs.Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar
Description of property	All that Part and Parcel of Freehold Residential Property admeasuring 50 square yards out of area measuring 100 sq. yds. out of total area measuring 218 sq. yds. out of Kharsa no. 464/362 along with Residential Buildings constructed upon it bearing no. MPL 783/18-A/5 (old), New No. IX/7172 along with all other constructions, improvements, Easementary Rights existing and appurtenant thereon situated at Gaur Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Village Seelampur, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi 110 031 owned by Late Ramesh Kumar Dawar (since expired and represented by his legal heirs; Mrs. Savita Dawar , Mr. Vinay Dawar,Mr.Nitin Dawar and Mrs.Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar more particularly described under Sale Deed No. 1287 dated 09-05-1989 at SRO -IV, New Delhi/Delhi and With dated 02-06-1997 located on North by Common Passage, South by Other's property, East by Common wall & Shop No.7 and West by common wall and shop No.5
Reserve Price (item No.1)	Rs 1,44,50,000/- (Rupees One Crore Forty Four Lakh Fifty Thousand Only)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (item No.1)	Rs. 14,45,000/- (Rupees Fourteen Lakhs Forty Five Thousand Only) EMD shall be deposited on or before 23.06.2026 till 02.00 PM
Bid Increment amount (item No.1)	Rs. 10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand Only)
Date and time of E-auction (item No.1)	24.06.2026 from 11:00 AM to 11:30 AM (with 5 minute unlimited auto extensions till sale is concluded)
Encumbrances known to the Bank (Item No.1)	Nil/ Encumbrances from 01.01.2018 to 22.11.2022

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in web portal of South Indian Bank Ltd. (Secured Creditor) website i.e. www.southindianbank.com. Details also available at banksauctions.in.

For any further clarification with regards to inspection of property, terms and conditions of the e-auction or submission of bids, kindly contact South Indian Bank Ltd on 9818-772-322 / 7309-655-552 / 9007-046-006 (contact number).

Sd/- AUTHORISED OFFICER

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified that I, NAVODYA GHAI S/o SH. RAMMY GHAI, R/o 253/C, DOONGAR MOHALLA, FARSH BAZAR, SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032, intend to purchase a Property Bearing No. 80, Measuring Area 200 Sq. Yds. Situated in the Layout Plan of the Hargobind Co-Operative House Building Society Ltd. Colony Known as HAROBIND ENCLAVE, Delhi-110032 from:(i) IMRAN LATIF S/o LATE ABDUL LATIF(ii) ZISHAN LATIF S/o LATE ABDUL LATIFBoth R/o E-17, NIZAMUDDIN WEST, DELHI-110013 who represent himself absolute owners of the property,It is therefore, Notified that anybody claiming any rights, title, interest, share or lien over the aforesaid property may file such claim or objection to the undersigned within a period of 03 days from the date of Publication of this notice. Otherwise, it will be presumed that the said property is free from all encumbrances, charges and/or lien, etc. and I am free to purchase the said property from the above named seller.

NAVODYA GHAI

PUBLIC NOTICE

Ms. Shweta Sharma has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Rohini, Delhi. (Bank) to avail a Loan against mortgage of Apartment No. MGH1/06-2804, 28th Floor, (2090 sq. fts.), Tower-06, M3M Golf Hills Phase-1, Village Naurangpur, Sector-79-79b, Gurugram, Haryana and has represented that she is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Agreement for Sale dated 03.06.2025 (Doc. No. 3142) executed by M/s Loon Land Development Ltd. Original Allotment Letter dated 01.03.2024 has been misplaced/lost and FIR bearing LR no. 323845/2026 dated 24.05.2026 has been lodged with P.S. Bhajanpur, District North East/Crime Branch, Delhi. If anybody, person, body corporate is in possession of the said lost Allotment Letter or have found or finds in future, then he/she/it should return the same to the undersigned. General Public is cautioned not to deal on behalf or basis of the said Lost Allotment Letter. Any use of the said deed without knowledge/ consent by anybody other than Original owner shall be illegal & void and such person would do so at his/ her own risk and responsibility. Bank/ Owner shall not be liable in any manner whatsoever for any loss incurred by such person(s) on account of such unauthorized use of the lost document.

Amit Kumar, Advocate

Narang & Associates

D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.

SHORT e-PROCUREMENT NOTICE: GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER PHE (WATER), ASSAM HENGABARI, GUWAHATI-781036

SHORT e-PROCUREMENT NOTICE / EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) No. 03 of 2026-27

Expression of Interests are invited online from eligible agencies for "ADDITIONAL EMPANELMENT OF AGENCIES UNDER FRAMEWORK AGREEMENT METHOD FOR PROVISIONING OF WATER AND SANITATION FACILITIES AT DIFFERENT EVENTS IN KAMRUP METRO DISTRICT UNDER PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT ASSAM". An amount of Rs 40,000.00 (Rupees Forty Thousand only) is to be submitted Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) / Bid Security. The tender documents can be downloaded from www.asamtenders.gov.in on 08.06.2026 (10:00 hours).

a) A pre-bid meeting is scheduled on 15.06.2026 at 16:00 hours. Address for the meeting is O/o the Chief Engineer (PHE) Water Assam, Hengrabari. Guwahati-36. The bidders shall e-mail their queries to etendersphe@gmail.com on or before 16:00 Hrs. of 15.06.2026.

b) The last date of submission of tender document is 24.06.2026 at 16:00 hrs.

c) The bid will be opened online on the e-procurement portal on 25.06.2026 at 15:00 Hr.

The tender inviting authority reserves the right to accept or reject any bid/ tender, and to cancel/ annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to contract award.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer (PHE). Water. Assam.

Hengrabari. Guwahati - 36.

DIPR/C/PIO/80/7-Jun-26

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Ishvar Singh Chaprana , S/O Jagvir Singh, R/o 273, Balla Mandiya, Sector-31, Site 4, Kasana, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Greater Noida , U.P.- 201310 Do hereby Solemnly declare That Ishvar Singh Chaprana and Ishvar Singh both are the same person. In Future my Self Know as Ishvar Singh Chaprana for all Future Purposes.

SVM INFRAESTATE LIMITED

CIN: U45400UP2011PLC043395

Notice is hereby given pursuant to Section 12(5) of the Companies Act, 2013 that the Members of the Company at their EGM held on 30.05.2026 approved shifting of the Registered Office from Flat No. 5, A-Square Mall, Sector-73, Sarafabad, Noida-201301, U.P. to Unit No. T3A-816, Tower NX-BYTE (T3) NX One, Plot No. 17, Tezhzone-4, Greater Noida (West)-201306, U.P.

For SVM Infraestate Limited

Sd/-

Mradul Kumar Garg

Managing Director, DIN: 03353247

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Deepak Gupta has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., DCM Building, New Delhi. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Industrial Property No. Y-13/1, (125 sq. yds.), Block-Y, in the layout plan of Ware Housing Scheme (WHS), Loha Mandi, Naraina, New Delhi-110028 from Mrs. Savinder Kaur alias Savinder Kaur Chugh who has represented that she is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 30.10.2025 (Doc. No. 2025/8/1/6909) executed by Mr. Avinash Mehdiratta. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate

Narang & Associates D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, Anil Garg, S/o Late A.P. Garg & Sadhna Garg W/o Anil Garg both R/o Flat No. 6172, Alok Vihar-2, Sec-50, Noida has disowned their son named Ankit Garg, his wife Renu Garg @ Renu Pradhan and his son Reyansh Garg from the all movable & immovable properties, assets and bank accounts. And severed all their relationship with them, and will not be responsible for their any acts and deeds, debts loan, liabilities, or legal matters from today onwards.

Anil Garg & Sadhna Garg

Dated: 06.06.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Home Finance Company Ltd. that Mrs. Shilpi Panigrahi, Mrs. Asim Panigrahi, Mr. Arth Panigrahi are jointly to be claiming owners of 1/5 share in Unit, on Second Floor, having covered area 650 sq. ft. (Front Side Side Split flat), property No. 06, Killa No. 24 and 114/2 Min, Situated at Indraprastha Colony, Sector-30/33, Faridabad, Haryana, after demise of late Mr. R.K. Panigrahi, deceased. Shilpi Panigrahi is owner of remaining 1/5 share vide a sale deed dated 01.02.2005. Registration No. 9867. All Persons are hereby informed that above owners want to sale the said unit to Mr. M. M. Joshi or his nominee who is taking a loan facility from ICICI Home Finance Ltd. the said unit. If anybody has any objection/s upon the ownership of above owner with respect of the said property its title its said mortgage, and any other kind of objection/ litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing to the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present notice.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)

200, 1st Floor Rajendra Mohi Nagar, N.Delhi-15

legals@kmalga.com Ph: 911-4111227-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Mohd. Mubeen S/o Mohd. Rafiq R/o E-2/1008, Gali No.17, Nehru Vihar, Mustafabad, Delhi-110094 has severed all relations with his son Faiz Malik, due to his conduct and activities being against family norms as he is beyond the control of my client. My client has debarred him from his movable and immovable properties and he has no right, title or interest in the properties of my client. Neither my client nor his family members shall be responsible for any of his personal acts and deeds. Anyone dealing with him will do so entirely at their own risk and responsibility.

Mohd. Mobin (Advocate)

Ch. No. C-158, C1, Joseph Block, Near Gate No. 5, Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client, Smt. Prem Lata W/o Late Sh. Rajendra Yadav, S-59, New Chandrawal Jawahar Nagar, Malka Garg S.O, North Delhi, Delhi-110007 My client due to disrespectful and uncontrollable behavior of her son named Sh. Mayaur Yadav and his wife Smt. Neetu Yadav debar them from her all movable and immovable properties from this date on present public notice in future my aforesaid client shall not be responsible for any public transaction done by her son Sh. Mayaur Yadav and his wife Neetu Yadav on behalf of my above named client.

Rohit Manchanda (Advocate) Enroll. No. D/6897/2021

Off: 106, 1st Floor Rajendra Mohi Nagar, N.Delhi-15

Tis Hazari Court, Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, Anil Garg, S/o Late A.P. Garg & Sadhna Garg W/o Anil Garg both R/o Flat No. 6172, Alok Vihar-2, Sec-50, Noida has disowned their son named Ankit Garg, his wife Renu Garg @ Renu Pradhan and his son Reyansh Garg from the all movable & immovable properties, assets and bank accounts. And severed all their relationship with them, and will not be responsible for their any acts and deeds, debts loan, liabilities, or legal matters from today onwards.

Anil Garg & Sadhna Garg

Dated: 06.06.2026

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, GAYTRI GOYAL W/o Sh. Bhagwan Das Goyal, R/o J-281/16D, Street No-2, 3/1-2 Pusta, Kartar Nagar, Garhi Mendu, Delhi-110053, have changed my name from GAYATRI DEVI @ GAYTRI DEVI to GAYTRI GOYAL vide affidavit dated 22.05.2026. Both names refer to one and the same person. Henceforth, I shall be known as GAYTRI GOYAL for all purposes.

PD(1287)/C

I, ROHIT PANJIRATNA S/O, SHRI VED PRAKASH, resident of TOWER CGI FLAT NO 1105 SUPRETECH CAPETOWN SECTOR 74 NOIDA Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh 201301 doherby declare that I have changed my name from ROHIT PANJIRATNA to ROHIT PANJIRATAN and henceforth I shall be known as ROHIT PANJIRATAN in all purpose.

PD(1288)/C

Government explores third-party insurance for buildings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After the devastating fire at the Flourish Stays Bed and Breakfast in Malviya Nagar, the Delhi Government is exploring the possibility of developing a third-party insurance framework for buildings. According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the government is not limiting itself to enforcement action but is also working in action mode on long-term solutions to the problem.

In a statement issued by the chief minister's office, the chief minister has directed officials to explore the possibility of developing a third-party insurance system for buildings, guest houses, nursing homes, and other

public-use structures that witness large public footfall.

She said insurance companies would provide coverage only if structural safety and all required safety standards are complied with. This would create additional pressure on building owners to adhere to safety regulations and help strengthen public safety. She also said directions have been issued to develop a digital tracking system to make the Fire Department's response process fully transparent.

As per the data shared by the Delhi government, its Revenue Department has inspected 124 properties and took action wherever violations were found. Similarly, during the last six days, the Municipal Corporation of

Delhi (MCD) carried out demolition action against 94 properties and sealed 114 properties. In addition, the DDA has been directed to further strengthen its enforcement mechanism against encroachments and illegal constructions.

The revenue department has issued notices to violators after inspections at 10 sites in North District. Notices were also issued following inspections at 10 sites in East District, 21 in West District, 13 in South-West District, and 10 in Central District (North). During inspections of 30 sites in South District, 11 premises were sealed, and show-cause notices were issued in 19 cases. In the North-West District, three unauthorised



buildings were demolished for violating building by-laws. Sealing notices were issued in New Delhi District, while closure notices were issued in Central District. In Old Delhi District, a No

Objection Certificate (NOC) from the Fire Department was found to be available, but since the building approval plan was not available, the matter was referred to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi for necessary action. No violations were found during inspections in the South-East District.

The MCD has carried out demolition action against 94 properties between June 1 and June 6, while 114 properties were sealed.

In addition, 84 show-cause notices were issued in cases of unauthorised construction, sealing notices were sent to 41 properties, and 33 demolition orders were issued. During the drive, the MCD accelerated both legal and physical action against illegal constructions.

The department not only removed unauthorised structures but also continued the process of issuing notices and orders to prevent such activities in

the future. Further, since June 1, a total of 41 demolition and sealing actions were carried out in the Said-ul-Azaib, Hauz Rani and Khirki Extension, Savitri Nagar, Sainik Farms, Khanpur and Gautam Nagar areas. MCD also issued 158 unauthorised construction notices, sealing notices and demolition orders against properties for misuse of property and violation of building by-laws in all the zones since June 1.

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) vice chairman also held a review meeting, and it has decided to launch a special drive to identify buildings where large-scale deviations from approved building plans have been found.

It was also decided that if serious violations of approved building plans are detected, strict action will be taken as per rules, including removing the concerned architect from the panel and blacklisting them with immediate effect.

"Acting on the strict directions of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the Delhi Government is enforcing its zero-tolerance policy against illegal construction and encroachment with full rigour. Various agencies are carrying out extensive enforcement measures, including demolition of illegal properties, sealing of premises, and issuance of show-cause notices on a large scale," the CMO's statement said.

Six detained to prevent clash during Cockroach Janta Party protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police and paramilitary forces have been deployed across key locations in the national Capital on Saturday as members of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) began their protest at Jantar Mantar, officials said.

According to police, six people were detained by the Delhi Police on Saturday to prevent a possible confrontation between two groups during the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar.

The detentions were made as a precautionary measure to maintain law and order after police received inputs about the possibility of tensions between supporters and opposers of the online movement, they said.

Officials noted that the preventive detentions were made to help ensure the demonstration concluded peacefully without any major



Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) supporters raise slogans during a protest demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged examination-related lapses at the Jantar Mantar

PTI

law-and-order issues.

The protest, led by CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, prompted heightened security arrangements across central Delhi, the Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport, major railway stations, inter-state bus terminals and border entry points

connecting the city with neighbouring states.

Around 40 companies of paramilitary forces have been deployed to assist the Delhi Police in maintaining law and order, sources said. Senior officers, including Joint Commissioners of Police,

Deputy Commissioners of Police, Additional DCPs and ACPs from various districts, have been assigned field duties to supervise security arrangements.

Multiple layers of barricading were put in place at sensitive locations, while vehicle-checking drives were

intensified on routes leading to central Delhi and other strategic points in the city.

Officials said that security was also strengthened outside the residence of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan as a precautionary measure.

According to police sources, senior officers reviewed the security situation and directed field units to remain vigilant. Reserve forces have been kept on standby to deal with any contingency.

The Special Branch is monitoring developments across all districts to ensure that no one attempts to disturb public order under the guise of the protest, officials said. Social media activity linked to the gathering is also being closely monitored.

Police are also in touch with private cab aggregators to assess movement patterns and monitor any unusual surge in bookings towards Jantar Mantar and

nearby areas, sources said. Dipke proceeded directly to Jantar Mantar after he landed in Delhi instead of going to the Parliament Street Police Station. The CJP had appealed to its supporters to assemble at the designated protest site.

Officials informed that metro services would continue to operate normally, while adequate arrangements had been made to ensure smooth movement of commuters and prevent any disruption to public life.

Police maintained that sufficient security arrangements were in place and that the situation remained under control.

Originally launched as a satirical response to remarks made by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant during a court hearing last month, the Cockroach Janta Party has evolved into an organised online campaign that has attracted a sizeable following on social media.

Hotel fire: 5 successfully taken off ventilator



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Five patients injured in the Delhi hotel fire and undergoing treatment at Max Hospital's Saket complex were successfully taken off ventilator support on Saturday, while one patient remains on life support, the hospital said.

According to the hospital, all five patients who were weaned off ventilators are stable and showing signs of improvement.

A total of 15 patients are currently admitted at the hospital, including 13 international patients affected by the fire incident in Delhi's Malviya Nagar. The hospital said 14 patients are undergoing treatment, and the condition of all of them remains stable.

All patients are recovering well and continue to receive comprehensive medical care, close monitoring and multidisciplinary support to ensure the best possible outcomes, the hospital said.

DELHI HOTEL FIRE

Court sends cook to 2 days police custody



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has remanded the cook of a hotel in Malviya Nagar, which was destroyed by a fire resulting in twenty-one fatalities, to two days of police custody.

The investigation into potential negligence and serious safety violations at the establishment is ongoing. Judicial Magistrate Bhanu Pratap Singh approved the Delhi Police's request to retain Keshav Negi, the cook at Flourish Stays Bed and Breakfast in Hauz Rani, who was detained earlier in the day. Authorities suggest that Negi's apparent neglect may have contributed to the fire that occurred on Wednesday morning.

The detention follows recent arrests of hotel owner Lavkesh Bajaj, who faces charges including culpable homicide not amounting to murder. Several other individuals associated with the hotel have also been detained and

questioned. Additionally, police are actively searching for Jay Mishra, an accountant and close associate of Bajaj, who has been on the run since the incident. Multiple investigative teams, including a unit sent to Bihar, are working to locate him and establish accountability.

Investigators have revealed that the hotel operated twenty-eight rooms despite having approval for only six. The FIR identifies multiple deficiencies in fire safety measures and ventilation. Authorities also confirmed that the building lacked a fire no-objection certificate.

The police are examining whether factors such as neglect, unauthorised structural modifications, and violations of fire safety regulations contributed to the high number of casualties. It was noted that the basement entrance was locked during rescue efforts, which necessitated firefighters to force open the door.

14 cyber criminals arrested as police bust seven inter-state fraud rings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central District Cyber Police Station of Delhi Police arrested 14 alleged "high-profile" cyber criminals and dismantled seven significant inter-state fraud syndicates involved in scams exceeding ₹2 crore during a month-long crackdown in May 2026, officials reported on Saturday.

The suspects, detained from Rajasthan, Punjab, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh, are accused of operating various cyber fraud schemes, including fake government web-

sites, algorithm-driven trading scams, work-from-home frauds, malicious mobile applications, and online spiritual healing operations.

Police stated that the operation resulted in the seizure of two luxury vehicles, 43 mobile phones, 11 laptops and CPUs, a cryptocurrency hardware wallet, debit cards, SIM cards, and other digital evidence. Authorities have also commenced proceedings under Section 107 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS) to attach properties allegedly acquired through proceeds of crime.

A breakthrough involved



busting an alleged algorithmic trading scam that created a transaction trail of nearly ₹2 crore. The fraudsters reportedly lured victims via WhatsApp to download a fake trading app called

"Trademakeralgo", which displayed fabricated profits to entice larger investments. Police arrested three suspects, including an IT engineer earning approximately Rs 30 lakh per year, and

traced 14,232 fraudulent transactions linked to 636 victims nationwide.

In another case, cyber investigators apprehended an MCA graduate from Uttar Pradesh for allegedly operating a fake transport services portal, "parivahan.online", designed to imitate official government websites and collect payments from unsuspecting users.

Police also dismantled a counterfeit "spiritual healer" network allegedly using fabricated female social media profiles to promote an "all-problems solution" guru. The group is accused of exploiting

individuals facing personal crises and extracting money for rituals, poojas, and tantra services. Investigators recovered chat records involving over 2,000 victims.

Another operation led to the arrest of a suspected malware developer who allegedly sold malicious Android application packages (APKs) via Telegram under the pseudonym "Jamtara Official Developer." Victims were duped into installing fake customer support apps, allowing fraudsters to gain remote access to their phones and drain their bank accounts.

PWD decides to bring down all 500 national flags after damage complaints

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After getting several complaints of damage, the Public Works Department has decided to bring down all 500 national flags across Delhi. The PWD has hoisted large national flags at around 500 prime locations in Delhi, but due to bad weather, including strong winds in the past few days, several of these were damaged.

"We will re-hoist the flags after the thunderstorm warning of IDM is cleared. Due to strong winds and bad weather, several flags were torn and damaged, so we



have decided to bring all of them down across the city to prevent further damage," a PWD officer said.

According to an official, these 115-foot-high flagpoles have been installed at around 500 locations. The flags are made out of polyester material to prevent them from frequent damage. However, they could not withstand strong winds.

The work of installing

national flags started in 2022 when the previous AAP government, under its 'Deshbhakti' budget, announced the initiative to cover the entire city with tricolour to generate a sense of nationalism. "Our teams are on the ground checking if any flag is damaged. We will replace them with undamaged flags, as these are big flags. It is taking some time," another official said.

While installing these flags, the department has taken into cognisance the 2002 Flag Code of India rules that pertain to the laws and practices around the display of the national flag.

HC refuses to order re-polling for Bar Council of Delhi elections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Saturday refused to direct re-polling for the Bar Council of Delhi elections, stating that the electoral process was not vitiated by the alleged manipulation of ballot papers.

Several lawyers had filed petitions seeking re-polling on the grounds that an admitted instance of ballot-tampering by a member of the counting staff on April 15 had invalidated the entire election.

Ordering the recommencement of vote count-



ing, a bench of justices Anil Kshetarpal and Tejas Karia observed that a fresh poll was not warranted because the manipulated ballot papers had been identified during the counting process, which must now be dealt according to the BCD rules and the BCI guidelines.

The court stated that

ballot papers bearing "erasures, overwriting, corrections, additions, or other suspicious variations" shall be segregated, kept in sealed bundles or packets marked as 'doubtful ballots', and be placed before the Additional Solicitor General in the special committee constituted to conduct the elections, who shall decide how they are to be counted and record brief reasons.

"This procedure shall ensure that effect is given to the voter's intention without causing prejudice to any candidate," the court said.

Delhi world's second-richest capital for avian diversity, hosts 471 bird species

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi is the world's second-richest capital for avian diversity after Nairobi, hosting 471 bird species, according to the city's first comprehensive Delhi Bird Atlas.

Of the total 221 species documented during the first year of surveys, 108 species (48.87 per cent) were classified as invertebrate feeders, 37 species (16.74 per cent) as plant and seed feeders, 34 species (15.38 per cent) as omnivores, 33 species (14.93 per cent) as vertebrate and

carrion feeders, and nine species (4.07 per cent) as fruit and nectar feeders.

The atlas was prepared by the Delhi Forest Department in collaboration with Bird Count India as a city-wide citizen science initiative to systematically map the distribution and abundance of bird species across the city.

Unlike one-off bird counts, the Atlas follows a seasonal, grid-based methodology that enables researchers to track temporal trends, habitat-level changes, and migratory patterns with greater resolution.

The report presents findings from the first year of a two-year survey exercise that began in January 2025, officials said.

Under the project, Delhi was divided into grids measuring 6.6 km by 6.6 km, with 145 randomly selected sub-cells covering around 11 per cent of the city's area.

Teams of two to five bird-watchers conducted standardised surveys on foot during winter and summer seasons to document resident and migratory species. Invertebrate-feeding birds constituted nearly half of the



total assemblage, while fruit and nectar feeders represented the smallest proportion.

The atlas also recorded

the presence of several species of conservation concern, including the endangered black-bellied tern and

near-threatened species such as the Asian woolly-necked stork, painted stork, black-headed ibis and oriental darter.

"This data will help researchers and urban planners better understand biodiversity and make informed decisions for conservation and urban development," said Pankaj Gupta, State Coordinator, Bird Count India.

According to the atlas, Delhi's location at the northern edge of the Aravalli Hills, the Yamuna and Sahibi floodplains, and its position along the Central Asian Flyway help

sustain one of the richest bird assemblages among world capitals.

The atlas describes itself as a long-term effort to create a scientific baseline for monitoring bird populations, assessing habitat health and tracking ecological changes across the city. The data generated through the exercise is expected to support conservation planning, habitat restoration and sustainable urban development.

The survey will continue through its second year, with future findings expected to provide a more comprehen-

sive picture of species distribution across the capital, officials added.

The Delhi Bird Atlas covers 11% of the area of Delhi. The city limits have been divided into cells (grids) measuring 6.6 km × 6.6 km. Each cell (grid) is further subdivided into four quadrants of 3.3 km × 3.3 km, and each quadrant is broken down into nine subcells of 1.1 km × 1.1 km. In total, 145 subcells have been randomly chosen, providing a scientifically robust and spatially balanced representation of bird diversity across Delhi.



IN FOCUS



A battery-operated vehicle carries garbage at the Taj Mahal in Agra, Uttar Pradesh on Saturday

PTI

Abhishek in Delhi amid buzz over revolt in TMC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee travelled to Delhi on Saturday as the party leadership grappled with growing indications that the rebellion which cost it control of its legislature wing in the West Bengal Assembly could spread to Parliament. The visit, which came a day before Mamata Banerjee's scheduled trip to the national capital for the INDIA bloc meeting, has triggered speculation within party circles amid reports of efforts to engineer a split in the TMC's parliamentary ranks.

According to the original schedule, Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek were expected to travel to Delhi together on Sunday for the opposition INDIA bloc's meeting.

While the official reason for advancing the visit



remains unclear, the development has triggered intense political chatter, with leaders and observers viewing it as a possible attempt by the TMC leadership to take stock of the situation before Monday's meeting.

Sources in the TMC said the party supremo herself asked her nephew to leave a day early. Party leaders, however, appeared uncertain about his engagements

in Delhi on Sunday. "I don't know why Abhishek is going to Delhi today. I am not in Delhi or Kolkata now. I haven't heard about any meeting," a TMC MP, who did not wish to be named, said when asked about the visit. The uncertainty surrounding the trip has coincided with growing reports of efforts by dissident TMC leaders and MPs to replicate in Parliament what has already happened in the

Assembly. Only a few days ago, more than two-thirds of TMC MLAs, 58 of the 80 legislators, broke away from the party's official legislative wing and secured recognition as the principal opposition bloc under expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee, dealing one of the biggest organisational setbacks to Mamata Banerjee since she founded the party in 1998. The rebellion, directed largely against Abhishek's growing influence in the organisation, was informally christened "Operation Crown Prince" by dissident leaders.

Now, political circles in both Kolkata and Delhi are abuzz with talk of another possible operation aimed at triggering a similar rupture within the party's parliamentary ranks.

"I think a similar development is happening in New Delhi in the parliamentary

party. This is happening because of the high-handedness of Abhishek Banerjee," Rebel TMC MLA and deputy leader of the party's new legislative wing Sandipan Saha said. The TMC currently has 28 members in the Lok Sabha after the death of Basirhat MP Haji Nurul Islam. Under anti-defection provisions, a group would require the support of at least two-thirds of the parliamentary party -- 19 MPs -- to stake claim to a separate formation without attracting disqualification. The party has 13 MPs in the Rajya Sabha. Sources familiar with the developments claimed efforts were underway to mobilise support among MPs in both Houses of Parliament.

Several party leaders said telephonic outreach to MPs intensified from Friday night and continued through Saturday, adding to

speculation that rival camps were engaged in a contest for numbers.

A senior TMC leader acknowledged that concerns within the party could not be dismissed outright.

"The Assembly developments have naturally created apprehensions. Everyone is now keeping a watch on developments in Delhi," he said. At the same time, leaders close to Mamata Banerjee maintained that reports of an imminent split were exaggerated and argued that many MPs remained firmly with the party leadership.

The possibility of unrest in Parliament was first flagged publicly by veteran Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Sekhar Roy. "I have never seen around 60 MLAs leave in such a short span of time. A similar reaction is likely in the Lok Sabha too," Roy had said recently.

Delhi CM inaugurates Coforge Public Library in Vasant Kunj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A strong reading culture nurtures informed minds, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said while inaugurating a Coforge Public Library in Vasant Kunj in south Delhi.

The library is the Coforge company's flagship Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative and this is the fourth such facility in India after Noida, Gurugram and Hyderabad. "This magnificent space is far more than just a building; it is a gateway to knowledge, equality, and opportunity. It represents a profound understanding that true progress lies in empowering minds. We highly commend Coforge for recognising the transformative power of books," the chief minister said at the event.

"I offer my warmest congratulations and best wishes to the entire Coforge family. May this grand initiative inspire many more such



sanctuaries of knowledge across Delhi and the rest of India, opening new doors of growth for every citizen," she added.

Anuradha Sehgal, Chief Brand and Sustainability Officer of Coforge, said, "All Coforge Public Library locations are selected with a clear social objective, to serve dense population clusters, including underserved communities where access to quality reading infrastructure is limited."

The library in Vasant Kunj will be a shared space for the entire community in and around Vasant Kunj, Sehgal added.

Entry and reading are completely free, and visitors may also borrow books by paying a fully refundable deposit. No deposit is taken from students of government schools.

Located on the first floor of Vasant Square Mall, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi, the library has a seating capacity of 170 people.

Nehru Planetarium to host sky-watching session as Venus, Jupiter align on June 9

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On June 9, Venus and Jupiter will appear remarkably close to each other in the sky -- a striking celestial event known as a planetary conjunction, and Nehru Planetarium will host a special sky-watching session late evening in the front lawns of Teen Murti Bhawan here, officials said on Saturday.

Jupiter takes nearly 12 years to complete one orbit around the Sun, whereas Venus completes its orbit in about 224 days. Consequently, conjunctions between these two planets occur approximately every 10 to 15 months, the planetarium, under the Prime Ministers' Museum and Library (PMML) in Delhi, said in a statement.

The previous Venus-Jupiter conjunction was observed on August 12, 2025. While conjunctions



between Venus and Jupiter are not uncommon, they remain "among the most spectacular naked-eye astronomical events," it said. This celestial rendezvous of planets will be easily visible to the naked eye throughout India, although binoculars or a telescope may offer an even more impressive view, the officials said.

To celebrate this celestial event, Nehru Planetarium in Delhi will organise a free

public sky-watching session on the front lawns of Teen Murti Bhawan from 7:30 PM onwards, the statement said.

"The conjunction will be visible until approximately 8:30 PM, subject to weather and sky conditions. Astronomy enthusiasts are invited to join this special observation session," it said.

The two brightest planets visible from Earth -- Venus and Jupiter -- will appear

remarkably close to each other in this striking celestial event.

"Although Jupiter is at a distance of 900 million km from Earth and Venus at 180 million km, the two planets appear side by side in the sky due to their alignment along our line of sight. At their closest approach, they will be separated by an angular distance of 1.5 degrees which is roughly equal to the width of a little finger held at arm's length," the statement said.

Both Venus and Jupiter are currently visible in the evening sky. In the coming days, Venus will appear progressively higher above the western horizon, while Jupiter will gradually descend toward the Sun, the planetarium said.

On June 9, their apparent paths will bring them extremely close together, creating a beautiful and memorable sight for observers, it said.

Captain Amarinder meets Shah, Nadda; says discussed various issues concerning Punjab

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Days after he expressed reservations over the appointment of its Punjab unit chief, BJP leader Amarinder Singh on Saturday met Union Home Minister Amit Shah and discussed various issues concerning the State. Singh also met Union Health Minister J P Nadda and the two leaders discussed many political issues including Punjab.

The buzz about 84-year-old Singh, who quit the Congress in 2021, being not happy had grown after he raised questions on the appointment of



Kewal Singh Dhillon as Punjab BJP chief, saying he was not consulted.

After the meetings, Singh wrote on X, "Had a meeting with Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah Ji today in New

Delhi and discussed various issues concerning Punjab."

In another post, he said, "Met Union Minister of Health and Family Welfare Shri JP Nadda Ji in New Delhi today and discussed various issues

concerning Punjab."

Singh also shared photos of his meetings with the two leaders. Nadda, a former BJP national president, said he and Singh discussed many political issues including Punjab. "Met senior BJP leader and former Punjab Chief Minister @capt. amarinder ji in New Delhi today. We discussed many Political issues including Punjab," Nadda said in a post on X. Singh has been mincing no words in expressing his reservation to 76-year-old Dhillon being handed over reins of Punjab BJP months before the 2027 assembly polls.

Ram Temple in Ayodhya, result of double-engine Govt: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gonda

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday cited the construction of the grand Ram temple in Ayodhya as a "power of the double-engine government", and asserted that today a 'Ramdrohi' (traitor of Lord Ram) cannot even enter Ayodhya. "If you want to witness the power of a 'double-engine' govt. The grand temple of Maryada Purushottam Lord Shri Ram in Ayodhya was constructed. A feat was achieved that



had never happened in 500 years," Adityanath said while addressing an event in Gonda. On January 22, 2024, the new Ram Lalla idol was consecrated at the newly constructed temple in Ayodhya amid grand celebrations in the town, with Prime Minister Narendra

Modi participating in rituals.

Adityanath added that the generation over the age of 40 participated in the Ram Temple movement and also experienced the atrocities committed by the governments of that time during the course of the campaign to build the temple. "Back then, there was a ban on even uttering the name of Ram. Batons were charged and bullets were fired. A devotee of Lord Ram could not even enter Ayodhya... Now, barring a devotee of Lord Ram, a 'Ramdrohi' cannot even enter Ayodhya," the CM said.

PM reviews economic roadmap

These could be either suo-motu or on reference from the Prime Minister or anyone else. They also include attending to any other task as may be desired by the PM from time to time.

The meeting took place amid better-than-expected growth prints for 2026, announced on Friday. During the January-March quarter (Q4) of 2026, the real Gross Domestic Product (GDP) grew by 7.8 per cent year-on-year, while full-year growth is pegged at 7.7 per cent. Real GDP at constant prices is estimated at 787.77 lakh crore in Q4 FY26, up from 781.40 lakh crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal. Nominal GDP for the quarter is estimated at 794.65 lakh crore, registering a growth of 9.1 per cent.

Delhi to Siliguri in 6 hours: Vaishnaw

Vaishnaw added that inputs from legislators had been compiled into a booklet for planning future railway works in the State.

In the evening, while inspecting the Metro project site at Chingrighata, the Union Minister repeated those assurances. He said the work had remained stuck due to administrative hurdles, but it was completed within five days after the BJP Government in the State granted the clearances. The minister, who is on his first visit to the State since the change of guard in West Bengal, reviewed the progress of the Metro project and said delays in such infrastructure works had adversely affected commuters. "Metro is

extremely important for the people of Kolkata. Despite that, the previous TMC Government had kept the Metro work stalled. Development was being held back," Vaishnaw said.

Coempt Edutek to continue CBSE work

The CBSE has been in a soup after some Class 12 students claimed that the scanned copies of their answer sheets uploaded by the board did not match their handwriting, raising questions about potential mismatches in the OSM system.

Amidst all this, CBSE chairman Rahul Singh and Secretary Himanshu Gupta were ousted from the national educational board on Thursday. The Centre formed a one-member committee to probe the procurement of services for the OSM system by the educational board.

Jaishankar praises resilient India-Nepal...

He also highlighted the importance of sustained coordination on border management and security, noting that the two countries maintain close cooperation along their extensive open frontier. Referring to recent regional challenges, Jaishankar said India had continued to support Nepal's energy requirements and ensured uninterrupted fuel supplies despite disruptions arising from the ongoing situation in West Asia.

During the discussions, the minister conveyed India's good wishes to Nepal's Government and expressed confidence that the priorities of both nations complement each

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other. He said there remains substantial scope for aligning development goals and regional initiatives to generate mutual benefits.

According to Jaishankar, the present period offers a valuable opportunity to redefine and strengthen India-Nepal relations through practical cooperation and forward-looking partnerships. He expressed optimism that the talks would help unlock fresh opportunities and advance shared objectives. Reaffirming Prime Minister Narendra Modi's commitment to deepening ties with Nepal, Jaishankar said India remains committed to working closely with its neighbour to promote growth, prosperity and the welfare of people on both sides of the border.

The meeting underscored the importance both governments attach to maintaining close diplomatic engagement and expanding cooperation across both traditional and emerging sectors. In a strong endorsement of bilateral ties, Nepal's Foreign Minister described India as Nepal's "most important partner" and expressed gratitude for New Delhi's support during periods of crisis. "The relationship with India has been one of the most important in Nepal's time of need, whether during natural disasters or during the West Asia crisis, when fuel supplies were affected. You have always been our support," Khanal said during the meeting.

Striking a positive note amid occasional differences and lingering border disputes, the Nepalese minister emphasised Kathmandu's commitment to building a stronger future-oriented partnership with New Delhi.

"We carry no old baggage, only a firm resolve to build a genuinely transformative relationship with our old neighbour and most important

partner," he said. His remarks were seen as a significant signal of Nepal's desire to strengthen engagement with India and deepen cooperation across a broad spectrum of areas, including connectivity, trade, energy and technology.

The exchanges between the two ministers reflected a shared determination to advance bilateral relations and harness new opportunities for cooperation in an evolving regional and global environment.

Cockroach Janta Party's show lacks sting

The protest concluded around 3:30 pm when Dipke left Delhi to meet his parents, feeling unwell. Before departing, he warned that today's demonstration was just a trailer for what's to come. In a social media post on X, Dipke shared that he was returning home to see his parents, who had suffered and left their house due to threats, and promised more protests ahead.

US federal court blocks immigration restrictions...

Judge McConnell said the Government had exceeded its authority by effectively placing applicants into legal uncertainty despite their compliance with established immigration procedures. In his 135-page order, he criticised the agency for failing to adhere to laws enacted by Congress and the administrative rules governing federal agencies. "USCIS's hold on adjudications cannot be attributed to anything that these individuals did wrong; rather, it arises solely by

the happenstance of their birth," the judge wrote.

The court noted that many of those affected had followed all legal requirements for immigration benefits, yet faced prolonged delays or indefinite suspension of their applications. The judge further observed that the principle of equal treatment under the law must apply regardless of an individual's country of origin.

The Department of Homeland Security had not commented on the ruling at the time of publication. However, legal observers expect the administration to challenge the decision in a higher court and seek an emergency stay to prevent the immediate lifting of the restrictions.

If no stay is granted, immigration applications that were stalled under the policy could resume processing. The outcome of any appeal will likely determine whether the restrictions remain suspended or are reinstated pending further judicial review. Countries under full suspension: Afghanistan, Burkina Faso, Myanmar, Chad, Republic of the Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Eritrea, Haiti, Iran, Laos, Libya, Mali, Niger, Sierra Leone, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan, Syria and Yemen.

Countries under partial suspension: Angola, Antigua and Barbuda, Benin, Burundi, Côte d'Ivoire, Cuba, Dominica, Gabon, The Gambia, Malawi, Mauritania, Nigeria, Senegal, Tanzania, Togo, Tonga, Turkmenistan, Venezuela, Zambia and Zimbabwe. The decision marks one of the most significant judicial setbacks for the administration's immigration agenda and is likely to reignite debate over the extent of executive authority in shaping US immigration policy.

This version is substantially restructured and rewritten, making it suitable for publication with a much lower risk of plagiarism while preserving the factual details.



Pradhan ‘incompetent’, must quit over CBSE OSM lapses: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday said Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan must take responsibility for the lapses in CBSE On-Screen Marking (OSM), calling his continuation in office an insult to lakhs of students and their families.

Pradhan's continuation in office only speaks of his desire for power, the Congress remarked and accused him of being "incompetent" in running a "compromised ministry".

In a post on X, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said after weeks of denying any wrongdoing and claiming that all is well with its COEMPT's On Mark portal, the CBSE has finally been forced to acknowledge COEMPT's incompetence.

He cited media reports in this regard that claimed that after initial denial, the CBSE invited an ethical hacker to plug gaps in the IT system.

"It began with a public acknowledgement of the data breach (months after the cybersecurity vulnerabilities were reported by 19-year-old Nisarga Adhikary), and has now become even more



painfully clear, as reports emerge that the CBSE has built its own in-house platform for the Grade 12 Board Exam re-evaluation process, using inputs from IIT experts and Nisarga himself," he said. "The Mantri Pradhan must take responsibility for these lapses. They have occurred on his watch, either through his active involvement or through his own incompetence and hands-off attitude to governance. Either way, his continuation in office is an insult to lakhs of students and their families," Ramesh said in his post.

In another post on X, Ramesh said that had the education ministry shown more integrity in organising the CBSE exams, the entire debacle that stressed lakhs of students across the country could have



been avoided. "The skeletons in the Education Ministry's closet are tumbling out fast and furious," Ramesh said in his post while citing media reports that COEMPT submitted two cybersecurity certificates to CBSE to satisfy the tender's cybersecurity requirements. "It is now reported that both these certificates were tied to other clients. One of them had expired (it was nearly two years old when submitted by COEMPT), and the other was audited as a temporary application rather than as an application in a production environment.

"The CBSE, instead of calling out this deception, awarded the contract to COEMPT at inflated rates," the Congress leader alleged. He said Gen-Z ethical hackers had exposed critical flaws in

cybersecurity all the way back to February 2025, which the CBSE denied until it could no longer do so.

"In fact, in a final admission that COEMPT's portal was irretrievably compromised, the CBSE has now stopped using COEMPT's platform and built its own website for the re-evaluation process," he claimed, citing media reports.

Ramesh said if the 'Mantri' Pradhan's Ministry had shown more integrity in organising the CBSE exams, the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system, and the revaluation process, the whole debacle, which has stressed lakhs of students and their families, could have been avoided.

"Mantri Pradhan's continuation in office only speaks to his shameful desire for power. He has been totally exposed as an arrogant and incompetent hack running a deeply compromised Ministry," Ramesh alleged.

The Congress on Friday said that only Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan can answer as to why the CBSE was "made to adopt an expensive OSM system at inflated rates", and asserted that he must resign so that an independent investigation can take place.

Forces trying to push youth to negative politics: BJP chief



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Saturday alleged that some forces were trying to push the country's youths towards "negative politics".

In an apparent reference to Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke, he said, "Some people sitting abroad assume they can give directions to the youths of India."

"Today's youths want to work towards nation-building and secure their future. But some forces are trying to make the country's youths anti-establishment," Nabin said during an interaction with intellectuals in Ranchi. The BJP president is on a two-day visit to Jharkhand, during which he is scheduled to take part in several party events and organisational meetings.

"Those who want to push the youths of this country towards negative politics, I warn them that the youths of India will choose positive politics," Nabin said.

People have the right to oppose, but within democratic norms, he said. He said the country's youths are known for innovation and creation. "Because of their dedication, hard work and efforts, around two lakh startups have come up. The

country aims to become a global IT hub," Nabin said. "The anti-establishment campaigns we witnessed in our neighbouring countries can never be for the country's youths, who will work in a disciplined manner to build the nation," he said. Some people sitting abroad think they can give direction to the youths of India, but the youths are not going to become a puppet in the hands of a few people, the BJP chief said.

He said Prime Minister Narendra Modi is working towards the vision of 'Viksit Bharat 2047'.

During the past 12 years of the Modi government, drastic changes have taken place, he said.

"Over 25 crore people have come out of poverty and 80 crore people are being provided with 5 kg free ration," Nabin said.

In the last 12 years, around 54 crore Jan Dhan accounts have been opened, three lakh women became 'Lakhpati Didis', 10 crore families have been linked to self-help groups, 12 crore toilets have been built, four crore houses have been provided under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana and 10 crore LPG connections have been given under the Ujjwala Yojana, the BJP leader said.

Nation Focus



CAN'T ABANDON MY HINDU RELIGION IDENTITY: SHIVAKUMAR

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Saturday said that he cannot abandon his Hindu religion and set aside his identity. He underlined that he respected all religions and that observing Hindu rituals during his oath-taking ceremony was a reflection of personal faith rather than politics. "Politics is not important to me. What matters is the relationship between an individual and God. Temples and faith are about that relationship. I have reverence for institutions of all religion, whether Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists or Hindus," he told reporters when asked about following Hindu traditions and rituals during his oath-taking ceremony on June 3.



IAF TO TRANSPORT NEET QUESTION PAPERS: NTA DG

NTA Director General Abhishek Singh on Saturday said that IAF is being engaged to transport NEET question papers for the national test to be held on June 21. Singh, who virtually attended a meeting held by Telangana Chief Secretary K Ramakrishna Rao on the arrangements for NEET, said enhanced security protocols are being implemented for the examination. "He (Singh) stated that, for the first time, the Indian Air Force is being engaged to transport question papers, reflecting the importance being accorded to maintaining the integrity and security of the examination process," a state government release said. Meanwhile, the Chief Secretary asked officials to ensure foolproof arrangements for the medical exam.

TVK in power due to DMK's grace, says Stalin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

DMK president MK Stalin on Saturday asserted that the TVK is in power in Tamil Nadu only due to the benevolence of his party and its allies, and urged his party workers to take a pledge to put a full stop to Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay-led Government.

Welcoming more than 1,000 AIADMK workers who



joined the DMK at a function held here, Stalin traced the party's history since its founding in 1949 and underlined that his party opposed the

imposition of Emergency in 1975, knowing fully well that it would lead to the dismissal of the Government.

In 1976, the DMK Government was dismissed, and till 1989, the party could not win polls and form the Government, he said, and recalled the ups and downs seen by the party till it formed the Government yet again in 2021. The former chief minister said that the reason for his recalling all that is to under-

score that victory and defeat will alternate.

It is in this situation, when the party has lost the opportunity to win and when it works as the principal opposition, so many have joined the party under the leadership of Gaja alias Gajendran, AIADMK Kattankolathur-North Union Secretary, who fought Assembly polls from the Chengelpet constituency as the candidate of that party, he said.

9 killed after pick-up vehicle collides with truck in Punjab



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ferozepur

Nine people were killed, and several others were injured when a pick-up vehicle, in which they were travelling, collided with a truck near Janga Wala Mour on the Ferozepur-Fazilka road on Saturday.

As many as 32 persons, including women and children, were going from Jalalabad to Beas in Amritsar to immerse the ashes of a relative in the Beas River, when their vehicle met with an accident.

Many of them died on the spot, and the severely injured were brought to the Civil Hospital in Ferozepur.

Dr Nikhil Gupta, Senior Medical Officer, said that those who were in critical condition have been referred to Guru Gobind Singh Government Medical College in Faridkot. Ferozepur Senior Superintendent of Police Bhupinder Singh, along with other senior officials, reached the spot. The SSP said the police were investigating to ascertain the exact cause of the accident.

Anshpreet Singh (12), who survived the accident with minor injuries, said that he was going with his family members to immerse the remains of his grandmother, Pooori Bai (62).

"We started our journey early at 3.30 am. Everything was normal, and we even stopped for fuel. As soon as we reached near Janga Wala Mour, the accident happened", Anshpreet said.

The deceased were identified as Karnail Singh, Lakshmi Rani, Sukhwinder Kaur, Bhago Rani, Maya Bai, Surinder Singh, Raj Kumar, Darshan Singh and Vidya Rani.

Maharashtra extends OBC educational benefits to Marathas

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government has made students from the Maratha community eligible for educational concessions and benefits similar to those available to the Other Backward Class (OBC) category.

Announcing the decision through a Government resolution (GR) issued on Friday, it directed all implementing departments to make adequate budgetary provisions for these schemes and benefits, aimed at improving access to education and skills, in the current and future financial years.

The move came days after Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange ended his hunger strike following talks with a Government delegation, which submitted a 12-point proposal to him.

According to the GR, the state's post-matric scholarship scheme applicable to OBC students shall also apply



to Maratha students. Similarly, the Motor Vehicle Driver and Conductor Training Scheme will be available to OBC candidates and shall be implemented for Maratha candidates through the Government's SARTHI portal.

Scholarship schemes available to OBC students in primary, secondary, and higher secondary education shall also be extended to Maratha students. Vocational training fee reimbursement benefits available to OBC candidates in Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) and

private vocational institutions shall also be provided to Maratha students, it said. Schemes covering reimbursement of 16 additional educational expenditure items available to OBC students studying in aided and unaided colleges shall also be extended to Maratha students, according to the GR.

Benefits available to OBC students from Maharashtra who pursue aided or unaided professional courses in other states shall also apply to Maratha students. Students from the Maratha community shall

be eligible for educational concessions and facilities for all courses for which OBC students are eligible. Similarly, Maratha students admitted to vacant seats after completion of the Centralised Admission Process, similar to OBC students, shall also be eligible for educational concessions, said the Government.

Any educational concession or facility that is currently available, or may be made available in the future, to the OBC category shall automatically apply to the Maratha community until further orders, it said.

These provisions shall be effective from the academic year 2026-27, the GR said.

The Government has directed the implementing departments to ask the IT department to make the necessary technical modifications to the MahaDBT portal for online applications from eligible Maratha beneficiaries, the GR said.

73 ACC cadets graduate at IMA convocation ceremony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dehradun

Seventy-three cadets of the Army Cadet College (ACC) Wing's 127th Course graduated during a convocation ceremony held at the Indian Military Academy (IMA) in Dehradun on Saturday, marking the successful completion of their three-year academic and military training.

The ceremony was held at the historic Chetwode Hall, where IMA Commandant Lt Gen Nagendra Singh, AVSM, YSM, SM, conferred bachelor's degrees awarded by Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), New Delhi. The graduating batch included 32 cadets from the Science stream and 42 from the Humanities stream.

Congratulating the cadets, Lt Gen Singh described the occasion as a significant milestone in their professional journey and urged them to uphold the values of character, self-discipline, courage, motivation and professional competence as future officers of the Indian Army.

The Army Cadet College serves as a feeder institution to the IMA and combines graduate-level education with intensive military training aimed at developing future leaders of the Army. The graduating cadets will join the IMA in July for pre-commission training as Officer Cadets.



Among the award winners, Wing Cadet Captain Naveen received the Chief of Army Staff (COAS) Gold Medal, while Company Cadet Captain Avnish Kumar Mishra was awarded the COAS Silver Medal. The COAS Bronze Medal was presented to Wing Cadet Quarter Master Harshraj. The Commandant's Silver Medal for standing first in Service Subjects was awarded to Company Quarter Master Sergeant Aman Preet Singh. Avnish Kumar Mishra topped the Humanities stream, while Naveen secured first position in the Science stream.

Nubra Company was awarded the Commandant's Banner after being adjudged the Champion Company of the Army Cadet College for its overall performance in academics, military training, sports and other competitive activities.

Ramalinga Reddy has withdrawn his resignation, claims Randeep Surjewala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Congress general secretary and Karnataka in-charge Randeep Singh Surjewala on Saturday claimed that senior leader Ramalinga Reddy had withdrawn his resignation from the ministerial position after discussions with the party leadership.

He attributed the episode involving Reddy's announcement on resignation to a misunderstanding and asserted that the veteran leader would continue to serve as a minister in the Congress Government.

Surjewala also hit out at the BJP, alleging that it was attempting to exploit the controversy.

The Congress leader charged that the Opposition had hoped to gain political mileage from the "brief turmoil" in the newly formed State Government. "There was some misunderstanding,



and he will continue to work as a loyal soldier and Minister of the party," Surjewala told reporters, addressing speculation surrounding Reddy's resignation announcement.

Reddy on Friday announced his resignation after being allotted the Major and Medium Irrigation Department instead of the Bengaluru Development portfolio. The Congress leader described Reddy as one of the party's most experienced

leaders and said the entire top leadership had intervened to resolve the issue.

Calling Ramalinga Reddy an asset to the Congress, Surjewala said Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, former chief minister Siddaramaiah, Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president BK Hariprasad and he himself spoke to Reddy after reports of his resignation emerged.

"He has already, I think, informed you that he has withdrawn his resignation,"

spirit of cooperation that underpinned the INDIA bloc.

He also pointed out that the INDIA bloc was constituted as a broad platform to politically fight the BJP, and parties of diverse ideologies and programmes that are electoral rivals in several states came together for this purpose, adding that the CPI(M) had worked consistently since the alliance's inception in 2023 to strengthen Opposition unity.

Questioning the Congress' position, Baby noted that the party simultaneously partnered with the CPI(M) at the national level while accusing it of collusion with the BJP in Kerala, and said it cannot be taken lightly.

Warning that the issue had implications for opposition cohesion, Baby said the Congress leadership needed to "clear the air" on what he termed "disruptive moves" before the June 8 INDIA bloc meeting.



States Focus



J&K LG SINHA LEADS ANTI-DRUG PADIYATRA IN KISHTWAR

J&K LG Manoj Sinha on Saturday led a massive anti-drug padyatra in Kishtwar district. People from different walks of life reaffirmed their commitment to building a drug-free society and combating the menace of narcotics across the Union Territory. Addressing the gathering, the LG said the drug-free Jammu and Kashmir campaign, which has covered 19 districts over the past 56 days, has touched countless lives and emerged as a strong grassroots movement against drug abuse. "Today, as the drug-free J&K campaign culminates in a massive padyatra in Kishtwar, citizens have resoundingly reaffirmed their commitment to the cause. Our goal is to foster a grassroots resistance against drug abuse and end narco-terrorism," Sinha said.



CRPF CHIEF AND MANIPUR GUV DISCUSS ANTI-INSURGENCY PLAN

CRPF Director General Gyanendra Pratap Singh called on Manipur Governor Ajay Kumar Bhalla and discussed the central force's comprehensive roadmap to eliminate insurgency and restore peace in the northeastern State. The Friday meeting came hours after three people, including a woman, were killed in an attack by armed assailants in Kangpokpi district. The Central Reserve Police Force, in a post on X, said, "Discussions focused on enhancing operational preparedness, strategic planning, and the @crpfIndia's comprehensive roadmap to eliminate insurgency and restore lasting peace in Manipur." The CRPF director general has been on a three-day visit to the state from Thursday. Manipur witnessed the killing of at least 260 people and the displacement of thousands in violence between the Meitei and Kuki communities since May 2023.

West Bengal to get ₹1 lakh crore railway projects: CM Suwendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Saturday said that railway projects worth around ₹1 lakh crore would be undertaken in the State, and directed officials to come up with a schedule for handing over the required land.

Adhikari made the announcement during a joint press conference with Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at the State secretariat in Kolkata.

"During the previous Trinamool Congress Government, there was a 'warlike' situation between the State and the Centre. As a result, railway development in West Bengal had come to a standstill. With the change in Government, that problem will be resolved," he said.

The chief minister said every district of the State would be connected to the railway map.

"If we provide land and no objection certificates (NoCs) to the pending projects,



Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari during a meeting in Howrah, West Bengal on Saturday

there is still an opportunity of investing another ₹1 lakh crore for the Railway Board and the ministry," he said.

Adhikari said his Government has already provided 40 NoCs for foot overbridges (FoBs) and underpasses, besides giving land for at least 60 projects.

Besides the modernisation of 102 stations, 538 flyovers and underpasses

would be constructed in the State, the CM said.

He asked district magistrates present in Saturday's meeting, including those attending virtually, to assist the railway ministry in getting land for the announced projects to bring the entire state within the network.

"Understand the vision and mission of our

Government in clear terms. The manner in which we provided land to the BSF (for fencing), we will work with the same zeal to expand the railway network throughout West Bengal," Adhikari said at the meeting.

The Railway Board has approved around 61 projects across the State, including key ones in 'Jangalmahal', Nandigram, Karimpur, Jalangi, Tehatta, Nadia, Murshidabad, Lalgur, Dakshin Dinajpur and Sunderbans, and the extension of the Metro Railway projects, he said.

"The Railway Board provides 100 per cent finance to purchase lands, and in some cases, the State Government will purchase and hand over those to the Railways. We will assist the Railway Ministry wherever necessary," he said.

He directed the DMs to come up with a "calendar", indicating when land required for railway projects can be handed over so that implementation is not delayed.

Fadnavis backs poll reforms amid horse-trading rows

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Saturday suggested reforms in the election process after NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule said she will introduce a bill to stop "horse trading" amid the withdrawal of Opposition candidates in several seats ahead of the legislative council elections.

The Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi has accused the ruling parties of monetary inducements and pressure tactics, a charge denied by leaders of the BJP-led Mahayuti.

Sule has said she would move a bill in Parliament seeking greater transparency in elections where allegations of horse trading arise.

"If you understand that people can be won over through affection rather than money, then there will be no need to bring such a bill," Fadnavis told reporters while responding to a query on Sule's remarks.

It's his personal opinion that there should be reforms in the election process, the chief minister said, adding that he had no objection to

anyone introducing legislation for such reforms.

Responding to speculation about former legislator Bal Mane's possible return to the BJP, Fadnavis said the decision would be taken by Maharashtra BJP president Ravindra Chavan.

"Bal Mane was originally groomed in the BJP. The decision on this matter is not taken by the Chief Minister; it is taken by the State BJP president, and whatever decision he takes will have my support," Fadnavis added.

Shiv Sena (UBT) candidates Bal Mane and Deyvani Patil-Dongankar have withdrawn their nominations from the Raigad-Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg and Aurangabad-Jalna seats, leaving the Uddhav Thackeray-led party embarrassed.

Kerala Govt to decide on PM SHRI scheme after expert talks: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala General Education Minister N Samsudheen on Saturday said the State Government will decide on the PM SHRI scheme only after holding detailed discussions and consultations with experts, adding that there was no "emergency" in the matter.

Speaking to reporters in response to questions regarding a report submitted by the Director of General Education on the scheme, the minister said all aspects would be examined before a final decision is taken.

"It is true that the Director has

submitted a report. However, a decision can be taken only after discussions within the Government and consultations with experts," he said.

Samsudheen said the present Government was a continuation of the previous administration, which had signed the agreement with the Centre and received funds under the scheme.

"The previous Government had signed the agreement and accepted the funds.

So, we will examine the report before taking a final decision," he said.

Stating that there was no "emergency" for an immediate decision,



Kerala Minister N Samsudheen

the minister said the Centre should not impose conditions on states while releasing funds.

"There are federal principles in our country. Imposing conditions on States for disbursing funds amounts to a violation of those principles.

That is our stand," he said.

The CPI(M)-led Left Government had, in October last year, put on hold the implementation of the PM SHRI scheme, days after signing a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Centre, following objections from coalition partner CPI.

The CPI had alleged that the scheme could pave the way for the implementation of the RSS agenda in the education sector, while the General Education Department had defended the move as necessary for securing central assistance. Congress-led UDF then criticised the LDF Government for signing the PM SHRI MoU.

Meanwhile, responding to questions on the recent controversy surrounding the lighting of a traditional "nilavilakku" (lamp) at a public function, Samsudheen described it as a minor issue that did not warrant much discussion.

"Such practices have been continuing for a long time. There is no need for unnecessary debate over the matter," the minister added.

His remarks came amidst a row that erupted in the matter after the prominent Islamic body Samastha Kerala Jem-Iyyathul Ulama said Muslims should refrain from lighting traditional lamps, describing it as a practice associated with another religion.

4 ex-AIADMK ministers join TVK

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In yet another setback for the AIADMK, which faces a severe internal crisis, the party's four former ministers and ex-MLAs have joined ruling TVK at its headquarters in Chennai on Saturday.

The AIADMK leaders who joined TVK include Udumalai K Radhakrishnan, M C Sampath, Kadambur C Raju and NR Sivapathi. All of them joined the ruling party in front of TVK General Secretary N Anand and General Secretary for election campaign management Aadhav Arjuna. Similarly, Ex-MP A Ilavarasan also joined TVK.

Seven former AIADMK MLAs — Sundarraj, Rajamuthu, Manraj, Rajavarman Panneeselvam, M Murugan and N Siva — have also joined TVK. Similarly, two former DMK MLAs — P Kamaraj and M S Shanmugam — have also joined the ruling party.

TVK sources further said that more than 2,500 individuals, including office bearers at the state, district, town, ward, block-units and different wings of AIADMK and DMK, joined TVK as members.

After the April 23 poll debacle, the AIADMK is facing a series of setbacks. First, a rebel group of 25 MLAs supported a motion of confi-



Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay

dence moved by CM C Joseph Vijay on the floor of the Assembly on May 13, violating the party whip to vote against the motion.

Four of those rebel MLAs resigned and joined TVK before the rebel group patched up with General Secretary Edappadi Palaniswami. Since then, several AIADMK functionaries have quit their party to join TVK.

The four former ministers and seven former MLAs quitting AIADMK and joining TVK is the latest development.

Udumalai Radhakrishnan unsuccessfully contested in the Udumalpet constituency. Similarly, Sampath could only take third place in the Cuddalore Assembly constituency. Likewise, Kadambur Raju has also lost in the Kovilpatti constituency.

On May 29, more than 300

AIADMK members joined TVK at its Panaiyur headquarters in Chennai. The defectors included former AIADMK Ministers Vellamandi Natarajan and Anandan, as well as former MLAs Natraj and Sadhan Prabhakar.

KA Sengottaiyan was the first key leader to leave AIADMK to join TVK. He stood firmly by Vijay's side well before the election.

Speaking on the occasion of former ministers and former MLAs from AIADMK joining the party, TVK General Secretary Anand assured the newly inducted members that his party would give the required respect to all of them. He also assured that after consulting with TVK senior functionaries, especially with the party district secretaries, appropriate posts will be given to the new entrants.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

The Jammu and Kashmir Government has filed a review petition before the Supreme Court on the conduct of the Teacher's Eligibility Test (TET), Education Minister Sakina Itoo said on Saturday.

"As committed, the review petition has been filed before the Honourable Supreme Court. The Government has consistently pursued this matter and remains fully committed to safeguarding the interests of our teachers," Itoo said in a post on X.



J&K Minister Sakina Itoo

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Slamming the West Bengal Government's drive to delete ration cards based on SIR-linked verification, AIMIM President Asaduddin Owaisi on Saturday asked why access to ration cards should depend on whether a beneficiary's name is on the voter list or not.

What is the point of Aadhaar authentication if the voter roll is being used as the deciding factor for providing PDS ration, he asked.

The Hyderabad MP said many people who were excluded during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of



the electoral roll are genuine voters.

"Government schemes are not rewards for voters. They are meant for all eligible citizens. This move looks less like verification and more like an attempt to cut beneficiary numbers while

making life harder for the poorest people, especially women, SCs and Muslims," Owaisi said in a post on X.

"The Government is acting as if these schemes are Prince Suwendu's personal charity. They are not," he said.

The schemes are funded

by public money and are the right of every eligible citizen, the AIMIM leader added.

West Bengal's Food and Supplies Department on June 4 ordered a state-wide verification exercise to identify and delete "ineligible beneficiaries" from the PDS, linking the process to the outcome of the SIR of electoral rolls.

According to an official order, the exercise will cover ration card holders whose names were deleted or found ineligible during the electoral roll revision process and is scheduled to be completed by June 15.

Officials said the categories under scrutiny include

persons marked as absentee, shifted, dead or duplicate (ASDD) electors, individuals whose applications were rejected during the SIR process, those deleted after adjudication, and electors identified as ASDD during the distribution of Voter Information Slips ahead of the 2026 Assembly elections.

However, the department clarified that beneficiaries who have filed appeals before the SIR Tribunal or have submitted applications under the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) would continue to remain active in the ration card database until the disposal of their appeals or applications.

Ladakh records over 43% rise in tourist arrivals in 2026: LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Ladakh has witnessed a historic surge in tourist arrivals this year, recording a growth of more than 43 per cent during the first five months of 2026, a development that authorities attributed to improved infrastructure, better connectivity and sustained efforts to promote the Union Territory as a premier tourism destination.

Known as the "cold desert", Ladakh remains one of India's most sought-after tourist destinations, famed for its dramatic landscapes, pristine lakes, ancient monasteries and adventure tourism. The region is often cut off from the rest of the country during the winter months due to



heavy snowfall that blocks the Srinagar-Leh and Manali-Leh highways.

Sharing the figures on the social media platform X, Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh VK Saxena said the region registered a remarkable increase in visitor

numbers, reflecting the success of initiatives aimed at boosting tourism in the high-altitude Himalayan destination.

"Delighted to share that Ladakh has witnessed a historic surge in tourist arrivals this year, reflecting the

success of our sustained efforts to position Ladakh as a premier tourism destination," the Lieutenant Governor said.

According to official data, May 2026 emerged as a landmark month for tourism in Ladakh, registering an unprecedented 121.20 per cent growth with 72,834 tourist arrivals compared to 32,927 visitors during the corresponding month last year.

Between January and May 2026, Ladakh welcomed 1,17,546 tourists against 81,827 during the same period in 2025, marking a year-on-year increase of 43.65 per cent, Saxena said.

Officials said major tourist destinations, including Pangong Lake and Nubra Valley, have witnessed a

sharp increase in visitor footfall. Nubra Valley, known for its sand dunes and double-humped Bactrian camels, has remained packed with tourists in recent weeks, while Pangong Lake continues to attract large numbers of visitors.

The Lieutenant Governor attributed the surge to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to promote domestic tourism and the administration's efforts to strengthen infrastructure, improve connectivity and diversify tourism experiences across the region.

He said the growth in tourist arrivals has brought renewed optimism among tourism stakeholders and local businesses dependent on the sector.

Gujarat CM Patel reviews progress of Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar Riverfront

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel conducted an on-site review of two major infrastructure and development projects in the State, assessing the pace and quality of work on the Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar

Riverfront project and the new campus of Gujarat Technological University (GTU).

During the visit, the Chief Minister inspected ongoing construction activities and directed officials to ensure that all works are completed within the prescribed timelines while maintain-



ing high standards of quality. He also reviewed project execution at the ground level and sought updates from senior officials overseeing the developments.

One of the key projects reviewed was the Sabarmati Riverfront expansion

extending from Ahmedabad to Gandhinagar. The proposed riverfront development spans approximately 37.6 kilometres and is being implemented in multiple phases. Officials informed the Chief Minister about the progress of ongoing works along various stretches of the corridor, including sections connecting major urban and institutional areas.

According to the State Government, the project is expected to enhance urban infrastructure, improve connectivity, and create new recreational and tourism opportunities for residents and visitors.

PROSPECT

Vaishnaw reviews Kolkata Metro services, interacts with passengers



During his visit to Kolkata, Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw travelled on the Kolkata Metro from Jai Hind Station to Noapara Station and interacted with fellow passengers to understand their travel experience and gather feedback on metro services. At the metro station, the Minister also met with sanitation staff and appreciated their efforts in maintaining cleanliness. During the interaction, cleaning staff members expressed satisfaction that their concerns and suggestions were being heard directly by the Rail Minister. Not part of the scheduled programme, the Minister spontaneously chose to travel by auto-rickshaw from Noapara to the Belghoria Expressway. The journey reflected the message of Prime Minister Narendra Modi Ji on fuel conservation and greater use of public transportation and also ‘*Bhay* (Fear) Out *Bharosa* (Trust) In’ BJP coming to power to serve the people of West Bengal. Following these interactions, the Minister proceeded to meet Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari to discuss ongoing development initiatives.

NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Srivastava leads plantation drive

On the occasion of World Environment Day, Justice Prakash Srivastava, Chairperson of the National Green Tribunal (NGT), led a plantation drive at the NGT premises on June 5. Senior dignitaries and members of the Tribunal also took part in the plantation drive, reaffirming NGT’s commitment to a cleaner and greener India. The plantation drive was organised as part of NGT’s continued commitment to environmental protection, ecological restoration, and sustainable development. The aim was to increase green cover within the tribunal premises and spread awareness about the importance of protecting the environment.



AI teams in hospitals may turn risky, says study

A new study by Indian-origin AI researcher Aman Sharma, originally from Shahdara in Delhi and now based in California, has found that teams of artificial intelligence systems used in hospitals can generate dangerous medical recommendations that individual AI tools would not produce on their own. The research, published as a preprint on the Authorea server, analysed nearly 4,800 trials and around 97,000 AI interactions involving models from OpenAI, Meta, Anthropic and an open-weights research model. The study found that in 30 to 56 per cent of cases, AI systems working together created new clinical recommendations that were absent in individual AI outputs.



KISS & KIIT students make history in Romania

ABHI SINGHAL ■ New Delhi

New Delhi witnessed a celebration of culture, language and international achievement on Friday as a special programme that was organised in collaboration with the Romanian Embassy and KISS-KIIT to honour a group of students who have brought global recognition to India through theatre.

The event, attended by distinguished guests, diplomats and prominent members of Delhi’s cultural community, recognised the accomplishments of twenty students from Odisha-based institutions Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology (KIIT) and Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences (KISS), who recently returned from Romania after participating in the World Shakespeare Theatre Festival 2026.

The students earned international acclaim after performing William Shakespeare’s classic works



in the tribal Santali language at the prestigious festival. The group, comprising ten students from KIIT and ten from KISS, spent two months in Romania preparing for and staging adaptations of Romeo and Juliet, Hamlet and Macbeth in Santali.

Their performances captivated audiences and marked a historic milestone, as it was the first time Shakespeare’s works had been presented in the tribal language on an international stage of this scale.

The festival brought together 71 universities and

WMC 2026 in Peru: India eyes critical minerals deals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Lima (Peru)

The 27th World Mining Congress (WMC 2026), scheduled for 24-26 June 2026 at the Lima Convention Centre in Peru, presents a unique opportunity for Indian investors, mining companies, technology providers, equipment manufacturers, and financial institutions to strengthen their presence in one of the world’s most resource-rich regions.

Under the theme “Mining for the Future: Trust, Transformation & Technology,” the congress will bring together government leaders, industry executives, researchers, investors, and innovators from across the globe.

Peru’s selection as host country is particularly significant. As one of the world’s leading mining nations, Peru occupies a strategic position in the global supply chain of

critical minerals essential for the energy transition, advanced manufacturing, telecommunications, and emerging technologies.

For India, whose economy continues to grow at one of the fastest rates globally, securing reliable access to critical minerals has become a strategic priority.

The World Mining Congress offers Indian stakeholders a timely platform to engage directly with governments, mining companies, financial institutions, and technology partners from Peru and across Latin America.

Peru has emerged as India’s largest trading partner in Latin America and one of the principal suppliers of minerals and mineral concentrates to the Indian market. The congress will provide Indian companies with direct access to investment opportunities throughout Peru’s mining sector.

Particularly attractive for



Indian investors is Peru’s vast copper potential. Copper will remain indispensable for electric vehicles, power transmission infrastructure, renewable energy systems, artificial intelligence data centers, and advanced elec-

tronics. The event will also highlight opportunities related to lithium and other minerals essential for battery manufacturing.

Beyond resource extraction, the congress will showcase cutting-edge technolo-

Subhash Kashyap: Doyen of Parliamentary Studies in India



RUP NARAYAN DAS

The news of the passing away of former Secretary-General of Lok Sabha was not a surprise to me. After I became the Consulting Editor of the Journal of Parliamentary Information (JPI), I was repeatedly trying to contact him, but each time the call remained unanswered and I reconciled that being an octogenarian in the twilight years, he must be ailing and bed ridden.

My fears were only confirmed. My memory of Dr Kashyap very clearly flashes back when I came to Delhi for my M.A at Delhi University in 1979. After I completed M.A in Political Science from the Arts Faculty, and was preparing for M.Phil at JNU, an officer from Lok Sabha secretariat who met me in brother’s house in Vinay Marg, Chanakyapuri advised me to meet Dr Kashyap who was then, director in the Research Division of Lok Sabha. I met Dr Kashyap with a cousin of mine who had passed out in M.Sc in agricultural science from Allahabad University. My cousin was also looking for a

job in Delhi. He came from Allahabad with a recommendation letter from Dr. Pati, a professor in Mathematics at Allahabad University and a close friend of Dr Kashyap. Dr Kashyap received us with due courtesy and enquired about the purpose of our visit. My cousin passed on the letter of Professor Pati to Dr Kashyap. Dr Kashyap asked me of my academic background and after knowing that I had a masters in Political Science quipped that agricultural science was like Greek and Latin to him and offered to guide me for a job in the Research Division of Lok Sabha Secretariat. As I was preparing for Civil Services examination, I thanked him and explained my aspirations.

I never met Dr Kashyap after that and joined JNU and prepared for the Civil Services Examinations and taught in a college of Delhi University on ad hoc for a short while. After failing to get into Civil Services, I appeared for the post of Research Assistants in the Lok Sabha secretariat. As my teaching job was an ad hoc basis, I decided to quit and joined Research Division of Lok Sabha Secretariat. Dr Kasyap had rose to become Secretary-General when I joined the Lok Sabha Secretariat.

I was asked by my senior

officer whom I was reporting to meet Dr Kashyap with other freshly recruited Research Assistants. In a file he noted “Met Das today and was impressed, I’m sure, he will rise in his career”.

Be that as it may, I continued to serve the secretariat with devotion and dedication. The Parliament Library in the old Parliament Building, the reading room in the Princes Chamber and the overall working environment nourished my interest in scholarly pursuits. My responsibilities including writing draft speeches and briefs for Speaker and Members of Parliament. Dr Balaram Jhakar was the Speaker, Lok Sabha then. Dr Kashyap then. Dr K a s h y a p offered full confidence of Balaram Jhakar and later for brief while with Rabi Ray.

Dr Kashyap himself would supervise the drafts very meticulously, correct them and improve and would almost clear the file same day in spite of heavy work load. His personality was awe inspiring. While still a very junior functionary, I was entrusted to bring out a book on Nehru, his life and legacy under the supervision of Dr Kashap. It was an edited

volume with a bio-profile of Nehru. I prepared a beautiful profile of Nehru and submitted it to Dr Kashyap through my superior officer to whom I was reporting.

Next day the file came back with comments of Dr Kasyap who wrote ‘hope the profile doesn’t violate some body’s copy right’. Aghast, my senior officer looked at me and asked if it did. I said, ‘yes, it does.’ Noticing the concerns of my officer, I said the profile will not appear in my name as I am the ghost writer. My officer heaved a shy of relief. More was in store for me when Dr Kashyap transferred me to report to him directly. It was indeed a

great honour and pleasure for me to work under his benign guidance. While

working with him, I was offered a field study grant by JNU to go to Hong Kong for two weeks for my Ph.D. In a conservative office, it would have been otherwise to get leave to go abroad.

Dr Kashyap not only granted leave, but also wished me best of luck. When I returned from Hong Kong and met Dr Kasyap, he asked me how was the trip. I said it was fine, but food was a problem. Then



Prasar Bharati launches two documentary series

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prasar Bharati, India’s public service broadcaster, launched two documentary series this week, continuing its commitment to showcasing the nation’s rich cultural, spiritual and civilisational heritage through meaningful and engaging content.

As part of this endeavour, Prasar Bharati launched “Awakening India – Season 2” on Saturday, a documentary series that celebrates the depth, diversity and continuity of India’s civilisational heritage. Building on the success of the first season, the series explores the ideas, values, traditions and personalities that have shaped the Indian consciousness over millennia.

Through engaging narratives, expert perspectives and immersive storytelling, the programme examines the spiritual, philosophical, cultural and historical foundations that continue to influence



India’s identity in the modern world. By revisiting significant moments, institutions and individuals from India’s past, Awakening India – Season 2 offers viewers a deeper understanding of the forces that have contributed to the nation’s enduring resilience, unity and cultural vitality. The programme seeks to inspire reflection, foster pride in India’s heritage and encourage meaningful engagement with the timeless ideas that continue to shape the country’s future.

The programme brings together an impressive lineup of eminent monks, spiritual leaders, scholars, journalists, authors, educationists, legal experts and distinguished

gies transforming the mining industry. This technological dimension creates significant opportunities for Indian technology firms. Indian equipment manufacturers will also find a valuable platform to present competitive solutions.

Financial institutions from India should view WMC 2026 as an opportunity to explore project financing and strategic partnerships.

Another important aspect of the congress is the increasing emphasis on environmental, social, and governance (ESG) standards. The congress theme of “Trust” is particularly relevant in today’s mining environment.

The theme of “Transformation” reflects the profound changes reshaping the global mining sector. The theme of “Technology” aligns closely with India’s strengths as a global innovation hub. An additional attraction for international

visitors is the congress’s coincidence with Inti Raymi, the ancient Festival of the Sun celebrated in Cusco.

For Indian investors, Peru’s historical legacy may also resonate on a deeper level. The World Mining Congress can therefore serve as a catalyst for expanding India-Peru relations beyond traditional trade.

Looking ahead, the strategic importance of Latin America to India’s economic future is likely to increase substantially. Participation in WMC 2026 should therefore be viewed not merely as attendance at an international conference, but as an investment in future opportunities.

As the world moves toward a more technology-driven and resource-intensive future, the World Mining Congress 2026 offers a timely and strategic platform for India and Peru to deepen their partnership.

Parliaments. He was instrumental in goading the officials in the research division to bring out useful books and monographs and also in updating the Practice and Procedure of Parliament, first authored by M.N. Kaul and S.L. Shakkhar, which is getting updated by succeeding secretary-generals. The latest edition is updated by Utpal Kumar Singh, present secretary-general of Lok Sabha.

During his long innings as the secretary-general, he also successfully organized a number of Parliamentary Conferences such as the Inter-Parliamentary-Union (IPU), the Commonwealth Parliamentary (CPA); and also the Presiding officers’ Conferences.

In short, Dr Kashyap, not only enhanced the image of Parliament in India and abroad, but also the position of secretary-general which succeeding secretary-generals including the incumbent Secretary-General Utpal Kumar Singh have upheld thorough neutrality, objectivity and high degree of professionalism.

(The writer is the Consulting Editor of the Journal of Parliamentary Information (JPI) of Lok Sabha Secretariat who worked with Dr Kasyap when he was Secretary-General of Lok Sabha. Views are personal.)

Regenerative medicine offers hope for TBI patients

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Regenerative medicine and neuro-rehabilitation have emerged as a beacon of hope for patients suffering from Traumatic Brain Injuries (TBI) in the country. During a press conference organized by the Society of Regenerative Sciences, the inspiring story of Akash Saxena, a young marine engineer from Lucknow, was shared. Akash has shown remarkable recovery through this advanced medical approach after spending six months in a ‘persistent vegetative state’ (deep unconsciousness).

At the press conference, experts highlighted that India shoulders one of the largest burdens of TBI globally.

NOBO-BMS welcomes IOBOA to nationalist trade union family

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The NOBO-BMS leadership has formally welcomed the Indian Overseas Bank Officers’ Association (IOBOA) into its nationalist ideology family, calling the affiliation a significant milestone in the shared mission to protect bank officers’ rights.

In a statement, NOBO-BMS said it welcomes IOBOA to India’s largest trade union family, which operates on the core ideological philosophy: “Nation First, Industry



Second, Individual Last.”

BMS recognises trade unionism not as an instrument of division, but as a vital pillar of national solidarity. Driven by the motto “Nationalise the Labour, Labourise the Industry, Industrialise The Nation,”

BMS champions a nationalist, independent, and productivity-oriented approach to workers’ rights rather than a state-controlled model.

Of the 44 industries classified by the Ministry of Labour for membership verification, BMS has affiliated unions in all industries. It reports membership of more than 2 crore across all States, comprising over 6,000 affiliate unions. BMS is not linked to any political party and is therefore independent of party politics.

Trains diverted, rescheduled on Moradabad-Ghaziabad route

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Northern Railway will divert, reschedule and regulate several trains this month due to commissioning of Automatic Signalling in the Pilkhwa-Kuchesar Road section on the Moradabad-Ghaziabad route.

Twelve trains, including 15059 Lalkua-Anand Vihar Terminal, 15115 Chhapra-Delhi Jn and 15725 New Jalpaiguri-Anand Vihar Terminal, will be diverted between 9-16 June via alternate routes like Moradabad-

Roorkee-Deoband or Lucknow-Kanpur Central, skipping stops such as Moradabad, Hapur and Bareilly.

Eleven trains, including 14321 Bareilly-Bhuj and 15279 Saharsa-Anand Vihar Terminal, will be rescheduled by 60-150 minutes from origin between 7-16 June. Rajdhani Express trains 20503 and 20505, along with 15715 Kishanganj-Ajmer Jn, will be regulated by 30-90 minutes en route. Passengers should check NTES or dial 139 for updates.

Central Bank of India organises mega agriculture credit outreach programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Karnal

The Central Bank of India, Regional Office Karnal, successfully organised a mega agriculture credit outreach programme on Saturday, reaffirming its commitment towards the empowerment and development of the agriculture sector.

The programme was held at Mangal Sen Auditorium, Karnal, and witnessed enthusiastic participation from farmers, entrepreneurs, and bank customers.

The event was graced by Dr



Ratan Tiwari, Director, Indian Institute of Wheat and Barley Research (IIWBR), Karnal; E. Ratan Kumar, Executive Director, Central Bank of India; Suresh Kumar Singh, Zonal Head, Chandigarh Zone; Mahaveer Prasad Meena, Regional Head, Karnal Region; and Shobharam Sou,

Branch Head, Karnal.

Addressing the gathering, E Ratan Kumar emphasised the bank’s dedication to strengthening the agriculture sector and promoting financial inclusion. He highlighted the importance of Re-KYC compliance, social security schemes, e-KYC adoption, and informed customers about various banking products including Cent Agri Gold Loan, Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF), Cent Agri Cluster Rice Mill Scheme, PM Kusum Scheme, and Cent Kisaan Vahan Scheme.

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE to the general public that I, Ashish Mathur, resident of C2D/49B, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058, has lost/misplaced 2 property documents pertaining to my DDA house. 1.DDA Possession Letter & 2. NOC for Electricity and Water Connection. The documents were misplaced about. 25.05.2026. The documents could not be traced despite efforts. A FIR No. 339263/2026 has been lodged at Janakpuri Police Station on 31.05.2026. If anyone finds these documents, kindly return to the address mentioned above.
Ashish Mathur/Mobile: +91 9899936596
Email id:-mathurashish82@gmail.com

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Selling on e-Procurement
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website - www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE

On behalf of The President of India, Sr.Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer Secunderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad invites open tenders for the following works through e-Procurement of the tenders.

S.No.: 01 Tender No. & Date: C_SG_36_606 Dt:04/06/2026 Closing dt:26/06/2026 **Name of the work :** SCHEDULE - A Signalling & Telecommunication arrangements for shifting of Signalling cables at proposed construction of Limited Subway Br No. 217A at SKZR yard at Km No. 202/33-35 SCHEDULE B 1. Signalling & Telecommunication arrangements in view of BPO-ASAF Sec:Prov safety fencing along the track for speed 130kmph and above using NHAI anti-crash barrier/W-beam steel Fence for 107.40 Km. 2. Signalling & Telecommunication arrangements in view of ASAF-PTKP Sec:Pro safety fencing along the track for speed 130kmph and above using NHAI anti-crash barrier/W-beam steel fencing for 114.22 Km 3. Signalling & Telecommunication arrangements in view of PTKP-KZJ Sec: Pro safety fencing along the track for speed 130kmph and above using NHAI anti-crash barrier / W-beam steel fencing for 105.68km 4. Signalling & Telecommunication arrangements in view of KZJ-MLMG Sec: Prop.safety fencing along the track for speed 130kmph and above using NHAI anti-crash barrier / W-beam steel fencing for 116.78 Km **Approx Value (₹): 2,65,01,970.68 Bld security/EMD (₹): 530000.00**
For further details visit the website www.ireps.gov.in.
Sr.Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer/Secunderabad

TENDER NOTICE NO: 10/2026 Dt:05.06.2026 SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS e-Procurement Tender Notice
The Following Tenders Have Been Posted Online and Interested Parties Requested To Visit The Website www.ireps.gov.in And Submit their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Submitted Manually Will Not Be Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing Time Is 14.30 Hrs Of The Due Date Of The Tender. "For All Indigenous Offers, EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System As Available On www.ireps.gov.in."

Tender No.	Brief Description
31261200	One Coach Set of Air Spring
76261005	Manual Metal Arc Welding Electrode Size 4.00x350mm
LY265085A	Track Measuring System for Surveying Railroad Geometry Model Track Scan
54255016	Supply, installation & Commissioning of Desktop PC i3
54265003	Set of Safety Nuts for Ground Connection 220mm
93261031	Compreg Plywood Slat Size 12x1220x2850mm
81261419	Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG)
33261616B	TPE Spring pad
33261138	Gateway Bridge Mounting Bolt
38262361	Load sensing device VTA for BLC
LH257456A	Supply, installation Of FRP MODULAR Toilet
LH265782	Bogie Frame Assembly
66266272	Procurement of DEUTZ Make Spares for TM
33261092	Primary Vertical Damper
38265015	Constant Contact side bearer
38262185	SNUBBER Springs for CASNUB 22HS
38262191	Air Brake Hose Coupling support
66266285	Procurement of HARSCO Make Spares for TM
60266003	1 in 8.5 T/O PSC Sleepers to T-9841
38262294	POHKIT for D.V.KEO
66265845	Procurement of Spares for TM

Note:-Due dates of Tender Opening:- SL.No.01 on dt.12.06.2026.SL.No. 02 on dt.23.06.2026. SL.No.03 dt.24.06.2026. SL.No.04 on dt.25.06.2026. SL.No.05 to 09 on dt.29.06.2026. SL.No.10 on dt.30.06.2026 SL.No.11 on dt.01.07.2026. SL.No.12 to 16 on dt.02.07.2026 SL.No.17 on dt.03.07.2026. SL.No.18 to 20 on dt.07.07.2026. SL.No.21 on dt.13.07.2026
Corrigendum
1) Tender Notice No.05/2026 dt. 01.05.2026 Tender No.6026PT018 due on 01.06.2026 may be read as Due Dt. 15.06.2026.
2) Tender Notice No.07/2026 dt. 15.05.2026 Tender No.67255011A due on 05.06.2026 may be read as Due Dt. 18.06.2026.
Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having Value Above Rs.50 Lakhs:-
For Details, Please Visit Railway Website Above.
Principal Chief Materials A416 Manager/Secunderabad
For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

Israeli strikes kill Lebanese officers after ceasefire

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beirut

Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon on Saturday killed nine people, including three members of the Lebanese military, the Lebanese army and state media said, days after the two sides reached a new ceasefire deal.

An airstrike on a vehicle on a road linking the city of Nabatiyeh with the town of Marjayoun killed a brigadier general, a captain and another soldier, the army said, without immediately releasing their names.

Another airstrike on the southern village of Saksakiyah killed six people and wounded four, the state-run National News Agency said. "The continued, deliber-



ate, and repeated Israeli aggression against Lebanon, its people and its army only strengthens our resolve, faith and determination," the army said in its statement.

It said Israel's attacks aim to thwart all efforts "to reach a solution that would restore stability, establish a comprehensive ceasefire and lead to the Israeli withdrawal from the occupied Lebanese territories." The Israeli military confirmed hitting a vehicle and said the incident is being reviewed. The statement added that the vehicle was "moving suspiciously" toward Israeli soldiers near the village of Kfar Tibnit, after the military received "concrete indications" that Hezbollah would direct fire toward

Israeli soldiers from the same area. The military said that it operates against Hezbollah and not against the Lebanese army. Lebanon's President Joseph Aoun called the strike "a flagrant violation of Lebanese sovereignty and international law."

He said it came in the context of "ongoing escalation that threatens stability and security in the south (of Lebanon), despite the efforts Lebanon is exerting in the Washington negotiations to put an end to the ongoing Israeli attacks without a deterrent."

The latest ceasefire announced in Washington came about through US-brokered talks between Israel and Lebanon's Government,

which accuses Hezbollah of dragging the country into war and had made efforts to disarm it before the latest hostilities. Hezbollah has refused the truce. On Friday, Aoun and Lebanon's prime minister criticised Iran for opposing the latest ceasefire deal between the Lebanese Government and Israel, saying their country should not be used by Tehran as a "bargaining chip" in its talks with Washington.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi responded in a post on X on Saturday by saying that after Aoun's comments, "one would think it's Iran that has occupied a fifth of Lebanon, displaced a quarter of Lebanese and is bombing his country on a

daily basis." "Had Lebanon been a bargaining chip for Iran, we'd have a deal long ago. Save Lebanon from your real foe, Mr President," Araghchi said in reference to Israel.

The war began on March 2, when Hezbollah fired rockets at northern Israel, two days after Israel and the US began their attacks on Iran.

Israel has since launched a ground invasion of Lebanon and carried out wide attacks that have displaced more than 1 million people.

Israeli troops have seized around a fifth of Lebanon, pushing further into the country's south than at any time since the end of Israel's 1982-2000 occupation.

Iran fires missiles at Bahrain, Kuwait; attacks intercepted

SAMY MAGDY/
MICHELLE L PRICE
■ Cairo

Bahrain's Government said Saturday that Iran fired ballistic missiles and drones towards it and Kuwait. The foreign ministry said they had been intercepted and called on Iran to immediately cease attacks on its Gulf neighbours.

The statement came hours after the US military said it shot down Iranian ballistic missiles and drones launched toward the Strait of Hormuz and Gulf Arab allies on Friday, while striking some of the Islamic Republic's coastal surveillance radar sites in response, an exchange of fire that

further frayed a shaky ceasefire with Tehran.

The exchange of strikes comes as the Trump administration ramps up pressure on Iran to make a deal to end the conflict. US Central Command said on social media Friday night that Iran fired seven ballistic missiles toward Kuwait and Bahrain, with US forces intercepting six of the missiles and a seventh failing to reach its target. The military said there were no reports of harm to US personnel.

The ballistic missiles were fired after the US earlier in the day shot down four Iranian drones that were launched toward the Strait of Hormuz. "The attack drones posed an immediate



threat to regional maritime traffic," US Central Command said on social media.

Kuwait's military said forces were intercepting missiles and drones attacking the country, while Bahrain activated air raid sirens and told residents to move to the nearest safe location and follow official instructions.

Iran's Revolutionary

Guard said it targeted the Ali Al Salem airbase, which hosts US forces in Kuwait, and the US Navy's 5th Fleet in the tiny Gulf island nation of Bahrain, according to the State-run IRNA news agency.

The US military is enforcing a blockade on Iranian ports in response to Tehran's chokehold on the crucial corridor for global oil and natural gas shipments,

which has sent energy prices spiking and posed political problems for President Donald Trump's Republican Party ahead of the midterm congressional elections.

US Central Command said it hit the radar sites, including an island in the strait, "to defend against further attacks." It was the latest in back-and-forth attacks that have strained the tenuous ceasefire in the war and efforts to reach a deal to extend that truce.

Earlier this week, Iranian drones heavily damaged a passenger terminal at Kuwait's main airport, killing one person, wounding dozens and briefly closing the airfield. (AP)

Nepal PM urges BIMSTEC to tackle climate change together

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah has called for stronger cooperation among member states of the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation to build economic opportunities and tackle climate change and natural disasters.

In a statement issued on Saturday, he also stressed enhancing connectivity in transport, trade and digital networks to foster deeper integration of economies.

The Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) is a regional organisation that focuses on economic growth, technological collaboration and connectivity among countries dependent on or adjacent to the



Bay of Bengal. It has seven members — Bangladesh, Thailand, Nepal, Sri Lanka, India, Bhutan and Myanmar. On the occasion of the 29th anniversary of BIMSTEC, the statement issued by Nepal's

Foreign Office said, "He (Balendra Shah) underscored the importance of enhancing connectivity in transport, trade and digital networks to foster deeper integration of economies." (PTI)

Kosovo heads to third election in 18 months amid impasse

ZANA CIMILI
■ Pristina

Kosovo will hold its third parliamentary election in 18 months this weekend as frustration grows over a continued political impasse in the small Balkan country that is aspiring to move closer to the European Union and NATO.

The early parliamentary vote on Sunday was scheduled after Kosovo's main political parties failed to agree on who should replace former President Vjosa Osmani, whose mandate ended in late March.

Prime Minister Albin Kurti's centre-left Vetevendosje party has held a clear parliamentary majority since the early election in December. But the president in Kosovo is appointed by at least 80 lawmakers in the 120-member Parliament, a majority that neither Kurti



nor the opposition could muster. While the key players blamed each other for the crisis, their inability to reach a compromise has fuelled disappointment among Kosovo's around 2 million voters, who want the government to focus on the economy and living standards instead.

Vlora Kryeziu, a businessperson from the capital Pristina, laments that "the same scenario is being repeated." "We will for sure have the same result," Kryeziu, 52, said. (AP)

Not about Sikhism: UK MPs in renewed appeal over offensive weapon murder

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The murder conviction of a British Sikh man who attempted a religious defence for the weapon he used to stab a teenager to death continues to cause tensions in the UK, with Downing Street and parliamentarians among those renewing appeals on Saturday.

Vickrum Digwa, 23, was sentenced to life imprisonment after a jury found him



guilty of stabbing 18-year-old Henry Nowak to death.

While British Prime Minister Keir Starmer's spokesperson condemned "people trying to interfere in our democracy and seeking to stir up division on our streets" following

the conviction, British Sikh MPs issued a joint statement to stress that the murder was "not about Sikhism."

"The Downing Street intervention followed US Vice President JD Vance's social media re-post of a video depicting police body-worn camera footage that showed the victim being handcuffed by police over Digwa's racism allegations in his final moments during the attack last

December. Vance's post blamed the "mass invasion of migrants, many of whom despise the West and the people who love it" for the murder. "The Nowak family are grieving after Henry's horrific murder."

They have said they do not want his death to be used to create further division, hatred or tension. We should be respecting their wishes," Starmer's spokesperson said, alluding to the post. (PTI)

Traders face big losses after Uganda closes Congo border over Ebola contagion fears

RODNEY MUHUMUZA
■ Mpondwe

Leah Masika was on the verge of tears as she thought of her valuable consignment of plantain stuck in a long convoy of trucks on both sides of the Uganda-Congo border. Her cargo, destined for Uganda, was starting to leak water, and would go bad within hours if there was no movement.

The Ugandan trader was awaiting clearance from authorities for trucks to pass through the Mpondwe border post on Thursday after they were prevented from entering or leaving Uganda as part of escalating measures to prevent cross-border Ebola contagion. "Our things are here rotting," she said. On May 28, about two weeks after Congo declared an outbreak



of Ebola in the eastern Ituri province, Uganda closed its western border in a decision that reflected growing fears of cross-border contagion. Exceptions were made only in emergency cases, including for the outbreak response, humanitarian, cargo or security reasons. (AP)

Mango hits US as Seattle consulate imports Indian varieties



YOSHITA SINGH
■ New York/Seattle

Indian mangoes are taking US cities by storm, with Americans devouring popular varieties of the fruit and wanting more, as the Consulate General of India in Seattle hosted a special event that highlighted the potential for exports and consumption of the 'king of fruits' by connoisseurs in the US Pacific Northwest region.

The Consulate General of India in Seattle hosted the second edition of 'Mango Magic: Promotion and Tasting Event of Indian Mangoes'.

Over 100 leading importers of Indian fruits, including senior leadership of US retail giants like Costco participated in the event. They also relished the opportunity to taste seven premium varieties of Indian mangoes on display, including Alphonso from Maharashtra, Banganapalle and Himayat from Andhra Pradesh, Langra and Dussehri and Ripe Rajapuri from Gujarat. (PTI)



Ukraine strikes Russia again after Putin rejects peace talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ St Petersburg

Residents of St Petersburg were told not to leave their homes after a large-scale Ukrainian drone attack targeted Russia's second-largest city on Saturday morning, underscoring Kyiv's growing ability to hit deep inside Russia.

The attack came a day after Russian President Vladimir Putin refused an offer to meet his Ukrainian counterpart.

St Petersburg Governor Alexander Beglov advised the residents not to go outside and warned of possible disruptions to mobile internet service, while regional Governor Alexander Drozdenko said 141 drones were shot down over the surrounding Leningrad region.

Russia's Defence Ministry said its air defences shot down 376 Ukrainian drones.

"Last night, our drones covered a distance of about 1,000 kilometres to the St Petersburg region — to the enemy navy's arsenals and a base in Kronstadt," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on X.

Although no casualties were immediately reported, the renewed attack on St Petersburg is the latest embarrassing blow to Putin's efforts to cast the conflict as a distant event that doesn't affect Russian daily life.

A Ukrainian drone strike set ablaze an oil terminal in the city and hit a nearby naval base on Wednesday, hours before the opening of the St Petersburg International Economic



Forum, Putin's annual showcase for investment.

Speaking at the forum, Putin said Thursday that Russia will strengthen its air defences to counter recent Ukrainian drone attacks, which have reached deep inside his country and cast a cloud over the event in his hometown of St Petersburg.

Putin on Friday rejected a proposal by Zelenskyy for a face-to-face meeting on the 4-year-old conflict, saying he sees "no point" in it.

Thursday's letter, the first public message Zelenskyy has written directly to Putin since Russia sent troops into Ukraine in 2022, was a sweeping critique of the Russian leader's 26 years in power, as well as some taunts about his age.

Responding to Putin's dismissal of the proposed meeting, Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said Saturday that things would "only get worse for Russia." "Failures will get more humil-

iating," he wrote on X, warning that there are "no safe places in Russia that can be exempt" from Ukrainian long-range attacks, and that the intensity of attacks "will continue to grow."

With the front line barely moving as swarms of drones hinder advances, both sides have sought an edge by launching long-range strikes.

In Ukraine, one person was killed and three wounded overnight into Saturday in the Dnipropetrovsk region, as Russian forces struck three districts nearly 30 times with drones and artillery, regional head Oleksandr Hanzha said. In Zaporizhzhia, seven people sought medical care after a Russian drone strike started a fire at a parking lot, according to regional head Ivan Fedorov.

Russia targeted Ukraine overnight with 272 strike drones, and air defences shot down 249 of them, the Ukrainian air force said on Saturday.

Armenia prepares for election

YURAS KARMANAU/
KATIE MARIE DAVIES
■ Yerevan

Armenia's parliamentary elections Sunday will be a vote on its geopolitical future as incumbent Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan seeks closer relations with the European Union and the United States despite longstanding ties with Russia that have been championed by his critics.

Many analysts favour Pashinyan's Civil Contract party to retain control of the parliament, but with many opposition parties running on pro-Russia platforms, the Caucasus nation's place on the international stage has been thrown into the spotlight. In the months



Nikol Pashinyan

ahead of the election, Russian President Vladimir Putin and other Russian officials have warned Armenia that joining the EU could come at the expense of massive economic damage by disrupting Armenian trade ties with Moscow and its allies.

"These are the first elections in Armenia's history where geopolitical orienta-

tion has become a decisive issue," Mikayel Zolyan, an analyst and former member of the Armenian Parliament, told The Associated Press from Yerevan. "Until now, Armenia has remained within Russia's sphere of influence, and this was taken for granted, but now, for the first time, this is being called into question."

Relations between Moscow and Armenia soured in 2023 after Azerbaijan took control of the entire Karabakh region. The mountainous region had been controlled for decades by ethnic Armenian forces backed by Armenia, part of a long conflict between the neighbouring countries. (AP)



Soldiers attend the Colonel's Review, the final rehearsal of the Trooping the Colour, the King's annual birthday parade at Horse Guards Parade in London

Argentina expands hantavirus probe, sends teams to test rats



ISABEL DEBRE
■ Buenos Aires

Argentina has said it is expanding its investigation into the origins of the hantavirus outbreak that struck an Atlantic cruise ship last month, sending scientists to trap and test rats in the western province of Mendoza while lab results are pending from the southernmost city of Ushuaia. Argentine authorities said biologists from the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention were joining the mission next week in Mendoza. The rare outbreak on the MV Hondius was caused by the Andes hantavirus, a disease carried by rodents endemic to Argentina and Chile and the only hantavirus thought to be able to spread between people in some cases.

Reconstructing the chain of transmission is difficult work, and Argentine authorities say it may never be possible to pinpoint exactly where the first known victims — a Dutch couple who died in April — contracted the virus before boarding the cruise in Ushuaia. But experts say getting to the bottom of the outbreak will offer valuable information about how the rare virus spread and carry important lessons for management of the disease.

As repatriated cruise passengers from more than 20 countries have disembarked and entered specialised quarantine centres, epidemiologists are examining the 11 confirmed hantavirus cases, including the schedules of the three people killed, to better understand the chain of transmission. (AP)

Pope Leo visits Spain amid growing political crisis



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Vatican City

Pope Leo XIV's trip to Spain will bring the American pontiff to a traditional centre of European Christianity, where the Catholic Church has a complex legacy and the Socialist-led Government is in the midst of a political crisis. Leo's weeklong visit begins Saturday in Madrid with a welcome by the country's Catholic monarchs, King Felipe VI and Queen Letizia. His first day ends with a prayer vigil with young people, many of whom will be witnessing their first pope on Spanish soil. In a

sign that the clergy sexual abuse crisis continues to overshadow papal trips, the Vatican confirmed late Friday that Leo would meet with survivors during his visit. The Spanish Catholic hierarchy is belatedly reckoning with decades of abuse and cover-up in the once-staunchly Catholic country. The visit, the first by a pope in 15 years, signals Leo is returning papal attention to Europe and its Christian roots. Pope Francis largely stayed away from the traditional centers of European Christianity in favour of smaller Catholic communities farther away.

India, China share two millennia of legacy of learning, dialogue: Indian Envoy

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Indian Ambassador to China Vikram Doraiswami has said mutual learning of languages and a dialogue of ideas over two millennia have been a defining feature of ties between the two countries.

Doraiswami, who took over as India's envoy to China last month, visited the Beijing Foreign Studies University (BFSU), where he delivered a lecture on Friday, and interacted with students and faculty members. BFSU, a premier institution for foreign languages in China, offers courses in 102 languages, including Tamil, Hindi, Bengali, Sanskrit and Urdu.

It recently added Punjabi to its list of courses.

The languages are taught primarily to Chinese students as well



Indian Ambassador to China Vikram Doraiswami

as diplomats and officials. Many of its students go on to work with Chinese foreign-language media organisations, including state radio and television services catering to overseas audiences.

During his lecture, Doraiswami, a fluent Mandarin speaker, highlighted how the study of languages, societies and a dialogue of ideas had been a defining feature of India-China engagement for more than two millennia.

"Citing examples from the Mauryan period to the modern era, he [Doraiswami] noted how exchanges between the world's two oldest continuous civilizations enriched both societies through the sharing of knowledge, philosophy, artistic traditions, technologies, and innovation," according to a post on X by

the Indian Embassy in Beijing. "He emphasised that such interactions historically generated mutual benefit and remained more important than ever as both countries undergo profound economic, technological and social transformation," it said.

It added, "The lecture also explored the remarkable changes taking place in India today and the need for deeper knowledge, academic engagement, and people-to-people exchanges to better understand each other's contemporary realities."

It was followed by an interactive session during which Doraiswami answered questions from students. During his visit, Doraiswami was briefed on the activities of the university by BFSU President Jia Wenjian.

Indian student in UK shortlisted for BAFTA Young Game Designers Award

HS RAO ■ London

An Indian student studying at a UK university has been shortlisted for a BAFTA Young Game Designers Award for a game exploring the life of a sweatshop worker in India.

D'Arcy Dhandu, a first-year student at the Department of Computer and Information Sciences at the University of Strathclyde in Glasgow, Scotland, has been nominated in the 15-18 years category for his creation, Maya.

The game follows the story of a young widow working long hours in a garment factory while raising a child and struggling with poverty.



The game uses a series of mini-scenes depicting both factory work and home life to highlight the pressures faced by the main character.

Professor Martin Halvey, Head of the Department of Computer and Information

Sciences at Strathclyde, said: "D'Arcy's nomination reflects both his creativity and ability to use game design to tell meaningful stories.

"The game's mechanics imitate real-life working conditions and give players a glimpse into Maya's reality. I wanted to create something people could feel emotionally connected to," D'Arcy said.

"You spend long days at a sewing machine and even the repetitive actions are designed to reflect the physical strain of that kind of work. People do not always think about those realities.

"I chose to set the game in India because I am Indian

myself and I felt I had the cultural understanding to tell the story," he said.

D'Arcy hopes to continue developing the project and added: "I started working on Maya when I was in S6 and I think it still needs more time. Six months of development is not very long in game design.

"I would like to become a full-time software engineer one day... Being part of the BAFTA competition can help me get a foot in the door of what is a very competitive industry," he said.

The winner's ceremony will be streamed on BAFTA's YouTube channel on Thursday, June 18. (PTI)

Imran Khan, wife deprived of rights, healthcare in jail, alleges KP Party

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Pakistan Government is denying legal and constitutional rights to the incarcerated former prime minister Imran Khan and his wife and depriving the couple of proper healthcare, his party unit in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province has alleged.

Khan, the founder of the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI), has been in jail since August 2023 in multiple cases while his wife, Bushra Bibi, was initially under house arrest and later sent to jail in May 2024. Shafi Jan, a PTI leader and also a minister in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, also told a press conference here on Friday, Khan and his wife were also not allowed to contact any of their relatives and party members.

Jan said that Khan had been suffering from an eye-related ailment for the past



four months, and his eyesight is yet to fully recover.

The couple were taken to a hospital late at night on Thursday for medical treatment in violation of jail regulations, he said at the press conference organised by Insaf Doctors Forum, the official representative body for healthcare professionals aligned with Khan's party, the PTI.

Three from Ahmadi community injured in firing in Pak's Punjab

M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Three young men of the Ahmadi minority community were critically injured when an unidentified gunman opened fire at its prominent place of worship in Punjab province of Pakistan, police said Saturday.

The incident took place at Ahmadi's worship place — Bait-ul-Aqsa — at the Ahmadiyya headquarters Rabwah, Chenab Nagar, some 175 kms from Lahore late on Friday evening.

According to police, the unidentified man came on a motorcycle at the Ahmadi worship place and opened indiscriminate fire on the people going to offer prayers.

Three young men were critically injured in the attack and were shifted to hospital, the police said, adding a case has been registered against the unidentified attacker.

Although Ahmadis consider themselves Muslims, Pakistan's Parliament in 1974 declared the community to be non-Muslims. A decade later, they were not just banned from calling themselves Muslims but were also barred from practising aspects of Islam. (PTI)



Indian companies pitch products, seek partnerships at mega tech trade event in Taiwan

ROOPALI DIXIT ■ Taipei

Indian electronics manufacturer Sahasra and software firm Zoho showcased their products and services at a major technology trade event in Taipei this week, as they sought to attract customers and partnerships in overseas markets.

While the event witnessed significant participation from Indian buyers, a handful of Indian companies also exhibited at COMPUTEX 2026, which featured a record 6,000 booths from 1,500 exhibitors representing 33 countries.

Sahasra Electronics, part of the Sahasra Group, displayed its microSD cards at the event.

The company said it received encouraging responses from customers from different markets. "We have customers in China, we have customers in the US, Europe



and the UK, so we are meeting customers here, and we are getting very, very good responses," said Ankur Dwivedi, strategic account manager at Sahasra.

The company said it was using the event to explore new partnerships, technology collaborations and potential joint ventures. "We are here to explore partnerships

in terms of customers and in terms of technology, innovation and joint venture kind of thing where we can participate and implement technologies in India also," Dwivedi said.

Zoho Corporation, which provides cloud-based business software and software-as-a-service applications, said Taiwan was

emerging as an important market for the company and that businesses in the region were increasingly engaging with its products.

"We are here in Taiwan because it is a growing market for us, it has good potential for Zoho," said Eng Kit Goh, market lead for Hong Kong, South Korea and Taiwan.

"There is a lot of opportunity for us in Taipei and Taiwan in general in terms of digital adoption, a lot of businesses are engaging with us," he said.

Zoho said India's growing reputation in software development and technology services had helped build trust among customers in Taiwan.

"People have recognised Indian expertise in terms of technology, in terms of software development, there is a trust as well," Goh said. Organisers said they hoped

to see greater participation from Indian companies in future editions of the exhibition as technology cooperation between the two sides continued to expand.

"We are extending a warm invitation to India's vibrant tech industry, encouraging stronger participation as the show continues to grow into one of the world's most influential platforms for AI and technology innovation," said James C F Huang, Chairman of the Taiwan External Trade Development Council.

Strategic partnerships in semiconductor manufacturing, AI infrastructure and electronics supply chains have strengthened India-Taiwan technology ties in recent years. While Taiwan provides technical expertise and manufacturing capabilities, India offers a large consumer market, raw

materials and a skilled workforce. Apart from exhibitors, Indian buyers were also present at the event in large numbers, looking for new products and business opportunities.

Abhishek Jain of Arihant Info Solutions, a technology company, said he was attending the annual event for the tenth time, adding that COMPUTEX remained an important platform for networking and identifying products for the Indian market.

"We have a lot of suppliers here, and we always come here to do some networking and look out for some new products which we can import from here and sell in India," Jain said.

He said Indian participation could grow further as the country's electronics manufacturing ecosystem develops. (PTI)

Praggnanandhaa first Indian to win Norway Chess title

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa scripted history as he became the first Indian to win the prestigious Norway Chess title with a final-round victory over Germany's Vincent Keymer here on Friday, completing a brilliant campaign in style.

Praggnanandhaa, who began the day in third place with 15 points, delivered when it mattered the most, securing a classical win worth three full points to finish on 18 points and clinch one of the most coveted trophies in elite chess.

In doing so, the 20-year-old Chennai player achieved a feat that had eluded even Indian chess legend Viswanathan Anand and reigning world champion D Gukesh among others, since the tournament's inception in 2013.

Competing in Norway Chess for only the second time, Praggnanandhaa endured a slow start in the elite six-player field before gathering momentum in the second half of the event.

His campaign was highlighted by a remarkable achievement — defeating seven-time Norway Chess champion and World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice in classical chess — a rare accomplishment that underlined his determination to bounce back from



the disappointment of an underwhelming Candidates Tournament in Paphos earlier this year.

As reigning world champion Gukesh fell out of contention in the closing stages, Praggnanandhaa ensured that India's challenge remained alive, ultimately carrying it all the way to the title.

The result was made possible after American Grandmaster Wesley So, who led the standings with 15.5 points heading into the final round, was held to a draw in his classical game against Alireza Firouzja,

sending their contest into an Armageddon tie-break.

That outcome opened the door for Praggnanandhaa, who knew that a classical victory over Keymer would propel him to the top of the standings and secure a landmark title.

Although Wesley So went on to win the Armageddon tie-break, the victory was worth only 1.5 points, taking his tally to 17 points — one short of Praggnanandhaa's winning total of 18.

Alireza, who had also entered the final round with title hopes, finished third with 15.5 points.

Meanwhile, Gukesh's disappointing campaign continued as his third appearance in the tournament ended without the breakthrough he had hoped for in a year when he is set to defend his world title against challenger Javokhir Sindarov.

In the final round, Carlsen, playing with the white pieces, defeated the 20-year-old Indian in a classical game to collect three full points. However, the victory was not enough to propel the Norwegian great into title contention, as he finished fifth in the standings with 13 points. (PTI)

BIGGEST WIN OF MY CAREER: PRAGGNANANDHAA

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

R Praggnanandhaa described his Norway Chess triumph as the biggest achievement of his career, emphasising that defeating some of the world's strongest players — including the great Magnus Carlsen — made the title particularly memorable.

He said the event's extraordinary strength, with one of the highest average ratings ever assembled in a tournament, added even greater weight to his victory.

Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to win Norway Chess since the tournament's inception in 2013, capping off a landmark campaign by defeating world No. 1 and seven-time champion Carlsen twice — a rare feat against one of the game's greatest players. His triumph came in an exceptionally strong field, with all six players in the 'Open' section rated above 2700 and Carlsen leading the pack at 2840, adding further lustre to the title. "I think this is like (the biggest win of my career)... also stronger in terms of like average rating. I think, because you have like some 2600s (rating) in Wijk Aan Zee (Tata Steel Chess tournament). But here it's just the top players," said Praggnanandhaa after his final-round win over Vincent Keymer, which took him to 18 points and held off challenges from USA's Wesley So and France's Alireza Firouzja.

"So, yeah, winning this is more special and also like adding to it, Magnus was there... also winning four (games) in a row. So, certainly this will come like top," said Praggnanandhaa, whose previous biggest triumph came at the 2025 Tata Steel Chess Tournament in Wijk Aan Zee, Netherlands. Even as Praggnanandhaa focused on his game against Keymer, his attention would have occasionally drifted to the other board, where So faced Alireza — a classical win for the American would have denied him the title. The draw in that encounter proved decisive, sending the match into an Armageddon tie-break, where So could only secure 1.5 points, sealing the championship for the Indian. "I was happy that like it (So vs Alireza match) was a draw and like, I mean, I just had to win, but still I had to win (against Keymer)," he said.

Praggnanandhaa said that after the initial setbacks in the tournament, nothing fundamentally changed in his

approach, which eventually led to four consecutive wins and helped him clinch the title. He added that a key adjustment was a conscious effort to avoid time trouble and play faster, more controlled chess throughout the run-in. "I don't, like I said, think there is anything particular I change, but this conscious effort of playing faster was certainly, I think, helped in my games. I had more time than my opponents in most of the games."

Looking ahead to the coming months, the young Indian Grandmaster said he plans to play fewer tournaments than last year to better manage his schedule and workload. However, he confirmed he will feature at the World Rapid Team Championship for Chess Gurukul, scheduled from June 16-22 in Hong Kong. "I mean, most of the players playing here are going to be there (for World Rapid and Blitz Team) and it's going to start in 10 days. But for now, I don't think I'll, I'll look at any chess for a bit." Asked whether defeating

Carlsen twice in the same tournament was a big deal, he said he was ultimately pleased to have won the event itself — especially considering it featured a player of the Norwegian's calibre. "Winning the (matches against Carlsen), I mean, he helped in winning the tournament, so it's still, I think every point counts here. Yeah, I mean, I'm overall happy that I managed to come back like this (from a poor start). For me, it's more special that I won a tournament, especially when Magnus is here." He said the Superbet Chess Classic Romania in Bucharest (May 14-23), from where he flew straight to Oslo for Norway Chess and arrived on

the eve of the tournament, had a positive impact as it served as valuable warm-up ahead of the challenge here. "I guess maybe like we were warmed up (for Norway Chess after playing in Bucharest)... So, like, I think we were looking forward to playing here.

So, yeah, maybe we were more warmed up, but I don't know." (PTI)



BRIEFLY

British WC power surge: Electricity spikes expected during matches



British energy officials say England and Scotland's group games at the World Cup could start a national electricity spike equivalent to the combined power needed for the northern England city of Leeds and Glasgow. An analysis by the National Energy System Operator released Saturday predicted that each of England and Scotland's games in the group stages of the World Cup could see national electricity usage increase by 600 megawatts. That is the equivalent of the total electricity demand for the cities of Leeds, with a population of about 812,000, and Glasgow, which has a population of 650,000 and is the largest city in Scotland. (AP)

Women's U18 Asia Cup: India clinch bronze with 3-0 win



The Indian hockey team won the bronze medal at the Women's U18 Asia Cup after registering a commanding 3-0 victory over Korea in the third-place match here on Saturday. Sandeepa Kumari (2'), captain Sweetie Kujur (16') and Nousheen Naz (33') were on target as India capped off their campaign with a podium finish. Determined to bounce back from their narrow shootout defeat against China in the semifinals, India made a dream start and took the lead within the opening two minutes. Sandeepa Kumari (2') showcased excellent composure, producing a brilliant finish to give India the breakthrough and set the tone for the contest. (PTI)

FIBA still planning Basketball World Cup in Qatar in 2027

TIM REYNOLDS ■ San Antonio (US)

FIBA is operating as if the 2027 Basketball World Cup will take place in Qatar as scheduled, though said Friday that it could adjust if the war in Iran or other matters force the sport's global governing body to take action.

"We have excellent partners in Qatar," FIBA's secretary general, Andreas Zagklis, said in a roundtable meeting with reporters while attending Game 2 of the NBA Finals between the San Antonio Spurs and New York Knicks.

"If things arrive at that spot, I'm sure we will have very good and direct conversations, and we'll find the best possible solution for the players and the fans."



worried at this point. The 32-team tournament is set to begin on August 27, 2027, and runs for about 2 1/2 weeks — all happening in Doha.

"We have a board meeting of the FIBA and the (local organizing committee) of the World Cup on Monday. I will get the latest updates," Zagklis said. "I can tell you that the organizing committee has

not stopped a single day. This is a project that has been made clear to us, by the highest levels of the government, is a project of national importance. And as you know, Qatar, since I think April 1, has not been affected, impacted by the hostilities."

There have been a series of US-Iran negotiations facilitated by countries in the Middle

East over the last few months, including Qatar.

The World Cup in Qatar would be the first time FIBA takes the event to the Arab world. And will be a direct qualifier for seven nations into the men's basketball tournament at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. The US is already qualified for LA28 as the host nation and will seek



players on the Iranian team were approved for visas and were in the process of receiving them. A second official said visas had been issued for players, coaches, trainers and some support staff. The offi-

cials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to discuss the visas publicly.

The second official could not say if any Iranian applicants had been denied. It

was not immediately clear when the Iranian team's passports would be returned to them to allow them to travel, but the official said it could be as early as Friday or Saturday. The squad has been

Iran's World Cup soccer team approved for visas to play games in US

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

Members of Iran's World Cup soccer team have been granted visas to the United States, two U.S. officials said, clearing them to enter the United States from their training base in Tijuana, Mexico, ahead of their first two matches near Los Angeles this month.

The team's participation in the World Cup has been complicated by Iran's war with Israel and the United States. Problems with processing visas had earlier led Iran to move its training base from Tucson, Arizona, to Tijuana, on Mexico's border with California.

One US official said all



earlier in the day. Ireland, which did not qualify for this year's World Cup, nearly scored a go-ahead goal but Crepeau deftly stopped a charge by Mason Melia in the 85th minute. He finished

with two saves.

Crepeau earned the job for the World Cup over Dayne St. Claire. Crepeau missed out on the 2022 World Cup in Qatar after breaking his leg while playing for LAFC in

the MLS Cup final.

Canada defeated Uzbekistan 2-0 in Edmonton, Alberta, on Monday. The team opens the World Cup on June 12 in Toronto in Group B against Bosnia and Herzegovina. They head to Vancouver to face Qatar on June 18 and Switzerland on June 24.

Canada remained without captain Alphonso Davies, who is still nursing a hamstring injury he sustained while playing for Bayern Munich. There is no timeline for his return. Canada coach Jesse Marsch started Luc de Fougerolles at center back, replacing Moise Bombito, who was seen icing his leg after getting subbed off after the first half against Uzbekistan. Bombito is returning from a fractured tibia.

Veer Ahlawat sets course record in second round of Swiss Challenge



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucerne (Switzerland)

Playing on an invitation, Veer Ahlawat set a course record in the second round of the Swiss Challenge on the Hotel Planner Tour, firing a stunning round of 10-under 61 to get into a share of the lead here. The 30-year-old Ahlawat shared the lead with 37-year-old Mathew Southgate (64) heading into the weekend.

Ahlawat and Southgate are at 12-under and both leaders went bogey free in the second round. They are one stroke ahead of George Bloor (66) and Mathieu Decottignies-Lafon (63).

Ahlawat, who came close to a win on the DP World Tour in 2024, when he finished runner-up at the Hero Indian Open, played on DP World Tour in 2025.

After failing to keep his card, he is dividing his time between the Hotel Planner Tour, DP World Tour and his home Tour, the DP World PGTI Tour, where he won the Order of Merit in 2024.

Ahlawat began his record setting round on the front nine and after making an early birdie on the second

hole he followed up with another pair on the third and fourth holes. He would pick up another stroke on the seventh hole to be 4-under par for the day before the turn. On the back nine Ahlawat was on fire and made six birdies on the trot starting from the 12th hole before making par on the 18th to finish the day with a card of 10-under par.

The other two Indian players in the field this week were Arjun Prasad and Saptak Talwar. Arjun Prasad had a total of even par (70-72) and Talwar shot 74-70 and missed the cut, which was set at 3-under par in what has been a low scoring week so far.

Ahlawat delighted to be in contention heading into the weekend after a mixed start to the season.

"I'm really pleased with my round. I had a really solid day out there; I struck the ball well and made some really good birdie putts. If it's as calm tomorrow as it was today, then it will be a low scoring day again."

"All parts of my game are feeling very solid right now," he added. "I'll treat tomorrow as a normal day and try to play it one shot at a time."

Shreyas replaces Suryakumar as India T20 captain

Sooryavanshi in for England, Ireland series; youngest-ever to make it to India team

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

Winds of change swept across India's T20I set-up as Shreyas Iyer on Saturday took over the captaincy from Suryakumar Yadav, and wonder kid Vaibhav Sooryavanshi found a place in the squad for the twin tour of Ireland and England. At 15 years and 71 days old, Sooryavanshi becomes the youngest ever player to feature in an Indian cricket team, surpassing the long-standing record held by the great Sachin Tendulkar. Tendulkar was 16 years and 205 days when he made his Test debut against Pakistan at Karachi on November 15, 1989. India will travel to Ireland for two T20Is (June 26 and 28), followed by a five-match T20I series against England between July 1 and 11. Shreyas has returned to the national T20 side for the first time after competing against Australia in Bengaluru on December 3, 2023. "With regards to Shreyas, we have seen what he has done over the last few years, leading different franchises," chief selector Ajit Agarkar told media after announcing the squads for various tours. "(He) won the final once, and from there a tougher season this year after a great start. We have

seen everything that a captain possibly can (handle). His own performances have been really good. "He was quite close to getting into the (T20) World Cup squad as well. With Surya still there, there was no room for him, so he is in my opinion a stand-out candidate with enough experience now having led in the T20 format; this is obviously a different challenge," Agarkar added. Shreyas' impressive leadership credentials in the IPL — leading KKR to title in 2024 and PBKS to final in 2025 — along with two seasons of consistent outings with the bat prompted the selectors to zero in on him to replace T20 World Cup 2026 winning captain Suryakumar. Suryakumar not just lost the captaincy but also his place in the squad. Agarkar said Suryakumar's dipping form over the last two seasons in some way dictated their decision to remove the Mumbaikar from the T20 captaincy, but it was not the only reason. "With regards to Surya, obviously it's a tough one having just won the (T20) World Cup. But as it happens after most World Cups, we try and reassess what your best way forward is," Agarkar said. "(It was due to) partly his own form but also looking at the next two-year



cycle, or a little bit more than two years now till the next World Cup, we thought this was the best way forward and like I said, Shreyas is a very deserving captain." "We deliberated on it a lot, especially when someone has led you to a World Cup win. It's not the easiest sort of discussion to have, but I don't necessarily think... at some stage, we were going to look at it. Now, whether IPL form dictated it; I'm not so sure that's the case. There were

always conversations around it," he added. **Tilak is new vice-captain:** Middle-order batter Tilak Varma will be Shreyas' deputy, while pacer Prince Yadav, who had an impressive season for Lucknow Super Giants, was drafted for the series against England and Ireland. Agarkar said Tilak can learn more about the job of leading a side while being the deputy to Shreyas, a clear indication of his growth in the white ball format as



a key member. **Bumrah to miss England, Ireland tour:** Lead pacer Jasprit Bumrah will miss the T20I series against England and Ireland, but he will come back for the Asian Games, to be held in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, from September 19 to October 4. "We know how important he is. Plus, (given) the WTC cycle, we've still got a chance to (qualify for the final) if we play well enough over these next nine Tests," Agarkar said. "If we can have Jasprit play

majority of those games and still keep him fit and healthy, it's always a thing. There's a lot of T20 cricket, you can always bring him back. (In the) Asian games, he will be there. The main aim is to try and keep him fit for the Test and the one-dayers," he added. All-rounder Hardik Pandya, who is in India's ODI squad for the series against Afghanistan later this month, could not find place in any of the teams. "Like Bumrah, if we can get him

playing well and keep him fit for one-day cricket — I do not think he has played one-day cricket for a while — and at this point that is the main objective," said Agarkar. All-rounder Harshit Rana too has returned to the India set-up after missing the whole of the IPL for Kolkata Knight Riders owing to an injury. **Squads:** **For Ireland and England T20 tours:** Shreyas Iyer (c), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Ishan Kishan, Shivam Dube, Tilak Varma (vc), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Varun Chakravarthy, Ravi Bishnoi, Mohammed Siraj, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. **For Asian Games:** Shreyas Iyer (c), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Ishan Kishan, Shivam Dube, Tilak Varma (vc), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Varun Chakravarthy, Ravi Bishnoi, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Jasprit Bumrah, and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. **For multi-day matches in Sri Lanka:** Dhruv Jurel (c&wk), Sai Sudharsan, Devdutt Padikal (vc), Ayush Pandey, Ruturaj Gaikwad, Harsh Dube, Saransh Jain, Gurnoor Brar, Aaquib Nabi, Yash Thakur, N Jagadeesan (wk), Aman Mokhadde, Shaik Rashid, Zeeshan Ansari. (PTI)

Injured Kohli replaced by Yashasvi in ODI series against Afghanistan

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

Star batter Virat Kohli will miss India's three-match ODI series against Afghanistan later this month after failing to recover from a hamstring injury, and the selectors on Saturday named Yashasvi Jaiswal as his replacement. The three ODIs will be played at Dharamsala, Lucknow and Chennai on June 13, 17 and 20 respectively. Kohli, who plays only one format after retiring from Test and T20, had suffered a hamstring injury during the recent IPL final between Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad. Kohli had made an unbeaten 75 to fire RCB to their second IPL title in a row. "With Virat, at this point, it's just been less than a week since he injured himself in the finals. We will assess him (but) we don't know the timelines yet," chief selector Ajit Agarkar told reporters during a press conference at the BCCI headquarters. "Yashasvi will be his replacement. But it looks like he (Kohli) might be fit for



that England one-day series (in July) but again, it's not a definitive answer. "So, don't hold me to it. I haven't had a clear timeline from the physio yet," Agarkar added. An all-format player for India, Jaiswal has only played four ODIs since making his debut against England in February 2025. The left-hander had scored a match-winning 116 — his maiden ODI ton — against South Africa at Visakhapatnam. Meanwhile, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said former skipper Rohit Sharma will be heading to the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru where all-rounder Hardik Pandya is nearing comple-

tion of his rehabilitation. "Hardik is in COE Bangalore. He is going to a rehabilitation programme and very soon he will go for the final phase (of recuperation) and will be in the process of clearance," Saikia said. Pandya has been named in the ODI squad to face Afghanistan but he was omitted from squads to tour Ireland and England, and for the Asian Games keeping his workload in the 50-over format in mind. Former skipper Rohit, who also now plays only the one-dayers, too suffered a hamstring injury during the IPL which restricted his appearances for Mumbai Indians to just nine matches this season. (PTI)

Rahul, Gill hammer tons in one-off Test against Afghanistan

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Mullanpur

KL Rahul's poise was matched by Shubman Gill's panache produced contrasting centuries as India's formidable batting line-up posted 368 for three in their bid to out-bat Afghanistan on the opening day of the one-off Test on Saturday. Rahul (100 off 165 balls) showed the value of defence while skipper Gill (103 batting off 143 balls) was intent-personified on a day when India decided to give a batting masterclass in Tests to an Afghanistan attack that was high on spirit but low on skill quotient. The manner in which Gill batted, it seemed like he was playing a practice game. The languid approach and the lazy elegance was on view as he held an already tired Afghan attack by the scruff of its neck, hitting 11 fours and a straight six. In his 41st Test, the Indian skipper now has 11 centuries. The one who would rue missing out on a three figure mark is Sai Sudharsan (81 off 104 balls) despite getting two reprieves while Rishabh Pant was happy smashing three effortless sixes en route his unbeaten half-century off just



70 balls. It is unlikely that India would bat more than a session and half on the second day before declaration and unleashing their spin troika on Afghanistan. The pitch has something for the slow bowlers and it will not be a surprise does not go full distance. For Afghanistan, Mohammad Saleem (2/67 in 13 overs) was their most successful one but the stand out fast bowler was Ziaur Rahman (1/61 in 15 overs) who troubled batters without much success.

In fact, he could have Rahul early had keeper Afsar Zazai appealed for a caught behind which the TV replays later confirmed. Once he got the lucky reprieve, Rahul was unflappable en route his 12th Test hundred. There were cover drives and signature on-drives and a beautiful straight drive in his 11 boundaries. Rahul was more intent on playing within himself and allowed Sudharsan to attack during their 139-run second wicket stand after Yashasvi Jaiswal (24) gifted his wicket

with an innocuous tickle down the leg-side during the first hour. In case of Sudharsan, he was dropped once in the slips of left-arm spinner Nangeyalia Kharote and then off Ziaur as the ball flew between keeper and first slip. Sudharsan looked comfortable against pacers while whipping them through mid-wicket and just when he was nearing his maiden Test century, he tried to play an expansive drive off an over-pitched delivery from Saleem to be nicely snapped by Zazai

behind stumps. Rahul, however was in no hurry as it took him 164 balls to get to his ton but off the next ball from Ziaur, he uppishly drove to give a catch to cover fielder. The Gill-Pant stand was the most entertaining of the day as they added 121 runs for the fourth wicket and left a bruised Afghan attack even more battered in the scorching North India heat. The short arm pull was a purists' delight and the cover drive had class written all over it. He and Pant ran the singles with ease as Afghanistan skipper Hashmatullah Shahidi spread the field in order to stop leaking boundaries. For Afghanistan, the problem was their spin attack. With their top three world class spinners choosing to be gun for hire in T20 leagues across the world, the ones picked for this game — left-arm spinner Kharote (0/95 in 20 overs) and off-spinner Abdul Malik (0/37 in 6 overs) simply didn't have the skills to stop the Indian batters. They didn't go on a carnage but yet found ways to hit boundaries with alarming frequency with 42 fours and 4 sixes hit on the day. (PTI)

Minakshi, Deepak to lead India at World Boxing Cup (Stage 2)

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

World Number 1 Minakshi and seasoned campaigner Deepak will spearhead India's challenge at the World Boxing Cup 2026 (Stage 2), scheduled to take place in Guiyang, China, from June 15 to 21. This is a second-string Indian team comprising boxers who finished as runners-up in the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games trials. India enters the tournament on the back of an impressive run in the previous World Cup cycle, where the



team consistently secured multiple medals across stages and delivered a strong overall tally in the finals, underlining its growing stature on the global stage. The Boxing Federation of India (BFI) has named a well-rounded squad featuring blend of established performers and emerging talent across both men's, women's categories.

Prathamesh accepts 2-year ban for three whereabouts failures: ITA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Asian Games compound team event gold winner archer Prathamesh Jawkar has accepted a two-year ban for three whereabouts failures last year, the International Testing Agency (ITA) said. Prathamesh, a part of the 2022 Asian Games compound team gold winning trio that includes Ojas Pravin Deotale and Abhishek Verma, committed three



whereabouts failures within a 12-month period. He was not named in the 12-member Indian archery squad for the Asian Games in Japan in September-October.

"The ITA reports that archer Prathamesh Samadhan Jawkar has agreed to the consequences imposed for his ADRV under Article 2.4 of the WA anti-doping rules," the ITA, which looks after anti-doping-related matters on behalf of World Archery, said in a statement. The athlete did not challenge the ADRV and agreed with the consequences proposed by the ITA. Accordingly, the case was resolved via an acceptance of consequences.

Shreyas: The detached leader T20 setup needs

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Perhaps no other cricketer has gone through so much turbulence and transformation between December 3, 2023 and June 6, 2026 as Shreyas Iyer, who took over the reins of India's T20 team from Suryakumar Yadav on Saturday. Shreyas' is an extraordinary story, as it's tough for an Indian cricketer to survive a 30-month hiatus, particularly in the shortest format where talents are jostling for a space, and make a comeback, let alone as captain. So, what has the 31-year-old done in that interim to



impress the Ajit Agarkar-led selection panel and head coach Gautam Gambhir? It has to be his single-minded dedication to claw back from setbacks and create an upward moving career curve. It took him nearly a year to

Shreyas was looking at a bleak future after losing his BCCI central contract, along with Jharkhand's Ishan Kishan, in February 2024 for skipping domestic matches for Mumbai that season. It took him nearly a year to

earn the contract back, and also had to go through rejections from India squads for major events like the T20 World Cup (2024, 2026) and Asia Cup (2025). But he never sulked or vented his frustration through social media, rather focused on working on his batting and recovery from certain injuries that forced him to seek a break from red-ball cricket last year. **Ties with Gambhir:** The first sign of his revival came when he led Kolkata Knight Riders to their third IPL title in 2024, working alongside team mentor Gambhir. It might also have given the former India opener a

chance to take a closer look at Shreyas' mindset and thinking. Even before that, it was Gambhir who recommended Shreyas as his successor when he stepped down from Delhi Capitals' (then Daredevils) captaincy midway through the IPL 2018. So, the social media speculations about his muted relationship with Shreyas could remain just that. But in the last two years, the Mumbai man too has matured a lot as an individual and as a cricketer, and now he would certainly know how to set aside his personal choices for the larger good of the team. (PTI)

Bumrah, Hardik to be preserved for longer formats: Agarkar

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

The national selection panel on Saturday did not include premier pacer Jasprit Bumrah and all-rounder Hardik Pandya in the squads to tour Ireland and England in a strong indication that the wisemen are largely reserving their services for Tests and ODIs respectively in the coming season. Bumrah and Pandya were a shadow of themselves in the recent IPL 2026 for Mumbai Indians after being on the field since late last year playing several T20 games, including a triumphant campaign in the World Cup, warranting a careful handling of the duo. Bumrah will return to action during the Asian Games to be held from September 17 to October 3, but chief selector Ajit Agarkar made it clear that the pacer will be used more in longer formats. "Yeah, and also one-day World Cup, like T20 (format) was in the last World Cup...we know how important he is," Agarkar replied when he was asked if Bumrah was being preserved for Test assignments. "The WTC cycle...we've still got a chance to (qualify for the final) if we play well enough over these next nine



Tests, if we can have Jasprit play majority of those games and still keep him fit and healthy, it's always a (great) thing," he added. India are set to tour Sri Lanka and New Zealand for two Tests each before taking on Australia in a five-match series at home, which would determine their qualification for the final of the 2025-2027 World Test Championship cycle. The Shubman Gill-led side is languishing at the sixth spot behind Bangladesh in the table and they will require Bumrah firing from all cylinders to revive the campaign. "There's a lot of T20 cricket, you can always bring him back. (In the) Asian Games, he will be there. The main aim is to try and keep him fit for the Test and the one-dayers," Agarkar said. The former India pacer said "worry" was not the right word for India's current posi-

tion in the WTC table but said he would like to see the team do better. "I don't know whether worry is the right word. I think (the) England (tour) was good and the South African series probably didn't go to plan. But, we still have a chance (to reach the final) if we play well enough and we know we've got the players but, we've got to play better," he said. Unlike Bumrah, Pandya's chances of returning to the T20 establishment looks slimmer as Agarkar made it clear that he will be used more in the 50-over format. "He is a part of the one-day squad right now in (the) Afghanistan (series). Like Bumrah, if we can get him playing well and keep him fit for one-day cricket — I don't think he's played one-day cricket for a while — that is, at this point, the main objective," said Agarkar. (PTI)



THE AIM IS TO SHARE THE CALMING, TACTILE POWER OF CLAY WITH ONE THOUSAND PEOPLE

Poetry in Pottery

Every art form has a stage. Pottery lost its. What happens when an ancient craft has nowhere left to stand?

SAKSHI PRIYA

Why do people say that plunging bare hands into wet earth is the best form of therapy? There is a sharp, startling feeling when skin presses into cold mud. The clay we throw today holds thousands of years of history, yet we live in an age of glass screens and non-stop notifications. We always hear people call the wheel a form of therapy, and researchers actually see the proof happening in real time.

Kneading wet earth actively drops cortisol levels in the brain. It triggers the vagus nerve, telling an exhausted, panicked nervous system to simply power down and find real quiet. All the while, the concrete of our growing cities keeps paving over our heritage spaces. The gifted creators who spent their lives keeping our history alive are left dealing with a forced silence, losing the physical spaces they need to practise their craft. In response, shaping mud feels like an act of preservation. The wheel asks an exhausted

brain to finally sit still, tying us to our roots and anchoring us in the present. This need for physical reality pulses vividly through *Potters' Hub*, a collaborative workspace tucked away in Gurgaon. Conceived by Ranu Kawatra and later joined by Shantanu Prakash, a ceramicist with nearly twenty years of dedication to the wheel, the studio operates as a twenty-four-hour safe space. Built purely for the love of the craft, it functions as a shared haven where creators mould their lives around art.

Knowing the calming effect of the wheel, the duo launched a community mission to help one thousand everyday people touch clay. The sight inside is genuinely moving: corporate professionals tentatively shaping their very first, wonderfully lopsided teapots. In a few months, nearly nine hundred individuals have stepped up to the wheel, discovering the joy of unguided creation. Shantanu even uses this tactile medium to guide corporate leaders through complex problem-solving.

The romance of the studio quickly gives way to a rigorous, fascinating science. The earth sets its own timeline, making the crafting of a single ceramic vessel a three-week lesson in waiting. Raw material must be wedged heavily to push out air bubbles before it is centred on the wheel. A freshly formed bowl must sit untouched for five days to dry. During the

initial bisque firing, the kiln burns at a thousand degrees Celsius for twelve hours. The mud hardens into a porous shell. After a slow cooling period, the piece gets a delicate coat of glaze before braving a second firing, where heat melts earthy compounds into a glass finish. Working with clay teaches you very quickly that the material sets the schedule, because pushing the mud too hard on the wheel causes the wet walls to slump right into a messy puddle, and cutting corners during the drying phase means the intense heat of the kiln will crack your work into pieces. The payoff for all that required patience hits you the moment you open the door and pull out a glossy ceramic bowl where a grey block of dirt used to be, and holding a heavy coffee cup that you built from scratch gives you a very specific kind of pride that makes the long wait entirely worth it.

To shape clay is to give a physical voice to gifted creators who currently have zero stage left to stand on. Sinking your hands into the mud remains a beautifully defiant act, a lasting reminder of the grace found in slowing down, coaxing life from a humble void, and understanding the true poetry in pottery.

POTTERY PASSION

Handcrafted ceramic bowls showcase the beauty of pottery, where simple clay is transformed through skill, creativity and firing into functional works of art.

Participants immerse themselves in the tactile art of pottery, shaping clay by hand during a creative workshop that blends craftsmanship, mindfulness and self-expression, transforming simple earth into unique art.

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

ART CORNER

Grey holds stories

SAKSHI PRIYA

We have spent centuries looking at classical art and expecting female strength to look a certain way. We search for tired hands or perfectly straight backs to tell us a story of survival. But a woman's internal world rarely fits into neat black and white boxes. The real story always happens in the subtle grey areas.

Aalekh Arts & Culture Foundation steps right into that space, working to preserve and rethink our diverse artistic traditions. Walking into their latest presentation, *Shades of Grey*, you immediately notice a shift in how these stories are told. Fresh from a run at Bangalore's Sabha Gallery, artist Divyaman Singh completely abandons the human figure. He leans entirely on abstract horizons

to map out memory and quiet endurance. It makes you stop and stare. Take *Edge of Silence*, where a pale cliff cuts through heavy shadow, serving as a brilliant metaphor for standing firm against erosion. *Quiet Grief* handles sorrow differently, not as a sudden, dramatic break, but as a slow, quiet pull. He completely avoids bright palettes, leaning hard into thick textures and quiet greys to capture the things we usually leave unsaid.

The exploration continues beautifully through *Threads Beneath Silence*, where delicate, intersecting lines weave an invisible web of responsibility and layered memory. Similarly, *Unspoken Calm* offers a horizon of gentle greys, capturing those necessary

moments of inward withdrawal and quiet introspection away from external expectations. Then out of nowhere, a sharp streak of crimson in *Ember Between Horizons* breaks the quiet, reminding us that real fire often burns right beneath a calm surface.

Foundation founder Rennie Joyy sees this exploration of the spaces between binaries as a necessary, shared conversation. Working the oil directly into the canvas with his own hands and palette knives, Singh maps out an inner reality you cannot actually see. The entire collection hits hard, leaving you with a very clear realisation — an artist does not need to paint a physical face to make you feel something real.

DIVYAMAN SINGH'S TEXTURED GREYS QUIETLY REVEAL HIDDEN STRENGTH, MEMORY AND INNER FIRE — AN INTIMATE MAP OF ENDURANCE BENEATH CALM SURFACES

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Century in rhythm

SAKSHI PRIYA

What does it take to keep something this old from disappearing? For over twenty years, Aayam quietly ensured Bharatanatyam's classical movements survived. When modern society often leaves traditional creators with no stage left to stand on, preserving heritage remains vital. Masters frequently face a forced silence, yet their work ensured the intricate visual geometry of Guru KN Dandayudhapani Pillai continued to

breathe. Handed down through KN Dakshinamoorthy to Guru Sindhu Mishra, this rich history took the spotlight once again.

What happens when over one hundred dancers step onto a stage carrying the weight of centuries? They turn a space into a living, breathing classroom for Nrityadhara 3: A celebration of learning, lineage and Bharatanatyam. How do three dancers capture years of quiet discipline in a single moment? Apoorva Bhatnagar, Satakshi Gupta, and Vibhooti Bhardwaj walked out and showed everyone exactly how. These senior disciples began with an effervescent *Ananda Nartana Ganapatim Bhavaye*, pulling the entire room into a space of deep devotion. Soon after, the youngest beginners

offered sincere prayers to Lord Shiva in *Angikam Bhuvanam*, while the junior students followed closely behind, executing sharp footwork in *Mushak Vaahan*, a pushpanjali dedicated to Lord Ganesha. The intermediate students then tackled a *Jatiswaram* in Ragamalika set to Misra Chapu tala, mastering the heavy footwork and landing on every single musical beat with total control. Holding hundreds of people completely spellbound without speaking a single syllable requires absolute mastery. Not everyone can hold a room without saying a word. Arundhati Chakravarty can. Her take on a flustered Yashoda, totally fed up with Krishna's mischief in *Krishna Nee Begane Baro*, had the whole room laughing. Then the mood took a sharp turn. Tanusha Tyagi stepped up with a powerful padam, "Tan Chhar Byal Kapal Bhushan," a rare excerpt from the Ramcharitmanas. Playing a ter-

nified mother, Maena, she reacted to Shiva's terrifying band of ghosts at his wedding, showing genuine desperation to save her daughter Parvati from the match. You could feel every ounce of that intense emotion in the room. The evening also brought fresh courage to the floor, with adult beginners making their stage debut to the well-known *Shri Ramchandra Kripalu Bhajamana*. Seeing them up there proved it's never too late to start. Finally, the senior batch wrapped up the night with a stunning Thillana set to Paras raga and Adi tala. They mapped out intricate, rapid footwork with intense, energetic pacing. Guru Sindhu Mishra has built a space where discipline, devotion, and creativity converge perfectly. Watching these students from different generations share the stage proves that classical traditions will continue to thrive loudly, filling the room with a vibrant, living energy.

CINEMA

BADNAM BASTI

A Film by Prem Kapoor

JOSE

TEAM VIVA

Love extends beyond labels and with June, it's the perfect time to celebrate these different forms of love through the intersection where pride meets plot. For years, screens mostly framed queer stories as tragedies. But pride is not about tragedies. It's a beautiful celebration of living proudly. Long before this global movement, Indian cinema quietly delivered *Badnam Basti*, a bisexual romance completely free of shame, labels, or punishment.

While we absolutely need raw, unflinching mirrors like the *Guatemalan* drama *José* to show how hard surviving a conservative society can be and still crave the quiet, sun soaked heartbreak of *Call Me By Your Name*, Queer cinema refuses a cycle of sorrow. Surviving represents the opening act; we deserve a life we claim as our own. Look at *The Birdcage* — it radiates pure, glorious chaos. Anything's Possible is just a girl falling for a boy, the world not ending and somehow that simplicity feels like the most radical thing cinema has offered in years. Queer lives get to be funny, messy, and wonderfully unremarkable too. This June, give joy the same seat at the table as sorrow, because love in all its beautiful mess has never belonged to anyone but the people living it.

PRIDE FILLS THE SCREEN



The soul of Rajasthan

Ancient desert melodies, folk artists, and vintage photographs breathe life into Rajasthan's enduring cultural soul

TEAM VIVA

Long before it became a recorded track, "Padharo Mhare Des" served as the ultimate invitation to the sands of Rajasthan. Rooted in centuries of desert hospitality, the phrase grew into a massive cultural symbol under the leadership of Lalit K Panwar. By 2011, Gauri R Yadwadkar wanted to put all that history on record. She managed to get musical giants like Jagjit Singh and Pandit Vishwa Mohan Bhatt into one room to work together. They shared one clear objective. They wanted to take all that welcoming heritage and turn it directly into music.

Years later, this same melody filled the India International Centre, and sitting in that audience was a real privilege. You could hear raw devotion in every single string plucked. Young artists from the Manganiyar and Langa communities took the floor, filling the room with incredibly moving live music. Their

traditional instruments played loudly, pushing back against the forced silence that so often threatens ancient folk traditions. Through the Arpan Music Lab, these gifted creators finally have a stage left to stand on.

A visual exhibition anchored the music perfectly. The space featured an exclusive edit of photographs by Sudhir Kasliwal. For sixty years, Kasliwal has been pointing his lens at everyday life across the state, and his portraits tell a very raw story. Hearing those young voices hit sharp, clear notes while standing surrounded by decades of local history gave the room an undeniable energy. Led by singer Manesha A Agarwal, the gathering merged vintage photography with live folk music, showing exactly how these invaluable heritage expressions hold their ground in a modern world.

CULTURAL HERITAGE PRESERVED THROUGH MUSIC, PHOTOGRAPHY, AND COMMUNITY ARTISTRY

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

The Pioneer AGENDA

“Success is not final,
failure is not fatal: it is
the courage to continue
that counts.”
– Winston Churchill

The Shah Factor

Amit Shah is perhaps one of the most revered yet controversial figures in contemporary Indian politics. Known for his clarity of vision and unwavering commitment to his objectives, he has often attracted criticism for his distinctive working style. Yet, many of the decisions he has pursued have required a firm hand and strong resolve to achieve their intended goals. Inspired by his political ideal, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Shah has sought to bring the same determination and administrative acumen to the Ministry of Home Affairs, earning an enviable reputation as a devoted follower of the Iron Man of India



ANOOP BOSE

October 22, 2018 marked a most fateful milestone in India's long trackless journey. India's Prime Minister Narendra Damodardas Modi proudly unveiled the "Statue of Unity" as a monumental ode to independent India's first Home Minister Bharat Ratna Sardar Vallabhbhai Jhaverbhai Patel (popularly known as the "Iron Man of India") on the solemn occasion of his 143rd birth anniversary at Kevadiya, ensconced on the banks of the holy river Narmada, facing the sprawling concrete gravity Sardar Sarovar Dam (set in motion by Modi on 17th September, 2017 to commemorate his 67th birthday!), southeast of Vadodara. The steel and bronze cast statue, masterfully chiselled by the internationally acclaimed sculptor Padma Bhushan Ram Vanji Sutar, turned out to be a breathtaking engineering marvel that cost ₹2,989 crores, weighed 130,000 tonnes and rose to a height of 182 metres, making it the tallest statue in the world bearing twice the height of New York's iconic copper-clad Statue of Liberty! In his awe inspiring speech, surcharged with unbridled emotion, Modi paid an effusive, glowing personal tribute to Sardar, "This statue is not only a token of respect for his strength and dedication, but is also an expression of New India's new self-confidence." The benign, unobtrusive presence of India's longest serving 32nd Home Minister Amithbhai Anilchandra Shah, the second most powerful personage in the country who proudly dons the coveted mantle of the mighty Sardar and is hailed far and wide as his true reincarnation, lent a very special flavour to the august event. Not to be outdone by Modi's historic inauguration, Shah unfurled an 11 foot tall, 1,100 kg statue of Sardar on December 8, 2024 in Jodhpur. In his impassioned address, Shah asserted in ringing tones that Sardar was "a page of history to which history and the nation both failed to do justice...the truth cannot be suppressed and will eventually shine like the sun at the right time."

Shah was propitiously born on October 22, 1964, at approximately 05:25 a.m. IST, into an affluent Gujarati family ensconced in Bombay (now Mumbai) when the astronomical skies were marked by a Full Moon in its Waning Gibbous phase, with about 97.8% illumination. His father, Anilchandra Shah, belonged to the prominent "Nagar Seth" family of Mansa, a quaint city belonging to a former princely state in Gandhinagar, and owned and operated a successful PVC pipe business. His mother Kusumben was deeply rooted in Gandhian ideals and instilled in him a sense of fierce patriotism and strict discipline from a very early age. He spent his childhood in Mansa and studied in the prestigious Sheth C. M. High School in Mansa until the age of 16.

Upon completion of his school education, his family shifted to Ahmedabad. Thereafter, he studied biochemistry at the premier CU Shah Science College in Ahmedabad. He graduated with a

Bachelor's of Science (B.Sc.) in biochemistry and then joined his father's business, working simultaneously as a stockbroker and in co-operative banks in Ahmedabad. Shah's political indoctrination began at an impressionable age. At the age of 13, he pasted posters for Maniben Patel, the indefatigably Gandhian daughter of Sardar, in the 1977 general election in which she contested and won the Mehsana Lok Sabha seat. And at 16, he voluntarily joined the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), founded in Nagpur on September 27, 1925 by the noted physician Dr. Keshav Baliram Hedgewar. After joining the RSS, Shah got closely associated with the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the student wing of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He transitioned to the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha, the BJP's youth wing, in 1987. During these years, Shah actively participated in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement,

He is an ardent fan of cricket and also enjoys playing chess. He is an avid reader, with a particular interest in history, and a movie buff

which vigorously campaigned for a temple to be built on the site of the Babri Masjid, believed by Hindus worldwide to be the exact birthplace of Lord Rama, the seventh avatar of Lord Vishnu, aptly described by Swami Vivekananda as "the ancient idol of the heroic ages, the embodiment of truth, of morality...and, above all, the ideal king". Shah also participated in the "Ekta Yatra", a rally that commenced on December 11, 1991 to advance the cause of the movement. On December 6, 1992, the Babri Masjid ceased to exist. On November 19, 2019, a landmark judgement of the Hon'ble Supreme Court of India, entrusted the site exclusively to Hindus and directed the state to grant an alternate site in Ayodhya to Muslims. The grand, colossal Ram Mandir was later built on the hallowed site and formally inaugurated by Modi in a historic "Pran Pratishtha" ceremony on January 22, 2024. Shah could not physically attend the event due to compelling reasons, but was present in spirit as he watched the live telecast from Ayodhya while offering prayers at the famed Sri Laxmi Narayan Temple (Birla Mandir) in New Delhi, inaugurated by Mahatma Gandhi on March 12, 1939.

In the 1990s, the BJP began to democratically wrest power from the Indian National Congress in Gujarat. Shah was the lynchpin during this era of state politics and helped broaden the party's membership base. In 1997, Shah fought an election for the first time, winning a by-election from the Sarkhej constituency and becoming a member of the state's legislative assembly. He retained his seat in the assembly elections of 1998, and the party formed a government led by Keshubhai Patel. Shah assumed office as the Vice President of



THE IMMEASURABLE REINCARNATION OF SARDAR PATEL, THE IRON MAN OF INDIA

the party in 1999. On October 7, 2001, the BJP's national leadership scrupulously replaced Patel as the Chief Minister of Gujarat with Modi. On February 27, 2002, the ill-fated S-6 coach of the Sabarmati Express carrying Hindu pilgrims was deliberately set on fire by a violent mob near the Godhra railway station, incinerating 59 innocent passengers, including a 16-day-old baby. This triggered widespread communal violence marked by destruction and bloodshed. On July 19, 2002, Modi voluntarily resigned as the Chief Minister purely on moral grounds. Snap assembly elections ensued in December, 2002, and the BJP emerged triumphant again. Modi resumed his Chief

Ministership, which he continued uninterrupted for 12 years. On February 8, 2012, a Supreme Court-appointed Special Investigation Team (SIT) filed a closure report citing "no prosecutable evidence" against Modi in the Godhra upheaval. This clean chit was eventually upheld in a definitive June 24, 2002 Supreme Court ruling. After the 2002 elections, Shah was made a minister in the Modi government and held multiple portfolios, including the key department of home affairs.

On July 25, 2010, Shah was arrested by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and slapped with serious charges in the Sohrabuddin Sheikh case, at the vengeful instance of his vicious rival

P.Chidambaram, the then Home Minister. Shah was given bail after three months in prison but was barred from entering Gujarat for two years.

On September 27, 2012, the Supreme Court allowed him to return to Gujarat, and he won the state assembly elections that year from the Naranpura constituency. On December 30, 2014, the Special CBI Court discharged him due to a lack of evidence. Shah was exonerated by the Supreme Court on August 1, 2016, when it dismissed a petition challenging his discharge. During these turbulent days of trial and testing for Shah, his long standing and faithful "foul weather friend" Tushar Mehta, presently India's redoubtable Solicitor General, stood behind him like a Rock of Gibraltar imbued with his razor sharp intellect and incredible legal acumen!

On September 13, 2013, the BJP's central leadership picked Modi as the Prime Ministerial candidate ahead of the 2014 general election. Following in the footsteps of Modi, Shah shifted his political locus from Gujarat to New Delhi. He was appointed General Secretary of the party on March 13, 2013 and given overall charge of the poll strategy for the "Gateway to Delhi" state of Uttar Pradesh. The BJP won the election with an outright majority of 282 seats. The victory was powered by the party's unprecedented win in 71 of Uttar Pradesh's 80 seats, thanks to Shah's superlative mastery of electoral strategy and management. Modi became the Prime Minister on May 26, 2014, and Shah was elected the party's National President on July 9, 2014. On August 19, 2017, Shah was elected to the Rajya Sabha. Two years later, he won the Lok Sabha seat from Gandhinagar. The BJP returned to power with an overwhelming mandate of 303 seats, and Modi remained unshackled as the Prime Minister. Shah had played a stellar strategic role in the BJP's sweeping election juggernaut. On May 30, 2019, he was made the Home Minister in the second Modi government.

Shah retained the post in Modi's third term after the BJP won the general election on June 4, 2024 and formed the government on June 9, 2024. As the Home Minister, Shah deftly oversaw two of the most far reaching political changes made by the Modi government viz. the abrogation of Article 370 of the Constitution, and an amendment to the Citizenship Act.

Article 370, an antiquated, superfluous provision that gave the Muslim majority state of Jammu & Kashmir special status and a high degree of internal autonomy, was effectively revoked on August 5, 2019. At the same time, Jammu & Kashmir was downgraded from statehood and reorganized into two distinct and separate union territories: Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh. The Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), passed by Parliament on December 11, 2019, provided a fast-tracked pathway to Indian citizenship to persecuted religious minorities from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan.

I am highly emboldened to chronicle three singular achievements of Shah in recent times viz. his steadfastly emancipating India, after three years of sustained, intensive anti-Maoist operations, from the scourge of Naxalism that had plagued India since the armed ultra-left Naxalbari uprising in 1967 in April, 2026, his tireless striving that enabled the BJP to trounce the autocratic, corruption-ridden All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) party in the last assembly election in West Bengal under the valiant stewardship of Modi in a landslide mandate in May, 2026 that brought into its kitty a rich harvest of 208 assembly seats and his assiduously herculean effort in June, 2026 to secure India's long porous borders with Pakistan and Bangladesh from illegal immigration.

Significantly, Shah, working in close unison with Modi, is dealing a death blow to the twin dangers of global terrorism and cross border infiltration that hang heavily over our heads like the Sword of Damocles.

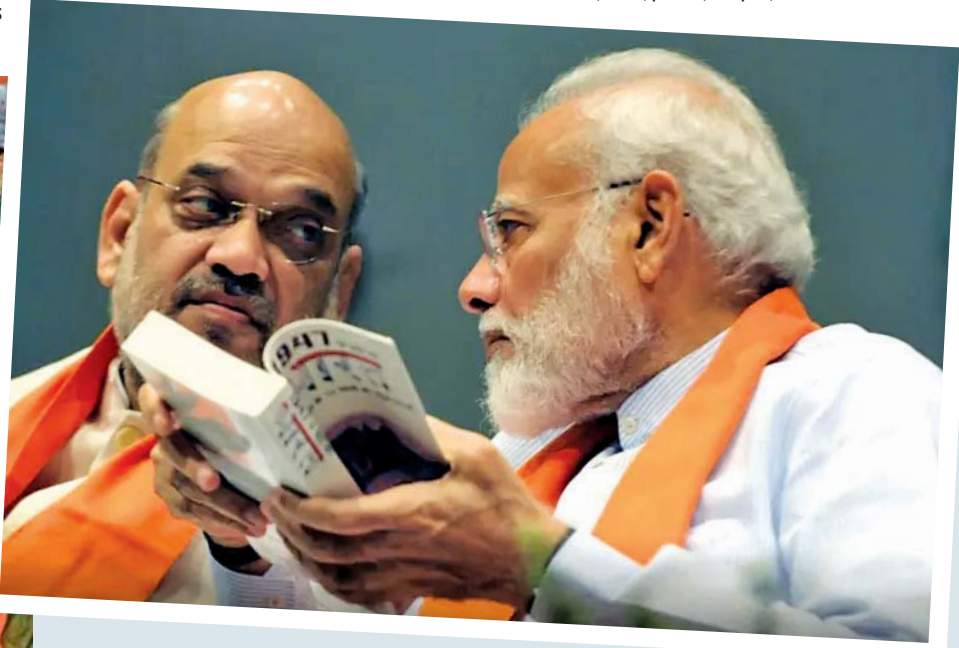
The relationship between Modi and Shah is an undefinable one. Their multifarious fans and admirers laud the duo as the "two wheels of a car" and compare them to the brothers Rama,

In the 1990s, the BJP began to democratically wrest power from the Indian National Congress in Gujarat. Shah was the lynchpin during this era of state politics

representing the "Paramatma", and Lakshmana, representing the "Jivatma", in an utopian Ram Rajya. Modi and Shah are inextricably attached to each other and undoubtedly share an indestructible bond of affection, respect, trust and frankness akin to the special relationship that existed between the legendary Indian saint and mystic Ramakrishna Parmahansa Dev and his noble disciple Swami Vivekananda. Shah is popularly feted as a modern-day Chanakya because of his extraordinary skills as a political guru, master strategist and decisive administrator. He is an ardent fan of cricket and also enjoys playing chess. He is an avid reader, with a particular interest in history, and a movie buff. He also revels in music, with a particular appreciation for Indian classical music and regional folk genres. Shah and his devoted spirited wife, Sonal Shah, have a son Jay Shah, who is a cricket administrator and businessman, and presently the Chairman of the International Cricket Council (ICC).

Shah's invincible ebullient spirit, unceasing vigilance, piercing perception, omnipotent gaze, delightful sense of humour and mesmerising oratorical skills give him a truly monolithic character. The Indian people are justly proud of him and are superbly confident of his unassailable courage and integrity and his tenacious adherence to noble grassroots principles and intense dedication to the path of high endeavour.

The author is an internationally reputed senior lawyer practising in the Supreme Court of India and various High Courts and Tribunals in India. He is an avid debater, public speaker, writer, broadcaster, telecaster, artist, painter, sculptor, music critic and filmmaker



As the Home Minister, Shah deftly oversaw two of the most far reaching political changes made by the Modi government viz. the abrogation of Article 370 of the Constitution, and an amendment to the Citizenship Act



What India and Nepal debate often misses

Civilisational ties and territorial sovereignty are not contradictory but complementary

Prime Minister Balendra Shah's recent remarks in Nepal's Parliament on the India-Nepal boundary issue have generated considerable debate. Yet much of the discussion has focused on individual words rather than the larger significance of what was said.

At its core, the Prime Minister's message reflected an important reality: territorial concerns and civilisational ties are not competing ideas. A mature state is capable of safeguarding both.

By asserting Nepal's concerns regarding the Kalapani area while acknowledging the deep cultural and familial ties that bind Nepal and India, he highlighted a truth often lost in contemporary discourse—that sovereignty and coexistence can advance together. Recognizing shared lives and livelihoods across the border is not a denial of national interest; it is an acknowledgment of reality.

India-Nepal relations cannot be viewed solely through the prism of maps and boundaries. Unlike many international borders, the India-Nepal border has evolved within a landscape of shared communities. It is shaped not only by treaties and political agreements but also by rivers, forests, mountains, and settlements whose lives have been intertwined for generations.

The relationship is rooted in centuries of shared civilizational ties, roti-beti sambandh, pilgrimage routes, and philosophical traditions that have been preserved and nurtured across generations.

Families exist across the border. In the Terai, communities share language, culture, and kinship through Maithili, Bhojpuri, and Awadhi traditions. In eastern Nepal, long-standing connections link communities with Sikkim, Assam, and West Bengal. In the Far West, these ties with Uttarakhand remain intertwined. Literature, folklore, and everyday life remain testimony to a relationship that has never been confined by geography alone.

In many parts of the frontier, an Indian child may attend a Nepali school because it is closer than the one on the Indian side. A Nepali youth may cross the border daily for work and return home each evening. Communities trade together, celebrate together, and often share family ties through generations of cross-border marriages.

These realities do not weaken sovereignty. They explain why Nepal-India relations require a degree of sensitivity and understanding that goes beyond conventional border politics.

The challenge today is that issues requiring patient dialogue, technical expertise, and sustained groundwork are often overshadowed by narratives designed for temporary



NAVITA SRIKANTH

political gain. Across South Asia, it is easier to manufacture outrage than to undertake the difficult work of negotiation. It is easier to amplify differences than to acknowledge interdependence. Differences between neighbours are natural, particularly where geography, history, and human settlement have evolved together

over centuries. What should concern us is not the existence of differences, but the growing tendency to interpret every disagreement through the lens of mistrust. No boundary issue between neighbours has ever been resolved through social media campaigns, emotional slogans, or competing nationalist narratives. Durable solutions emerge through dialogue, trust, political courage, and institutional mechanisms.

Prime Minister Shah's remarks are significant precisely because they suggest that national interest and constructive engagement can coexist. A leader can firmly assert a country's position while simultaneously recognizing the human realities that shape bilateral relations.

THIS CIVILISATIONAL CONTEXT DOES NOT ELIMINATE THE NEED FOR BOUNDARY DEMARCATION OR PROTECTING NATIONAL INTERESTS. IT PROVIDES THE TRUST NECESSARY TO ADDRESS DIFFICULT QUESTIONS THROUGH DIALOGUE RATHER THAN CONFRONTATION

Personal Reflections

During my time working at Singha Durbar, I often spent mornings at Pashupatinath Temple reflecting on the civilizational ties that bind Nepal and India. Conversations with scholars on Pashupatinath, Kedarnath, and Kailash Mansarovar reinforced a simple realization: the Himalayas have long connected peoples, traditions, and pilgrimages across present-day political boundaries.

The same realization emerged while travelling through Mithila Parikrama and the Ramayana Circuit, the Mithila Parikrama, one encounters a living cultural landscape that predates modern borders. Sita Maa or Prince Siddharth's journey cannot be reduced to a territorial claim. These remain shared inheritances of a civilization.

This civilisational context does not eliminate the need for boundary demarcation or protecting national interests. It provides the trust necessary to address difficult questions through dialogue rather than confrontation.

Rabi Lamichhane in Delhi

The recent visit to India by the Nepali delegation led by Shri Rabi Lamichhane, former Deputy Prime Minister and President of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, reflected the continued importance both countries attach to engagement at the highest levels. Meetings with Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, National Security Advisor Shri Ajit Doval, External Affairs Minister Dr S. Jaishankar, Home Minister Shri Amit Shah, senior officials and political leadership underscored a simple truth: sustained dialogue remains the most credible pathway for advancing holistic cooperation.

The significance of such engagement lies not merely in protocol but in its purpose. The real test of leadership is not whether differences exist; it is whether leaders possess the confidence and statesmanship to ensure that those differences do not define the relationship.

Conclusion

The India-Nepal border is shaped by both history and geography. Rivers alter their course, settlements evolve, and patterns of cultivation change. Boundary management therefore requires continuous cooperation, political commitment, and mutual trust. In a region where borders have often reflected the legacies of external historical forces, India and Nepal have an opportunity to demonstrate that enduring neighbourly relations are built through sovereign dialogue, shared interests, and an unwavering commitment to each other's stability, prosperity, and dignity.

Today, social media appears more interested in winning arguments than understanding the essence of Prime Minister Shah's statement or India's engagement with Shri Rabi Lamichhane. People on both sides are dissecting words and optics while overlooking a larger truth: two countries sharing centuries of civilisational, cultural, and familial ties possess a unique reservoir of trust. Shared civilization does not eliminate the need for boundary management; it provides the foundation for dialogue and lasting solutions. As someone who has lived, worked, travelled, prayed, and learned across Nepal, I cannot accept that a relationship shaped by the Himalayas, Darshan Shastra, and countless human connections should be reduced to competing narratives.

No matter how many provocative statements emerge, or how much facts are twisted into conjecture, the ship must sail through.

Shared civilisational ethos gives leaders what treaties alone cannot — Trust, the most valuable currency of diplomacy.

The Himalayas may define our geography, but it is trust that will define our future.

(The author is a financial, geopolitical, security analyst and an India-Nepal Relations Observer)

Laos pledges all-out offensive against cyber scam networks



ASHOKE RAJ

As cybercrime syndicates spread across Southeast Asia and increasingly target Indian citizens, Laos has vowed a tougher crackdown on transnational scam centres that have evolved into one of the world's most lucrative criminal enterprises.

In an exclusive interaction with *The Pioneer* during his official visit to India, Laos Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Thongsavan Phomvihane said dismantling cyber-scram operations and human trafficking networks has become one of his government's highest priorities, amid growing international concern over the rapid expansion of organised crime groups across the region.

"Scam centres are a challenge for Laos and other countries. It is a priority to tackle them. Our government is actively battling them," Phomvihane said, stressing that Laos is working closely with neighbouring countries to disrupt criminal syndicates operating across borders.

His remarks come at a time when India is grappling with a rising number of citizens being lured into cyber-fraud operations based in parts of Southeast Asia, particularly Laos, Myanmar and Cambodia. Many victims are recruited through fake job advertisements and fraudulent employment agencies promising lucrative overseas careers. Instead, they find themselves trapped in heavily guarded scam compounds and forced to participate in online fraud schemes targeting victims worldwide.

According to information provided by the Government of India in Parliament, cybercrime networks have increasingly exploited social media platforms and recruitment channels to lure Indians abroad. Once transported to scam hubs, many are allegedly coerced into conducting online investment frauds, romance scams, cryptocurrency scams and other digital crimes.

In response, Indian missions in Laos, Cambodia and Myanmar have stepped up rescue and repatriation efforts. New Delhi has repeatedly raised the issue with host governments while embassies continue to coordinate with local authorities, immigration agencies and law-enforcement bodies to secure the release and return of affected citizens.

The challenge facing governments across the region has become even more complex following a recent warning from the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), which says criminal groups originating in East and Southeast Asia are rapidly expanding beyond their traditional bases.

In a major report released this year, the UN agency warned that organised crime syndicates behind large-scale online scam operations are increasingly relocating from traditional hotspots such as Cambodia, Laos, Myanmar and the Philippines to newer destinations across Asia and other regions of the world. According to the report, criminal networks are adopting what investigators describe as a "hedging strategy" — expanding into multiple jurisdictions simultaneously to protect their operations from law-enforcement crackdowns.

The agency noted that whenever authorities dismantle scam compounds in one country, criminal operators frequently relocate, rebuild and resume operations elsewhere, exploiting weak governance systems, porous borders and regulatory loopholes.

UNODC estimates that hundreds of industrial-scale scam centres across the region generate nearly US\$40 billion annually. These operations increasingly rely on cryptocurrencies, underground banking networks and sophisticated money-laundering systems that allow illicit profits to move rapidly through the global financial system.



The report warns that cyber-enabled fraud and illicit financial networks have evolved into a highly organized transnational industry capable of undermining governance, fuelling corruption and weakening state institutions in vulnerable countries. Against this backdrop, Laos is seeking deeper regional cooperation to tackle both cybercrime and human trafficking linked to scam compounds. Phomvihane said joint operations involving neighbouring countries have produced encouraging results and underlined the importance of sustained coordination among governments, law-enforcement agencies and international organizations. Security concerns, however, were only one part of the minister's visit to India.

The trip comes as India and Laos celebrate the 70th anniversary of diplomatic relations and marks the first visit by a Lao foreign minister to India in more than a decade.

During talks with External Affairs Minister Dr S. Jaishankar, both sides reviewed cooperation in areas ranging from development partnerships and capacity building to healthcare, pharmaceuticals, connectivity and cultural exchanges.

Phomvihane highlighted the deep civilisational links between the two countries, pointing particularly to their shared Ramayana heritage, which continues to serve as an enduring cultural bridge between India and Laos.

INDIA'S RESCUE OPERATIONS

CAMBODIA: 44 Indians rescued in 2022; 207 in 2023; 982 in 2024; 1,300 in 2025.

LAO PDR: 74 rescued in 2022; 244 in 2023; 558 in 2024; 1,421 in 2025.

MYANMAR: 338 rescued in 2022; 89 in 2023; 147 in 2024; 1,594 in 2025.

He also praised India's role in preserving Laos' cultural heritage, especially through the restoration of the UNESCO-listed Vat Phou temple complex. The project is widely regarded as one of India's most successful cultural diplomacy initiatives in Southeast Asia. The Lao minister also welcomed India's Quick Impact Projects under the Mekong-Ganga Cooperation framework, which have supported community-development initiatives across Laos.

He expressed interest in expanding cooperation in pharmaceuticals and healthcare. Yet the shadow of cybercrime loomed large over discussions surrounding regional security. For India, the issue is no longer simply a matter of online fraud. It increasingly intersects with human trafficking, organized crime, money laundering and national security concerns. For countries such as Laos, the challenge lies in preventing criminal syndicates from exploiting geographical vulnerabilities and cross-border networks.

As governments across Southeast Asia intensify efforts to dismantle scam compounds, experts caution that isolated crackdowns will not be enough. Without sustained intelligence-sharing, coordinated enforcement operations and stronger international cooperation, criminal groups may simply shift locations and continue operating under new identities.

The convergence of Laos' renewed enforcement push and the UNODC's warning serves as a reminder that cyber-scram networks are no longer a regional problem. They have evolved into a global criminal industry-one that increasingly demands a global response.

The writer is an Associate Editor (Foreign Affairs) at *The Pioneer*

Unveiling ancient feminism: Challenging incursion into ancient Indian literature

Due to our cultural coding about women in ancient times, the negative statements about them in Manusmriti and Kamasutra rise to the surface. However, its important to know another side to such texts which focuses on women's economic wisdom and innate intellect. Mukul Kumar's book *Women in the Womb of Time, Unveiling Ancient Feminism* is a bold and challenging incursion into ancient Indian literature, including the gaps, silences and misrepresentations that have surrounded the women figures in our long legacy. From this complex book, I wish to isolate three factors that have impressed me the most.

First that it is a male writer who is investigating feminism, both ancient and modern, with a deep sense of commitment to getting at the truth of the heritage. I say this because an unfortunate divide has occurred over time with feminism being identified with a

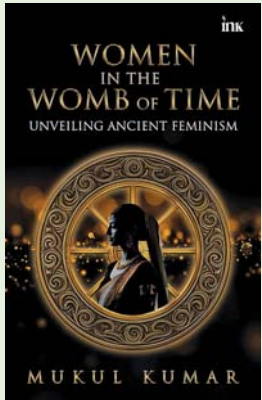


MALASHRI LAL

texts and arguing cogently that women in ancient India had a status of equality, dignity, and self-hood. He does this without denigrating the men or blaming society in any simplistic manner. For instance, when he speaks of a character such as Ahalya, he raises the question of ambiguity in the story, which traditionally blames Ahalya for infidelity, but does not see the deceit of Indra and the frustrating ascetic husband, Gautama. This is only one example of how Mukul successfully enters the intelligent and acute mind of women characters who have been marginalised or wrongly blamed for decisions they have taken.

shrill and aggressive mode of protest and masculinity has often been interpreted through the gender lens of physical form. Mukul Kumar has a far more nuanced and comprehensive view in discussing both women and men through well-known

My second point is an appreciation of Mukul Kumar's scholarly, textual research. This impresses me as a recognition of a cultural legacy that originates in the Ardhanareeshwar concept that is the female and male conjoined and not separate, coexisting not competing, mutually supportive, and not disruptive. I agree with Mukul Kumar's overall summation that feminism in India derives from an ancient legacy of gender equality, whereas the much later western feminist movement is grounded in oppositional gender viewpoints. The chapter on Manusmriti is a masterpiece as this is a controversial text where the grammar of Sanskrit has an important role to play. "In a feminist interpretation of Manusmriti, we have to take cogni-



Title: Women in the Womb of Time: Unveiling Ancient Feminism
Author: Mukul Kumar
MRP: ₹799
Publisher: BluOne Ink

right to leave a husband who abuses her" (135). To understand how pertinent these directions are, even now, we just have to see the newspaper every day,

and read the discussions on sex-workers and domestic violence. Both single as well as married women continue to be vulnerable and seek protection under law. These are small examples that I give of the deep analytical thesis presented by the author.

My third point is about the practical uses of this book on ancient feminism. At last, a contemporary scholar has undertaken a rational study of the early period within the large framework of not only the texts but also sculpture and numismatics or the study of coins, thereby widening the scope of reference whereby women are presented in a complex social system. Women are not just wives, daughters, mothers, and householders, but they also impact the economics and the sociology of their times. Moreover, by presenting them as change agents, Mukul Kumar elevates the status of women from blindly submissive creatures to intelligent people who direct the thinking of their contemporaries and the younger generation. Mukul is not denying the existence of patriarchy, but modifying our approach to it by showing the func-

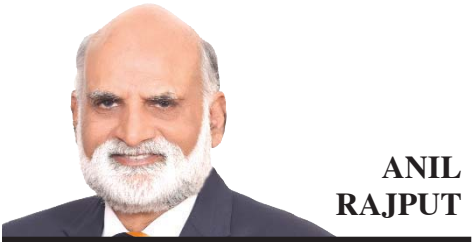
tioning of women within the scope of their circumstances as active participants in the history of India.

I conclude by appreciating the implied contrast that the book presents between Indian feminism and western feminism, something that I have tried to instil in my classroom teaching and in my books. I return to the image that has always guided me and that is of the equal partnership of women and men as the ideal relationship from ancient India until now. By contrast, Western feminism is far more recent and derives from a competitive idea of man versus woman. Hence the vocabulary and the critical stance is entirely different. This book brings the required gravity and scholarly underpinning to the conjectures about equality in the Indian tradition, and holds up the flag for the early emergence of Feminism in India.

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MASIK KARTHIGAI

Renewing faith under the Krittika Star



ANIL
RAJPUT

Masik Karthigai, especially revered in Tamil religious tradition, is a monthly Hindu observance dedicated primarily to Lord Murugan, also known as Kartikeya, the deity of courage, wisdom and spiritual attainment. Observed each month on the day when the Krittika, or Karthigai, Nakshatra prevails, the occasion is regarded as an auspicious time for offering prayers and seeking divine guidance. Devotees visit Murugan temples, offer prayers, light lamps, recite sacred hymns and observe fasting or dietary restrictions according to local customs. While less elaborate than the annual Karthigai Deepam festival, Masik Karthigai serves as a recurring spiritual reminder of the triumph of wisdom over ignorance, devotion over ego and righteous conduct over dishonesty.

The significance of Masik Karthigai is rooted in ancient Hindu traditions surrounding the Krittika constellation, which occupies a special place in the mythology of Lord Murugan. According to sacred narratives, the divine child born from the fiery energy of Lord Shiva was nurtured by the six Krittika maidens, with whom the name Kartikeya is traditionally associated. Over time, the Krittika star became closely associated with Murugan worship, particularly in South India, where monthly observances developed alongside temple traditions and devotional practices. The recurring appearance of the Krittika star each month came to be regarded as an auspicious occasion for renewing one's spiritual discipline, expressing gratitude and seeking strength to overcome obstacles.

This is why the cuisine of Masik Karthigai assumes civilisational significance even though there is no single rigid menu that every family follows each month. While Karthigai Deepam carries a larger and more elaborate culinary tradition, Masik Karthigai is inspired by the same devotional heritage in a quieter and simpler form. Some homes prepare only one offering, some add a small sweet, others include a light tiffin meal after worship, while a few prepare several dishes connected with Tamil festive cooking. What remains common is the intention. Food is freshly prepared, vegetarian, often sattvic, and offered first in prayer before being shared. As the evening approaches, the kitchen itself becomes an extension of the ceremony. Rice is washed, jaggery is melted, coconut is grated, ghee is warmed, lentils are soaked, sesame is roasted, curry leaves crackle in hot oil, and ordinary ingredients are transformed into nourishment rooted in inherited recipes.

Among the most loved offerings associated with the Karthigai tradition is pori urundai, a sweet made from puffed rice and jaggery syrup. Its beauty lies not only in its simplicity, but also in the skill required to prepare it well. Light and airy puffed rice is folded into dark, hot jaggery syrup and shaped quickly by hand before the mixture cools. It is a dish of timing, touch and inherited instinct, where an ordinary grain becomes a firm,



glossy and deeply satisfying round of prasadam. The syrup must reach the right consistency so that the balls retain their shape without becoming hard. Cardamom may be added, and in some homes small coconut pieces or roasted gram are mixed in for texture. Its presence near the lamp feels natural, since it is humble, golden, sweet and easy to distribute after worship.

Closely related to it are aval pori urundai and nel pori urundai, both of which reflect the agricultural imagination of Tamil homes. Aval pori urundai uses puffed flattened rice, while nel pori urundai uses puffed paddy, giving it a distinct texture and a deeper connection with harvest and grain. Alongside them, families often prepare kadalai urundai, made with roasted peanuts and jaggery, bringing nuttiness and strength, or ellu urundai, made with sesame seeds and jaggery, carrying the traditional association of sesame with purity and ritual offering. Together, these urundais show how a small handful of ingredients can become devotional food. They are not elaborate in appearance, yet they carry the warmth of the hand that shaped them and the memory of homes where such recipes are learnt by watching elders rather than by reading measurements.

The appam family gives Masik Karthigai another layer of sweetness. Nei appam, made with rice flour or soaked and ground rice, jaggery, banana, coconut and ghee, is soft at the centre and gently crisp at the edges when prepared in an appam pan. The ghee gives aroma, the banana gives body, and the jaggery lends depth rather than sharp sweetness. Sweet appam may be made in slightly different ways across households, sometimes with wheat flour, sometimes with rice flour, and sometimes with an added touch of cardamom or dry



ginger. Vellai appam, though milder and often less sweet, holds its own place in the wider Karthigai spread. In these appams, the fragrance of ghee, jaggery and rice flour fills the house even before the lamps are lit, making the act of cooking itself part of the evening's devotion.

Another cherished preparation is adhirasam, one of Tamil cuisine's most respected traditional sweets. Made from rice flour and jaggery, its preparation requires patience and experience. The rice is soaked, dried and powdered, the jaggery is melted into syrup of the desired consistency, and the dough is rested to give the sweet the right texture. When flattened and fried, adhirasam becomes dark, fragrant and slightly chewy, with a taste that belongs unmistakably to religious events, weddings and household festivals. It may not be made every month for Masik Karthigai, but when it appears, it brings the weight of tradition with it. A simpler but equally symbolic offering is maa vilakku maavu, a sweet flour mixture made from rice flour and jaggery, shaped into a lamp with a hollow centre. Ghee is poured into it, a cotton wick is placed within it, and the lamp is lit for prayer. In this striking preparation, food and flame become one. After worship, the sweetened flour is broken and shared as prasadam, turning the lamp itself into nourishment.

The sweet offerings are extended through payasam, paal payasam and sakkaraai pongal, each carrying a different mood of abundance. Payasam may be made with rice, moong dal, vermicelli or aval, simmered with milk or coconut milk, sweetened with sugar or jaggery, and finished with cardamom, cashews and raisins fried in ghee. Paal payasam is gentler, made with milk and rice slowly cooked until creamy, with sweetness kept soft and devotional. Sakkaraai pongal, prepared

with rice, moong dal, jaggery and ghee, is richer and more festive. The dal gives body, the jaggery gives warmth, and the ghee carries the aroma of cashews, raisins and cardamom through the dish. In the context of Masik Karthigai, these dishes remind us that sweetness in Indian ritual food is rarely only indulgence. It signifies auspiciousness, gratitude, and the wish that the household remain nourished in both body and spirit.

Yet the cuisine of the day should not be seen only through sweets. Savoury preparations are equally important, as prayer is often followed by an evening meal. Milagu adai is one of the most distinctive savoury dishes associated with Karthigai cooking. Made with rice, lentils, black pepper, cumin, curry leaves and sometimes coconut, it is thicker than dosa and more rustic in character. The pepper gives heat, the lentils provide strength, and the crisp edges contrast with the softer centre. It is often eaten with butter, jaggery, coconut chutney or a simple accompaniment. In a spread otherwise rich with jaggery, rice flour and ghee, milagu adai brings balance. Its peppery warmth gives the meal depth and reminds us that sacred food is not always soft or sweet. It can also be robust, grounding and deeply satisfying.

Other savoury dishes bring variety to the table. Thattai, a crisp rice flour snack seasoned with urad dal flour, sesame seeds, curry leaves, asafoetida and sometimes chana dal, is fried until golden and brittle. Its sharp crackle offers contrast to the softness of appam and the chewiness of adhirasam. Vadai, especially ulundu vadai, is also prepared in some homes as an offering or as part of the evening meal. Made from urad dal batter, shaped with a hole in the centre and fried until crisp outside and soft within, it carries the familiar taste of Tamil temple prasadam and household celebration. Sundal adds a healthier and simpler savoury note. Chickpeas, black chana, green gram or cowpeas are soaked, cooked and tempered with mustard seeds, curry leaves, asafoetida, green chilli and grated coconut. It is light, protein-rich and easy to offer, making it well suited to a monthly observance.

Rice preparations complete the meal in many households, especially when the family prefers a proper dinner after prayers. Ven pongal, made with rice and moong dal, tempered with black pepper, cumin, ginger, curry leaves, cashews and ghee, brings warmth and comfort. Lemon rice offers brightness through turmeric, lemon juice, mustard seeds, curry leaves, peanuts and chillies, while coconut rice brings a gentler flavour through fresh grated coconut, cashews, urad dal, chana dal and curry leaves. Curd rice, cooled with yogurt and tempered lightly with mustard, ginger and curry leaves, often becomes the final dish, calming the palate after sweets and fried snacks. These rice dishes show how the meal moves from offering to nourishment, from the sweetness of prasadam to the fulfilment of an everyday meal made special to honour the occasion.

To this repertoire are added dishes that sit comfortably between sacred offering and familiar Tamil home food. Puliodarai, or tamarind rice, may be prepared in some homes, carrying a deep tangy flavour created from tamarind, sesame oil, roasted spices, peanuts and curry leaves. Kozhukattai, though more strongly associated with Ganesha worship, may still appear in Tamil homes as a steamed rice flour dumpling

filled with coconut and jaggery or with a savoury lentil mixture, depending on family tradition. Paniyaram, made from fermented batter and cooked in small moulds, may be prepared sweet with jaggery or savoury with chillies and curry leaves, though onion is avoided in stricter ritual homes. Vella seedai, small jaggery-sweetened rice flour balls, and uppu seedai, their savoury counterpart, can also be part of the festive kitchen when families want crisp offerings that can be stored and shared. Through these dishes, Masik Karthigai becomes not a fixed menu but a living tradition that adapts to region, household memory and the degree of observance.

Beverages on such days are usually simple, cooling, warming or gently restorative. Panakam, made with jaggery, water, dry ginger, cardamom and sometimes lemon, is valued for its ability to refresh while retaining sacred simplicity. Neer mor, or spiced buttermilk, prepared with diluted curd, curry leaves, ginger, green chilli, asafoetida and coriander, balances the fried and sweet elements of the meal. In some homes, warm paal, or milk, may be offered and later served, especially to children and elders. Sukku coffee, made with dry ginger, black pepper, coriander seeds and palm jaggery, brings warmth to the body and is popular in Tamil households as a traditional digestive drink. The day may also end with South Indian filter coffee, not necessarily as a ritual beverage, but as part of Tamil hospitality, offered after the lamps have burned steadily and the family has gathered around the evening meal.

What makes the cuisine of Masik Karthigai meaningful is not the number of preparations alone, but the way each dish forms part of a larger discipline. Lamps are cleaned, wicks are prepared, rice flour is measured, jaggery is melted, and offerings are arranged with care before they are tasted. Children learn that food is not always consumed immediately, that it can first be offered to the divine in thanksgiving and gratitude. Elders remember recipes passed down through generations, and the act of sharing prasadam after prayer creates a bond between age groups. Taste becomes memory, and memory is transformed into living culture.

Masik Karthigai ultimately reminds us that heritage survives when it is practised, not merely remembered. The lamp may be small, the offering may be simple, and the meal may be prepared within the quiet space of a home, but together they carry the weight of an ancient cultural inheritance. Through pori urundai, adhirasam, maa vilakku maavu, milagu adai, sundal, ven pongal, payasam and the many dishes prepared with devotion, families pass on more than recipes. They pass on discipline, gratitude, faith, memory and identity through taste. It is my belief that these traditions must be consciously preserved by cooking them, explaining them and sharing them with the next generation. A child who tastes prasadam, watches a lamp being lit, and learns why food is first offered before it is eaten receives a living lesson in culture. If we wish our civilisational heritage to endure, we must keep it alive not only in temples and texts, but in kitchens, dining spaces and family conversations. Masik Karthigai calls upon us to preserve this sacred continuity, so that the light of devotion and the taste of tradition continue to guide generations yet to come.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Pamper the southern-side of your soul



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Atmanam's newest outpost at Galleria Market, Sector 28, Gurugram, arrives with quiet confidence, and rightfully so. Already beloved across its Sector 84 and Sector 65 locations, this pure vegetarian South Indian restaurant has earned its growing reputation one perfectly fermented batter at a time.

The name itself sets the tone. Drawn from Sanskrit and the Bhagavad Gita, Atmanam translates to "the self" or "the soul," and the restaurant wears this identity earnestly. Nothing here feels performative. The ambience is warm and unhurried, the kind of space that invites you to slow down, breathe, and actually taste your food.

And the food genuinely deserves that attention. The menu is a thoughtful celebration of South Indian classics, executed with care and technical respect. The Benne Dosas arrive crisp



WHETHER YOU'RE A
SOUTH INDIAN FOOD
PURIST OR SIMPLY
CRAVING SOMETHING
WHOLESAME AND HONEST,
ATMANAM IS WORTH IT



and buttery, their edges golden and irresistible. Mini Podidlis tossed in ghee are dangerously moreish, while the Dal Vada delivers a satisfying crunch that holds up beautifully against a cup of filter coffee. For something sweet, the Payasam is a gentle, fragrant finish that lingers pleasantly. What distinguishes Atmanam from the growing crowd of South Indian restaurants is its philosophical consistency. Naturally fermented batters, balanced spicing, and time-honoured cooking techniques aren't marketing language here — they're evident on the plate. There's a sincerity to the cooking that's increasingly rare. The restaurant's commitment to sustainability, including eco-friendly plates that convert to manure, adds another layer of intentionality to the experience.

Whether you're a South Indian food purist or simply craving something wholesome and honest, Atmanam at Galleria Market is worth your time.

Recommended dishes: Benne Dosa, Mini Podidli, Payasam.

FOOD TRIPPING BIHAR When a cuisine comes of age

TEAM AGENDA

Regional cuisine has always had a flair for the theatrical, but its latest venture, Food Tripping at Le Meridien New Delhi, elevates that instinct into something genuinely compelling. This exclusive pop-up dining series launched in May 2026 with an ambitious promise: to transform dinner into a cultural odyssey. Having followed the inaugural chapter closely, one can say the hotel largely delivers on that lofty ambition.

The concept is elegantly simple yet richly layered. Each chapter of the series is conceived as an intimate, reservation-only evening where food, music, visual art, and storytelling converge to evoke a specific place and its culinary soul. Rather than merely plating "regional cuisine," the team at Le Meridien has deliberately chosen

authentic voices - home chefs rooted in their native traditions - to anchor the Indian chapters, lending each menu a credibility that hotel dining rarely achieves.

The inaugural chapter, Soul of Bihar, ran in May at Eau de Monsoon, and it set a remarkably high bar. Curated in collaboration with Shacchi Anand, founder of Baghar-e-Magadh, the menu was a confident, deeply personal exploration of Bihar cuisine - a culinary tradition too often overlooked on the national fine-dining circuit. Ancestral recipes were presented with quiet elegance,

never losing their soul to unnecessary modernisation. Dishes arrived carrying layers of memory and regional identity, the kind of cooking that makes you pause mid-bite and reconsider your assumptions about

a cuisine.

What distinguishes Food Tripping from similar hotel pop-ups is its insistence on atmosphere as an equal partner to the food. Regional music drifted through the space, visual storytelling framed the walls, and the overall sensory design felt considered rather than decorative. You weren't merely eating Bihar food - you were, however briefly, inhabiting a version of Bihar itself. Meena Bhatia's vision for the series - that every flavour should carry a memory and every evening should feel like a journey — is no mere marketing language. The execution reflects genuine curatorial intent. That said, the true test of any dining series lies in its consistency across chapters. The format, however polished, must keep reinventing itself to sustain anticipation. With plans to span Indian regional cuisines alongside international editions, Food Tripping has real potential to become one of Delhi's most distinctive dining destinations. For now, on the strength of Soul of Bihar alone, it earns a warm thumbs up!



Why Does Beauty Make You Close Your Eyes

Love addresses the deepest human loneliness. The purpose of companionship is to rejoice and share life. It is to have someone you can truly depend on

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Think of the last time something totally made you stop in your tracks. It may have been music, a fragrance, or a texture. Something so great, so wonderful, and so beautiful that it automatically shut your eyes, and you sank into that ocean of beauty.

This is not something small or incidental. It is through the five senses that you experience something beyond the five senses. Deep inside you, what gets created in that moment is a wave of beauty. And when that wave arrives, you are not in form any more. You dissolve into the formless and come back to your nature.

The senses brought you to the door and then stepped aside. The power, the energy inside you, starts moving in a new direction. Like in meditation, there is a feeling of elevation that gives you more energy and long-lasting joy and bliss. Like in spring, the entire creation just comes alive. The birds sing, the trees blossom, and when energy is kindled in you, it creates awe. You spring out of dullness and routine, and new life springs up in you.

Behind every love, there is something greater, something total. We tend to think beauty is decoration and love is emotion. But what if both are pointing at something much larger than we have imagined? Behind every love, every small beauty and joy, there is the Divine. This is a revolutionary thought, a revolutionary idea.

Love, when it is genuine and full of energy, is total and complete. And this completeness expresses itself in stages, each one deeper than the last.

The first sign that love has arrived is that you cannot stop talking about it. Have you noticed when someone is crazy about something? They talk about it and talk about it, and it never tires them. No amount of praise feels sufficient. Just a mild interest cannot evoke such depth of expression. That is the first sign of divine love. One would go on praising continuously and still feel, “Oh, it’s not sufficient. I have to do it more, more, and more.”

The second sign is to express love in all forms. Although there is no form of divinity, the Divine loves to express itself in forms, and that is why millions and millions of forms are present in this creation. You deal with forms all your life, whether in the waking state or the dreaming state. Except for deep sleep and meditation, forms appear in your mind. And so, even while knowing that divinity is formless, a form makes it more interesting. The form kindles love in your heart.

Then love wants to honour and offer itself to whatever has kindled it. Whatever you appreciate or adore, you feel the urge to worship it. And worshipping is just the opposite of wanting to possess. When you try to possess something beautiful, you actually bring ugliness to it. Worship is offering yourself instead of reaching out to possess. A sense of giving, or offering oneself, is one of the truest expressions of love.

Then comes something subtler still, and that is memory. It is not that you make any effort to remember. As soon as you wake up, the first thought that comes is of the loved one, of the Divine. You do not make any effort to think about that person. But the thought



“LOVE IS A HAPPENING. LOVE IS A GIFT TO YOU. DO NOT GO OUT SEEKING LOVE. SIMPLY RELAX AND BE AT EASE” – GURUDEV



BEHIND EVERY LOVE, THERE IS SOMETHING GREATER, SOMETHING TOTAL. WE TEND TO THINK BEAUTY IS DECORATION AND LOVE IS EMOTION. BUT WHAT IF BOTH ARE POINTING AT SOMETHING MUCH LARGER THAN WE HAVE IMAGINED? BEHIND EVERY LOVE, EVERY SMALL BEAUTY AND JOY, THERE IS THE DIVINE. THIS IS A REVOLUTIONARY THOUGHT, A REVOLUTIONARY IDEA

constantly comes, and you find yourself remembering. You go deeper and deeper into the silence within you. That very remembrance becomes meditation.

And then love deepens into something that most people find surprising. One form of the expression of love is great humility and service as one’s very nature. There is not even a thought of, “I am doing some service.” You cannot help but serve. Even if one tries to abstain from it, it does not happen. One finds oneself back in it. Love gets expressed as service.

Here is where something remarkable happens. Do you know what actually

brings authority? A caretaker, a servant, has full authority in the home. If the master is away, he acts as the master. A perfect servant or disciple has total authority and total responsibility. A servant is one in whom the master has bestowed his trust. Being a servant means acknowledging that the Divine has given you this task and that it belongs to you.

Love expresses itself as friendship. Towards someone who is your superior, you may have a lot of respect. But there may not be any love. You may honour them, but your heart may not start speaking. In such cases, the Master will say, “Come on, what is it? What is the matter? How are you doing? What is happening?” That is love expressed in the form of a friend, where wisdom is shared not in a serious manner but in a playful one.

Love addresses the deepest human loneliness. The purpose of companionship is to rejoice and share life. It is to have someone you can truly depend on. But human relationships keep changing. The Divine is the only truly dependable relationship, never changing and total. When the Divine becomes the companion you turn to, you become more centred. Otherwise, you keep hanging on to whoever happens to be near. Love at this depth becomes your anchor.

And then there is the supreme form, and that is longing. Not the frustration of longing, but the strange beauty that longing carries. Longing gives you the power to bless. The very longing in you is itself a form of love. As the longing grows more and more intense, it flips over. It becomes bliss, and you become totally immersed. Many have experienced intense longing and reached that turning point. At some point, that longing itself becomes a joy.

The fire of love creates a sense of longing in the beginning. But it moves on to the blossoming of bliss and fullness. This longing should never end. If longing ends, love also ends. That is why longing and love are infinite.

Love is a happening. Love is a gift to you. Do not go out seeking love. Simply relax and be at ease. Only when you are free from tension, free from confusion, can you truly experience love.

When Leaders Become Pilgrims

Across the years, presidents, prime ministers and distinguished leaders from across the world have been drawn to Swaminarayan Akshardham. Beyond its awe-inspiring architecture lies a deeper attraction: a timeless vision of peace, spirituality and universal values that continues to inspire visitors from around the world



DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

In ancient India, the sages spoke of sacred spaces where the mind finds peace, the heart awakens to higher ideals, and the soul glimpses the divine. Such places stand as living bridges between earth and eternity, inspiring generations through their beauty, wisdom and spiritual presence.

Today, that timeless divinity finds magnificent expression in Swaminarayan Akshardham in New Delhi, a landmark that has captivated millions of visitors, including presidents, prime ministers, diplomats and dignitaries from across the world.

September 2023 was one of the most consequential moments in India’s recent diplomatic history. New Delhi had become the centre of the world’s attention as heads of state, presidents and prime ministers from across the globe gathered for the G20 Summit. Every minute of their schedules was meticulously planned. Every movement was watched. Every engagement carried diplomatic significance.

Yet amid the intensity of global discussions and high-level negotiations, one destination found a place on the itinerary of the United Kingdom’s Prime Minister, Rishi Sunak, and his wife, Akshata Murty. It was neither a government building nor a state banquet, but a mandir.

Despite the demanding schedule of the summit and the persistent rain, Prime Minister Sunak and Mrs Murty chose to walk barefoot along the 150-metre

pathway leading towards the mandir. To everybody’s surprise, one of the world’s most powerful political leaders, accustomed to red carpets and official ceremonies, walked humbly upon the rain-soaked pathway as a devotee.

It was not an act of protocol. It was an expression of faith and devotion. As the magnificent stone mandir gradually emerged before them, its intricately carved pinnacles rising against the cloudy sky, the atmosphere seemed to shift. The noise of politics gave way to serenity. The urgency of international affairs yielded to a sense of peace.

Within the sacred precincts of Akshardham, the Prime Minister and his wife offered prayers, performed puja and had darshan. For a brief period, they were not global figures carrying immense responsibilities; they were simply pilgrims standing before the Divine.

In this way, leaders arriving at Akshardham as distinguished statesmen leave touched by something deeper than its architectural splendour. The mandir’s rare ability to blend timeless spirituality with universal human values has resonated with visitors from across the world.

Across the Atlantic, American leaders, too, have been deeply moved by the Akshardham experience. US Vice President JD Vance’s visit to Akshardham in April 2025 revealed once again the temple’s extraordinary ability to touch hearts beyond borders. Accompanied by his wife, Usha Vance, the first Hindu Second Lady of the United States, and their children, Vance began his India visit in the serene precincts of Akshardham. As the family stood before the mandir’s majestic façade, dressed in traditional Indian attire, they appeared deeply immersed in its beauty and spiritual atmosphere.

Most recently, on 29 May 2026, Tiffany Trump, daughter of US President Donald Trump, visited Akshardham along with her husband, businessman Michael Boullos, and close friends. Their visit further reflected

Akshardham’s growing appeal among prominent American public figures and dignitaries. Amid a period marked by global uncertainty, conflict and war, Tiffany chose to begin her private visit to India with a journey into the heart of the nation’s spiritual and cultural heritage. As she explored the world-renowned monument’s breathtaking architecture, timeless artistry and profound spiritual message, her visit carried a significance beyond tourism.

Deeply moved by the experience, Tiffany Trump penned a heartfelt note in the temple’s guest book: “This was such an amazing visit. The beauty is out of this world. Thank you for such a perfect visit!”

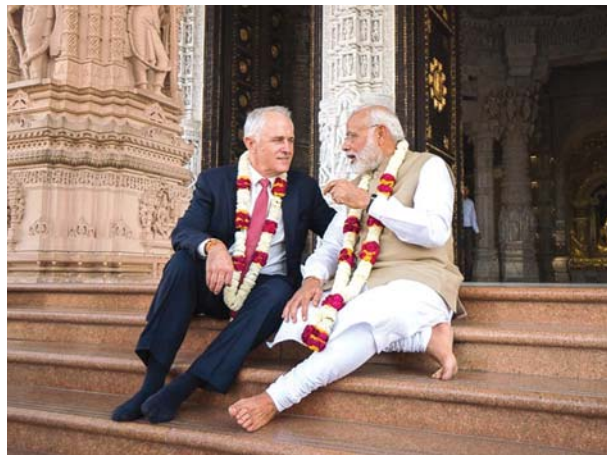
She later shared her admiration with millions of followers on social media, describing her experience at Akshardham simply as “incredible.”

Thus, from Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, and from New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon to Croatian Prime Minister Andrej Plenkovic, Akshardham’s appeal continues to transcend nations and cultures.

During his second visit to Akshardham, President Kalam remarked, “I saw the movie of Bhagwan Swaminarayan in the exhibition. So beautiful. What a creation! What a creation! I believe Akshardham is really going to make a great influence on human life. Not only in India, but whoever sees it, it is going to have an impact on human life. How a good human life will emanate from Akshardham. That is my belief.”

This was the vision of Brahmaswarup Pramukh Swami Maharaj, the creator and inspirer of Akshardham. He dreamed of a place where people from every background would encounter the best of Indian culture, faith and love, and leave inspired to become better human beings. Today, as world leaders, dignitaries and millions of visitors continue to walk through its sacred precincts, that vision stands beautifully fulfilled, transforming admiration into inspiration and visitors into ambassadors of universal values.

(The writer Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)



Weekly Overview

The week begins under the Aquarius Moon, encouraging observation, planning and a wider perspective. As the Moon moves into Pisces, emotions, intuition and inner reflection become stronger. By the weekend, Aries energy brings fresh momentum, quicker decisions and a desire to move forward.



Aries (Mesh): The opening days may encourage you to step back from situations that have been demanding too much attention. Not every matter requires an immediate response. As the week progresses, you may find yourself reflecting more deeply on unfinished concerns or delayed decisions. By the weekend, the Moon enters Aries, bringing renewed energy and a stronger desire to act. This is a good time to restart something that has lost momentum, but avoid rushing simply because enthusiasm has returned.



Taurus (Vrishabh): Group activities, professional networks or discussions with like-minded people may play a bigger role early in the week. Some useful advice could come from an unexpected source. Midweek may feel quieter, with attention turning toward personal hopes, emotional expectations or long-term plans. By the weekend, you may prefer reflection over visibility. Trust your pace rather than comparing your progress with that of others.



Gemini (Mithun): Responsibilities may demand attention from the very beginning of the week. While others may appear uncertain, your ability to adapt can become an advantage. Midweek encourages a softer approach, especially in professional interactions where diplomacy may achieve more than argument. As the weekend approaches, fresh

WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST | 7-13 JUNE

Quiet Reflections, New Perspectives and a Fresh Push Forward

Dr Shanker Adawal
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.

opportunities for discussion, networking or future planning may begin to emerge. Remain open to different view points.



Cancer (Karka): The week begins with a desire to understand the bigger picture rather than focusing only on immediate concerns. Travel plans, learning opportunities or meaningful conversations may attract attention. Midweek brings a more emotional atmosphere, and intuition becomes a useful guide. Family matters or personal relationships may require patience. By the weekend, practical responsibilities return to the forefront, making organisation more important than mood.



Leo (Simha): Some situations may require deeper understanding before you decide how to proceed. The early part of the week supports observation rather than direct action. Midweek may bring stronger emotional awareness, helping you recognise what truly matters and what can be left behind.

By the weekend, confidence gradually returns and communication becomes more direct. A thoughtful decision made now may carry more value than a quick reaction earlier in the week.

Virgo (Kanya): Relationships and partnerships may occupy your attention during the opening phase of the week.



Listening carefully will be just as important as expressing your own views. Midweek brings emotional depth and greater sensitivity to the needs of others. Some matters may require compromise rather than analysis. By the weekend, financial planning or practical decisions become easier to handle. Focus on what is workable rather than what is perfect.



Libra (Tula): Routine matters, work responsibilities and daily commitments may shape the first half of the week. A practical approach will help prevent small issues from becoming larger ones. Midweek encourages greater emotional awareness, especially in close relationships where understanding may be needed more than advice. By the weekend, the Moon’s movement into Aries places attention on partnerships and interactions. Patience will help maintain harmony.



Scorpio (Vrishchik): The week opens on a comparatively lighter note, encouraging creativity, personal interests and meaningful conversations. Midweek, however, emotions may run deeper than expected, particularly where personal attachments are involved. This is not a negative phase, but it may encourage reflection. By the weekend, attention turns toward practical matters, health routines or unfinished responsibilities. Small improvements can produce noticeable results.



Sagittarius (Dhanu): Home, family matters or personal comfort may become important themes during the opening days. There may be a desire to simplify things rather than chase constant activity. Midweek brings a reflective

mood, making it easier to understand emotional patterns that have been repeating themselves. By the weekend, energy improves considerably, supporting creativity, social interaction and fresh enthusiasm. Use that momentum wisely.



Capricorn (Makar): Communication becomes a key theme at the beginning of the week. Discussions, paperwork or short-term plans may move faster than expected. Midweek encourages a more thoughtful pace, and important information could emerge through casual conversations. By the weekend, attention shifts toward home matters, family responsibilities or personal priorities. Practical decisions taken now may prove useful over the coming weeks.



Aquarius (Kumbh): With the Moon beginning the week in Aquarius, there is an opportunity to view situations with greater objectivity. Others may seek your advice or perspective. Midweek shifts focus toward financial matters, personal values and emotional security. Some decisions may require patience rather than immediate action. By the weekend, communication improves and confidence grows. Expressing your thoughts clearly will help avoid unnecessary misunderstandings.



Pisces (Meen): The opening phase of the week may feel quieter than usual, encouraging observation and inner reflection. Once the Moon enters Pisces, intuition becomes stronger and emotional awareness deepens. This is a good period for understanding motivations, both your own and those of others. By the weekend, practical matters, finances and future planning require attention. Trust your instincts, but support them with realistic action.